HT BENGALURU

Tuesday, October 27, 2026

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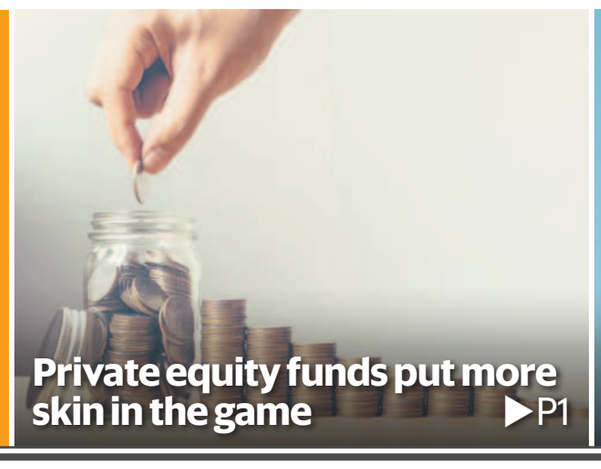

Private equity funds put more skin in the game ▶P1

Noel wants Chandra choice deleted from records ▶P1

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NOT FOR RELEASE, PUBLICATION OR DISTRIBUTION DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY, OUTSIDE INDIA.
INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF EQUITY SHARES ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE LIMITED ("BSE") AND NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED ("NSE", AND TOGETHER WITH BSE, THE "STOCK EXCHANGES") IN COMPLIANCE WITH CHAPTER II OF THE SECURITIES AND EXCHANGE BOARD OF INDIA (ISSUE OF CAPITAL AND DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS) REGULATIONS, 2018, AS AMENDED ("SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS").

(Please scan this QR Code to view the Red Herring Prospectus and the Abridged Prospectus)

Edelweiss ALTERNATIVES

EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED

(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Our Company was originally incorporated as "Edelweiss Alternative Asset Advisors Limited" at Mumbai, Maharashtra as a limited company under the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated May 14, 2008, issued by the Registrar of Companies, Maharashtra at Mumbai and commenced its business pursuant to certificate of commencement of business dated May 22, 2008. Subsequently, the name of our Company was changed to "EAAA India Alternatives Limited" to align the name with the business of our Company and a certificate of incorporation dated August 30, 2024, was issued by the Office of the Central Processing Center, Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Gurgaon, Haryana. For details of the change in the name of our Company, see ***"History and Certain Corporate Matters"*** on page 270 of the red herring prospectus dated October 19, 2026 (**"RHP"**) filed with the Registrar of Companies, Mumbai-I at Mumbai (**"RoC"**).

Corporate Identification Number: U67190MH2008PLC182205; **Registered Office:** Edelweiss House, Off C.S.T Road, Mumbai City, Kalina, Mumbai 400 098, Maharashtra, India; **Contact Person:** Deepak Mukhija, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; **Tel:** +91 22 4019 4706; **E-mail:** ipo@eaaa.in; **Website:** www.eaaa.in

OUR PROMOTERS: EDELWEISS FINANCIAL SERVICES LIMITED, EDELWEISS SECURITIES AND INVESTMENTS PRIVATE LIMITED, EDEL FINANCE COMPANY LIMITED AND EDELWEISS GLOBAL WEALTH MANAGEMENT LIMITED

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING OF [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH (THE "EQUITY SHARES") OF EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED (THE "COMPANY" OR "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE (THE "OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹12,000 MILLION (THE "OFFER") COMPRISING AN OFFER FOR SALE OF [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 AGGREGATING UP TO ₹12,000 MILLION BY EDELWEISS SECURITIES AND INVESTMENTS PRIVATE LIMITED (THE "PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER", AND SUCH OFFER FOR SALE, THE "OFFER FOR SALE", AND SUCH EQUITY SHARES, THE "OFFERED SHARES"). THE OFFER SHALL CONSTITUTE [•] % OF THE POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

DETAILS OF THE OFFER FOR SALE			
NAME OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER	TYPE	NUMBER OF EQUITY SHARES OFFERED/ AMOUNT	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION PER EQUITY SHARE (IN ₹)^
Edelweiss Securities and Investments Private Limited	Promoter Selling Shareholder	[●] Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each aggregating up to ₹12,000 million	54.45

^As certified by NGS & Co. LLP., Chartered Accountants (FRN: 119850W/W100013), by way of their certificate dated October 20, 2026.

PRICE BAND: ₹1,585 TO ₹1,665 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH.
THE FLOOR PRICE IS 317 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND THE CAP PRICE IS 333 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.
BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 9 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 9 EQUITY SHARES THEREAFTER.
THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FISCAL 2026 AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 39.27 TIMES AND AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 41.25 TIMES AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 39.89 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026.
WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NET WORTH FOR LAST THREE FISCALS 2026, 2025 AND 2024 IS 26.57% AND FOR THREE MONTHS PERIOD ENDED JUNE 30, 2026 IS 28.96% *(annualised)*.

The details of the Offer for Sale, Total Offer Size and the post Offer market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹1,585 per Equity Share		At Cap Price of ₹1,665 per Equity Share	
	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value ₹5 each	Up to Amount (₹ million)	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value ₹5 each	Up to Amount (₹ million)
Offer for Sale	7,570,977	12,000.00	7,207,207	12,000.00
Post-Offer market capitalization of the Company (₹ million)	102,478.56		107,650.98	

BID/OFFER PERIOD

BID/OFFER OPEN

BID/OFFER CLOSES ON: WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 28, 2026#

 # UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5.00 p.m. on the Bid/Offer Closing Date.

We are an alternatives platform in India with more than 17 years of experience *(Source: Care Report)* of managing long term patient capital with an AUM of ₹953,448.78 million, as of June 30, 2026. Our wholly owned subsidiary, Sekura India Management Limited ("Sekura"), is part of our asset operating and management team and proficiently supports our various business verticals, including operations, maintenance, monitoring, efficiency improvement, and turnaround management. We are an experienced player, catering to a diverse client base of global and domestic institutional clients and manage India focused funds across our business verticals.

The Offer is being made through the book building process in accordance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations.
The Equity Shares of the Company will get listed on the main boards of BSE Limited ("BSE") and National Stock Exchange of India Limited ("NSE").
NSE shall be the designated Stock Exchange.
• QIB Portion: Not more than 50% of the Offer • Non-institutional Portion: Not less than 15% of the Offer • Retail Individual Portion: Not less than 35% of the Offer

In making an investment decision, potential investors must rely only on the information included in the RHP and the terms of the Offer, including the risks involved and not rely on any other external sources of information about the Offer available in any manner. In relation to price band, potential investors should only refer to the pre-Offer and Price Band advertisement dated October 20, 2026 ("Price Band Advertisement") for the Offer and should not rely on any media articles/ reports in relation to the valuation of the company as these are not endorsed, published or confirmed either by the company or the book running lead managers to the Offer ("BRLMs").

In accordance with the recommendation of the committee of independent directors of our Company, pursuant to their resolution dated October 20, 2026, the above provided Price Band is justified based on quantitative factors/ key performance indicators ("KPIs") disclosed in the *"Basis for Offer Price"* section beginning from page 140 of the RHP vis-a-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA") of primary and secondary transaction(s), as applicable, as disclosed in the *"Basis for Offer Price"* section beginning on page 140 of the RHP and provided below in the Price Band Advertisement.

Risk to Investors
For details, refer to section titled *"Risk Factors"* on page 20 of the RHP.

1. **Dependence of our Total Income on the Variable Additional Return:**
   Our Variable Additional Return constitutes 32.41%, 27.54%, 30.14%, 24.25% and 16.19% of our Total Income for the three months period ended June 30, 2026, June 30, 2025 and Financial Years 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Further, the realized Variable Additional Return may be different from our Variable Additional Return recognized on a year-on-year basis and the timing and receipt of Variable Additional Return are unpredictable and contribute to volatility in our cash flows.
2. **Dependence of our Total Income on the Management and Advisory Fees:**
   A significant portion of Total Income comes from our Management and Advisory Fees. There is a risk that it may fluctuate depending on the performance of our funds, changes in fee structure, competition and market conditions which may consequently affect our Total Income.
3. **Historical growth rates may not be indicative of the future growth:**
   Our business growth depends on, among other things, our ability to retain client trust, our ability to deal with changing market conditions, such as developing new investment products, maintaining and extending our distribution capabilities, and complying with new regulations. Any failure in managing our growth could affect our AUM and/or FPAUM, or damage our brand or reputation, which could result in a reversal of any growth that is achieved.
4. **Risk related to valuation methodologies**
   Most of the investments of our funds are illiquid and thus may have no readily ascertainable market prices. We value these investments based on our estimate, or an independent third party's estimate, of their fair value as of the date of determination, which often involves significant subjectivity.
5. **Lack of directly comparable Indian listed peers**
   The absence of directly comparable Indian listed peers may present challenges in terms of how investors perceive and value our Company. The lack of comparable companies in the domestic market can create uncertainty and variability in the assessment of our financial performance, growth prospects, and overall business value.
6. **Risk related to the capital commitment**
   Our funds are dependent on our clients honoring their capital calls for disbursements to enable our funds to make investments and cover fund expenses. However, these capital calls may not be honored due to several factors, which in turn can adversely affect the operations and performance of our funds. Any failure to timely secure capital commitment in future, if arisen, may compel us to divest assets under suboptimal conditions, adversely impacting investment returns and fund performance.
7. **Risk related to the regulatory and statutory restrictions**
   Our Group Companies and Promoters are subject to purview of various authorities such as SEBI, RBI and tax authorities which may result in financial penalties, additional compliances and regulatory restrictions.
8. **Risk related to the negative cash flows**
   We have experienced negative cash flows in the past and prolonged negative cash flow could adversely affect our financial condition and business operations including delays in implementing strategic initiatives or expansion plans. The following table sets forth certain financial information

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for the periods indicated:

(in ₹ million)

Particulars	Three months period ended June 30,*		For the Financial Year ended*		
	2026	2025	2026	2025	2024
Net cash (used in) / generated from operating activities	1,303.84	1,456.81	2,352.44	(1,201.69)	(132.70)
Net cash (used in) / generated from investment activities	(119.64)	(180.50)	1,117.01	878.11	(1,526.40)
Net cash generated from / (used in) financing activities	(550.39)	(291.57)	(3,440.59)	75.95	1,780.44

**The financial details are in agreement with the Restated Consolidated Financial Information for the three months period ended June 30, 2026, June 30, 2025, Financial Years 2026, 2025 and 2024.*

9. Unpredictable Variable Additional Return

The timing and receipt of Variable Additional Return (net of Variable Additional Return related cost) from the funds we manage and advise are inherently unpredictable and contribute to the volatility of our cash flows. Given below is our Net Variable Additional Return for the periods indicated:

(in ₹ million)

Particulars	Three months period ended June 30,		For the Financial Year ended			Total accrued[2]
	2026	2025	2026	2025	2024	
Variable Additional Return [1] **(A)**	1,089.53	582.98	2,904.72	1,907.29	945.66	6,847.20
Variable Additional Return related cost **(B)**	825.03	131.52	1,610.87	1,311.31	841.62	4,588.83
Net Variable Additional Return **(C=A-B)**	264.50	451.46	1,293.85	595.98	104.04	2,258.37

Note:

(1) Variable Additional Return is the additional variable return to the Company and its Subsidiaries once the fund has achieved the hurdle rate of return for its investors based on NAV and/or Realisation, shown as other operating revenues in Restated Consolidated Financial Information. The recognition of Variable Additional Return is guided by the waterfall distribution mechanism specified in the respective fund documentation and as per Company and its Subsidiaries' policies.

(2) Total accrued is for the period from April,1 2023 till June 30, 2026.

10. Risk related to distributors or placement agents

More than 33.75% of the funds raised from domestic investors in three months period ended June 30, 2026 were raised through distributors. Mismanagement in handling our relationships with distributors or placement agents could have a negative impact on our business, financial condition, and results of operations.

11. Offer-related Risk:

We will not receive any proceeds from the Offer for Sale, aggregating up to ₹12,000 million and the proceeds from the Offer for Sale will be transferred to the Promoter Selling Shareholder.

12. The Price/Earnings ratio based on diluted EPS for Fiscal 2026 for the Company at the upper end of the Price band is as high as 41.25 as compared to the average industry peer group PE ratio of 39.89.

13. Weighted Average Return on Net Worth for Financial Year ended 2026, 2025 and 2024 is 26.57%.

14. Weighted average cost of acquisition of all shares transacted in the last one year, eighteen months and three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus:

The details of weighted average cost of acquisition of all Equity Shares transacted in the last one year, eighteen months, and three years by the Promoters (including the Promoter Selling Shareholder) and members of the Promoter Group preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus is as follows:

Period	Number of Equity Shares transacted of face value ₹5 each	Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition per Equity Share of face value of ₹5 each (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'X' times the Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition	Range of acquisition price: Lowest Price – Highest Price (in ₹)
Last one year	Nil	NA	NA	Nil
Last eighteen months	6,363,744	925.00	1.80	925.00
Last three years*	52,258,260*	184.02*	9.05	51.84* - 925.00

As certified by NGS & Co. LLP., Chartered Accountants (FRN: 119850W/W100013), by way of their certificate dated October 20, 2026.

** Pursuant to the resolution of the Board dated August 9, 2024, and the resolution of Shareholders dated August 16, 2024, each equity share of face value ₹10 each was subdivided into 2 (two) Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each. The number of equity shares held and average cost of acquisition per equity share shown in the table above has been adjusted to give effect to such sub-division.*

15. The 4 BRLMs associated with the Offer have handled 114 public Issues in the past three financial years, out of which 30 Issues closed below the offer price on listing date:

Name of the BRLMs	Total Issues	Issues closed below IPO Price on listing date
Axis Capital Limited*	35	7
Jefferies India Private Limited*	9	3
Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited*	21	6
Nuvama Wealth Management Limited*	15	7
Common issues of above BRLMs	34	7
Total	**114**	**30**

**Issues handled where there were no common BRLMs*

Additional Information for Investors

1. Our Company has not undertaken pre-IPO placement from the date of the DRHP till date.
2. **Transaction of shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company by the Promoter(s) and members of the Promoter Group:**

The details of transaction of shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company by Promoter(s) and members of the Promoter Group from the DRHP filing date is set forth below:

Sr. No.	Date of Transfer	Name of transferor	Name of transferee	Whether connected with the Company, Promoters, members of Promoter Group, Directors, KMPs and Subsidiaries and Group Companies and the directors and key managerial personnel of the Subsidiaries and Group Companies	Nature of Transfer	Nature of consideration	Face value per Equity Share (₹)	Number of Equity Shares transferred	Transfer price per Equity Share (₹)	Total consideration (in ₹)	% of pre-Offer Equity Share capital
1	March 6, 2026	Edelweiss Investment Adviser Limited	Goyal Mg Gases Private Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	300,000	1,322	396,600,000	0.46
2			Madhu Silica Pvt. Ltd	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	300,000	1,322	396,600,000	0.46
3			Vikas Vijaykumar Khemani	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	300,000	1,322	396,600,000	0.46
4			Malpani Retails Private Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	185,000	1,322	244,570,000	0.29
5			Ashutosh Joshi	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	185,000	1,322	244,570,000	0.29
6			Ananta Capital Ventures Fund 1	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	150,000	1,322	198,300,000	0.23
7			B Arunkumar Capital & Credit Services Pvt Ltd.	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	150,000	1,322	198,300,000	0.23
8			Prachi Exports	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	110,000	1,322	145,420,000	0.17
9			Pranabh Mody	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
10			Naresh Shah	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
11			Cosmo First Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
12			Clear River Advisory LLP	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
13			Shri Bajrang Power & Ispat Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
14			Bhishma Realty Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
15			Rameshbhai Vinaychand Shah	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	75,000	1,322	99,150,000	0.12
16			Suresh Shetty HUF	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	50,000	1,322	66,100,000	0.08
17			Emerging Securities Pvt Ltd.	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	50,000	1,322	66,100,000	0.08
18			Swiss Exports LLP	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
19			Oceanic Pharmachem Private Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
20			Harsh Pati Singhania	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
21			Sajive Jain	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
22			Rupendra Periwal	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
23			Dixit Aswin Joshi	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
24			Solaris Chemtech Industries Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
25			Swyom India Alpha Fund	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
26			Altruist Technologies PVT LTD.	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
27			Vimal Labhubhai Lakhani	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	35,000	1,322	46,270,000	0.05
28			Prashant Ranjit	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	25,000	1,322	33,050,000	0.04
29			Bigopp Solvisory LLP	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	25,000	1,322	33,050,000	0.04
30			Patnaik Enterprises LLP	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	20,000	1,322	26,440,000	0.03
31			Kishori Investments Private Limited	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	20,000	1,322	26,440,000	0.03
32			Shree Dayal Family Trust	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	20,000	1,322	26,440,000	0.03
33			Umesh Kedia	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	20,000	1,322	26,440,000	0.03
34			Shravan Devakinandan Agarwal	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	20,000	1,322	26,440,000	0.03
35			Jay Vinod Chheda	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	17,500	1,322	23,135,000	0.03
36			Vinod Bhavanji Chheda	No	Secondary transfer	Cash	5.00	17,500	1,322	23,135,000	0.03
	Total							**2,840,000**		**3,754,480,000**	**4.39**

3. The aggregate pre-Offer and post-Offer shareholding of the Promoters, members of Promoter Group, additional top 10 Shareholders (apart from our Promoters and members of the Promoter Group) is set forth below:

Shareholders	Pre-Offer shareholding as on the date of the Red Herring Prospectus		Post-Offer shareholding as at Allotment*			
			At the lower end of the Price Band (₹1,585)		At the upper end of the Price Band (₹1,665)	
	No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	% of pre-Offer Equity Share capital	No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	% of post-Offer Equity Share capital	No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	% of post-Offer Equity Share capital
Promoters						
ESIPL[$^]	57,916,502	89.58	50,345,525	77.87	50,709,295	78.43
Total (A)	**57,916,502**	**89.58**	**50,345,525**	**77.87**	**50,709,295**	**78.43**
Member of Promoter Group (who hold Equity Shares)						
Edelweiss Rural & Corporate Services Limited	3,214,012	4.97	3,214,012	4.97	3,214,012	4.97
Edelweiss Investment Adviser Limited	309,732	0.48	309,732	0.48	309,732	0.48
Total (B)	**3,523,744**	**5.45**	**3,523,744**	**5.45**	**3,523,744**	**5.45**
Public Shareholders (top 10 Shareholders)						
Amit Agarwal	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46
Goyal Mg Gases Private Limited	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46
Madhu Silica Pvt. Ltd	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46

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Shareholders	Pre-Offer shareholding as on the date of the Red Herring Prospectus		Post-Offer shareholding as at Allotment*			
			At the lower end of the Price Band (₹1,585)		At the upper end of the Price Band (₹1,665)	
	No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	% of pre-Offer Equity Share capital	No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	% of post-Offer Equity Share capital	No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	% of post-Offer Equity Share capital
Vikas Vijaykumar Khemani	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46	300,000	0.46
Malpani Retails Private Limited	185,000	0.29	185,000	0.29	185,000	0.29
Ashutosh Joshi	185,000	0.29	185,000	0.29	185,000	0.29
Ananta Capital Ventures Fund 1	150,000	0.23	150,000	0.23	150,000	0.23
B Arunkumar Capital & Credit Services Pvt Ltd	150,000	0.23	150,000	0.23	150,000	0.23
Deepak Khimji Chheda	110,000	0.17	110,000	0.17	110,000	0.17
Harish Agarwal	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Pranabh Mody	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Naresh Shah	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Cosmo First Limited	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Clear River Advisory LLP	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Shri Bajrang Power & Ispat Limited	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Bhishma Realty Limited	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Rameshbhai Vinaychand Shah	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12	75,000	0.12
Total (C)	**2,580,000**	**4.01**	**2,580,000**	**4.01**	**2,580,000**	**4.01**
Other public Shareholders						
- (D)**	**635,000**	**0.96**	**8,205,977**	**12.69**	**7,842,207**	**12.13**
Total (E= A+B+C+D)	**64,655,246**	**100.00**	**64,655,246**	**100.00**	**64,655,246**	**100.00**

$ *Also, the Promoter Selling Shareholder.*

**Assuming full subscription in the Offer. The post-Offer shareholding details as at Allotment will be based on the actual subscription and will be updated in the Prospectus, subject to finalization of the Basis of Allotment. Also, this table assumes there is no transfer of Equity Shares by these shareholders between the date of the Price Band Advertisement and Allotment (if any such transfers occur prior to the date of Prospectus, it will be updated in the shareholding pattern in the Prospectus).*

^ Including 2 Equity Shares each held by Vinit Agrawal, Hemal Mehta, Deepak Mukhija and Bhanudas Jadhav (as first holders) on behalf of and as nominees of ESIPL and jointly with ESIPL.

*** As on the date of the Price Band Advertisement, our Company has 56 Shareholders out of which 32 Shareholders are categorised as other public Shareholders (D) in the table above.*

BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE

The *"Basis for Offer Price"* on page 140 of the RHP has been updated for the details of the price band. Please refer to the websites of the BRLMs: www.axiscapital.co.in, www. jefferies.com, www.motilaloswal.com and www.nuvama.com for the *"Basis for Offer Price"* updated with the above price band.
You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of Axis Capital Limited.

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors):

Bid/ Offer Period (except the Bid/ Offer Closing Date)	
Submission and Revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST
Bid/ Offer Closing Date	
Submission of electronic applications (online ASBA through 3 in 1 accounts) for RIIs	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Bank ASBA through online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and Syndicate UPI ASBA applications through UPI as a payment mechanism where Bid Amount is up to ₹500,000)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 4.00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual Applications)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 3.00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 1.00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual Applications of QIBs and NIIs where Bid Amount is more than ₹500,000)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 12.00 p.m. IST
Modification/ Revision/cancellation of Bids	
Upward revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors#	Only between 10.00 a.m. on the Bid/ Offer Opening Date and up to 4.00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date
Upward or downward revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIIs	Only between 10.00 a.m. on the Bid/ Offer Opening Date and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date

#QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors could neither revise their Bids downwards nor cancel/ withdraw their Bids.

On the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bids shall be uploaded until:

(i) 4.00 p.m. IST in case of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors; and

(ii) until 5.00 p.m. IST or such extended time as permitted by the Stock Exchanges, in case of Bids by Retail Individual Investors.

(iii) On Bid/Offer Closing Date, extension of time may be granted by Stock Exchanges only for uploading Bids received by Retail Individual Investors after taking into account the total number of Bids received up to closure of timings for acceptance of Bid cum Application Forms as stated herein and as reported by the BRLMs to the Stock Exchanges.

Bid/Offer Period	
BID/OFFER OPENS ON*	**Monday, October 26, 2026**
BID/OFFER CLOSES ON#	**Wednesday, October 28, 2026**

**In accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, the Anchor Investor Bidding Date shall be one Working Day prior to the Bid/Offer Opening Date, i.e., Friday, October 23, 2026*

 # UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5.00 p.m. on the Bid/Offer Closing Date, i.e. Wednesday, October 28, 2026.

An indicative timetable in respect of the Offer is set out below:

FINALISATION OF BASIS OF ALLOTMENT WITH THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE	On or about Thursday, October 29, 2026
INITIATION OF REFUNDS FOR ANCHOR INVESTORS/ UNBLOCKING OF FUNDS FROM ASBA ACCOUNT*	On or about Friday, October 30, 2026
CREDIT OF EQUITY SHARES TO DEMAT ACCOUNTS OF ALLOTTEES	On or about Friday, October 30, 2026
COMMENCEMENT OF TRADING OF THE EQUITY SHARES ON THE STOCK EXCHANGES	On or about Monday, November 2, 2026

In case of any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date for cancelled/withdrawn/deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated by the intermediary responsible for causing such delay in unblocking at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher in accordance with applicable law. For (i) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such multiple amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock,; (ii) any blocking of amounts more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iii) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted/ partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking, in accordance with applicable law. The Bidders shall be compensated in the manner specified in the SEBI ICDR Master Circular, in case of delays in resolving investor grievances in relation to blocking/ unblocking of funds, which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of our Company with the SCSBs, to the extent applicable. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking.

The processing fees for applications made by the UPI Bidders using the UPI Mechanism may be released to the remitter banks (SCSBs) only after such banks provide a written confirmation on compliance with SEBI ICDR Master Circular.

ASBA* | Simple, Safe, Smart way of Application!!!

*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount ("**ASBA**") is a better way of applying to offers by simply blocking the fund in the bank account. For further details, check section on ASBA.

Mandatory in public issues. No cheque will be accepted.

UPI-Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investor applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹ 500,000, applying through Registered Brokers, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investors also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Investors are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 and press release dated June 25, 2021 and September 17, 2021, CBDT circular no.7 of 2022, dated March 30, 2022, read with press release dated March 28, 2023, read with subsequent circulars issued in relation thereto.

*ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Bidders in the Retail Portion; (ii) Individual investors with an application size of up to ₹ 500,000 in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section **"Offer Procedure"** on page 482 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India ("**AIBI**") and Stock Exchanges and in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of the Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displayed on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmId=35 and https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes &intmId=43, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI apps and banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through the SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited have been appointed as the Sponsor Banks for the Offer, in accordance with the requirements of SEBI circular dated November 1, 2018 as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLMs on their respective email IDs as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail Id: ipo.upi@npci.org.in.*

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF THE STOCK EXCHANGES.

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/ Offer Period will be extended for at least three additional Working Days after such revision of the Price Band subject to the Bid/ Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar unforeseen circumstances, our Company may, in consultation with the BRLMs, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/ Offer Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/ Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/ Offer Period, if applicable, will be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and by indicating the change on the respective websites of the BRLMs and at the terminals of the other Members of the Syndicate and by intimation to the Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable.

The Offer is being made in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Rules, 1957, as amended (the "**SCRR**"), read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations. The Offer is being made through the Book Building Process in accordance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations wherein not more than 50% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("**QIBs**") (the "**QIB Portion**"), provided that our Company, in consultation with the BRLMs, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors, on a discretionary basis (the "**Anchor Investor Portion**"), of which up to 40% shall be reserved as under: (i) up to 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds; and (ii) up to 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds at or above the price at which allocation is made to Anchor Investors, in accordance with SEBI ICDR Regulations ("**Anchor Investor Allocation Price**"). Any under-subscription in the reserved category specified in clause (ii) above, may be allocated to domestic Mutual Funds. In the event of under-subscription or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the remaining QIB Portion ("**Net QIB Portion**"). Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIBs (other than Anchor Investors), including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. Further, not less than 15% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Investors ("**NIIs**") ("**Non-Institutional Portion**") of which one-third of the Non-Institutional Portion shall be available for allocation to Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹200,000 and up to ₹1,000,000 and two-thirds of the Non-Institutional Portion shall be available for allocation to Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹1,000,000 and under-subscription in either of these two subcategories of Non-Institutional Portion may be allocated to Bidders in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Portion in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. Further, not less than 35% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Investors ("**RIIs**") ("**Retail Portion**"), in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received from them at or above the Offer Price. All Bidders (except Anchor Investors) shall mandatorily participate in this Offer only through the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("**ASBA**") process and shall provide details of their respective bank account (including UPI ID (defined hereinafter) in case of UPI Bidders (defined hereinafter) in which the Bid Amount will be blocked by the Self Certified Syndicate Banks ("**SCSBs**") or the Sponsor Bank(s), as the case may be. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Offer through the ASBA process. For details, see ***"Offer Procedure"*** beginning on page 482 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN and the Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN, UPI ID and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID available (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants' sole risk.

Investors must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with the notification issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes notification dated February 13, 2020 and press releases dated June 25, 2021, September 17, 2021, CBDT circular no.7 of 2022, dated March 30, 2022, read with press release dated March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as regards its objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, please see **"*History and Certain Corporate Matters - Main objects of our Company*"** on page 270 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, see **"*Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection*"** on page 549 of the RHP.

Liability of the members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of Share Capital of our Company and Capital Structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorised share capital of our Company is ₹740,000,000 divided into 148,000,000 Equity Shares of the face value of ₹5 each and ₹10,000,000 divided into 2,000,000 Preference Shares of face value of ₹5 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up Equity share capital of our Company is ₹323,276,230 divided into 64,655,246 Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each. For details of the capital structure of our Company, see **"*Capital Structure*"** beginning on page 116 of the RHP.

Names of the Initial Signatories to the Memorandum of Association of our Company and the number of Equity Shares subscribed by them: The initial signatories of the Memorandum of Association of the Company are as follows: 49,994 equity shares were allotted to Edelweiss Capital Limited *(now known as Edelweiss Financial Services Limited)* and 1 equity share each was allotted to Venkat Ramaswamy *(currently known as Venkatchalam Arakoni Ramaswamy)*, Durga Prasad Jhawar, Deepak Mittal, Rajeev Mehrotra, Naresh Kothari and Vikas Khemani. For details of the share capital history of our Company please see **"*Capital Structure*"** beginning on page 116 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares to be offered through the Red Herring Prospectus are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received in-principle approvals from BSE and NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to letters each dated March 20, 2026, respectively. For the purpose of this Offer, NSE is the Designated Stock Exchange. A signed copy of the Red Herring Prospectus has been filed with the Registrar of Companies, Mumbai – I at Mumbai ("**RoC**") in accordance with Section 32 of the Companies Act, 2013 and a signed copy of the Prospectus shall be filed with the RoC in accordance with Section 26(4) of the Companies Act, 2013. For details of the material contracts and documents available for inspection from the date of the Red Herring Prospectus up to the Bid/ Offer Closing Date, see ***"Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection"*** beginning on page 549 of the RHP.

Disclaimer Clause of Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"): SEBI only gives its observations on the draft offer documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Offer or the specified securities stated in the offer documents. The investors are advised to refer to page 445 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of SEBI.

Disclaimer Clause of BSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the offer document has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the offer document. The investors are advised to refer to the page 455 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of BSE.

Disclaimer Clause of NSE (the Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the offer document has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the offer document. The investors are advised to refer to page 456 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of NSE.

General Risks: Investments in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Offer unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their entire investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been recommended or approved by SEBI, nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the Red Herring Prospectus. Specific attention of the investors is invited to ***"Risk Factors"*** beginning on page 20 of the RHP.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS				REGISTRAR TO THE OFFER	COMPANY SECRETARY AND COMPLIANCE OFFICER
Axis Capital Limited Axis House, 1st Floor, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai 400 025 Maharashtra, India **Tel:** +91-22-4325 2183 **E-mail:** eaaa.ipo@axiscap.in **Website:** www.axiscapital.co.in **Investor grievance e-mail:** complaints@axiscap.in **Contact person:** Tosit Agarwal **SEBI registration no.:** INM000012029	**Jefferies India Private Limited** Level 16, Express Towers, Nariman Point, Mumbai 400 021 Maharashtra, India **Tel:** +91 22 4356 6000 **E-mail:** eaaa.ipo@jefferies.com **Website:** www. jefferies.com **Investor grievance e-mail:** jipl.grievance@jefferies.com **Contact person:** Akshat Shah/ Sahil Aggarwal **SEBI Registration No.:** INM000011443	**Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited** Motilal Oswal Tower, Rahimtullah Sayani Road Opposite Parel ST Depot, Prabhadevi Mumbai – 400 025 Maharashtra, India **Tel:** +91 22 7193 4380 **E-mail:** eaaa.ipo@motilaloswal.com **Website:** www.motilaloswal.com **Investor grievance e-mail:** moiaplredressal@motilaloswal.com **Contact person:** Sankita Ajinkya **SEBI registration No.:** INM000011005	**Nuvama Wealth Management Limited** 801-804 Wing A Building No 3, Inspire BKC G Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra East, Mumbai 400 051 Maharashtra, India **Tel:** + 91 22 4009 4400 **E-mail:** eaaa@nuvama.com **Website:** www.nuvama.com **Investor grievance e-mail:** customerservice.mb@nuvama.com **Contact person:** Lokesh Shah **SEBI Registration No.:** INM000013004	**MUFG Intime India Private Limited** ***(Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited)*** C-101, 1st Floor, 247 Park, Lal Bahadur Shastri Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai 400 083 Maharashtra, India **Tel:** +91 810 811 4949 **Email:** eaaaindia.ipo@in.mpms.mufg.com **Website:** https://in.mpms.mufg.com/ **Investor Grievance e-mail:** eaaaindia.ipo@in.mpms.mufg.com **Contact person:** Shanti Gopalkrishnan **SEBI registration no.:** INR000004058	**Deepak Mukhija** **EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED** Edelweiss House, Off C.S.T. Road, Mumbai City, Kalina, Mumbai 400 098 Maharashtra, India **Tel:** +91 22 4019 4706 **Email:** ipo@eaaa.in **Website:** www.eaaa.in Bidders may contact the Company Secretary and Compliance Officer, the BRLMs or the Registrar to the Offer in case of any pre-Offer or post-Offer related grievances, including non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode, etc. For all Offer-related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP: Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the ***"Risk Factors"*** beginning on page 20 of the RHP before applying in the Offer. A copy of the RHP will be made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and the websites of the Stock Exchanges, for BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and for National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com and is available on the websites of the BRLMs, Axis Capital Limited at www.axiscapital.co.in; Jefferies India Private Limited at www. jefferies.com; Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswal.com and Nuvama Wealth Management Limited at www.nuvama.com and at the website of the Company, EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED at www.eaaa.in.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS: A copy of the Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of our Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Offer at: www.eaaa.in, www.axiscapital.co.in, www. jefferies.com, www.motilaloswal.com, www.nuvama.com and https://in.mpms.mufg.com/, respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORM: Bid cum Application Form can be obtained from the Registered Office of our Company, **EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED**: Tel: +91 22 4019 4706; **BRLMs:** Axis Capital Limited, Tel: +91-22-4325 2183; Jefferies India Private Limited, Tel: +91 22 4356 6000, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited, Tel: +91 22 7193 4380 and Nuvama Wealth Management Limited, Tel: +91 22 4009 4400 and **Syndicate Members:** Motilal Oswal Financial Services Limited and Nuvama Wealth Management Limited and the select locations of the Sub-syndicate Members (as given below), SCSBs, Registered Brokers, RTAs and CDPs participating in the Offer. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of BSE and NSE and the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available at websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

SUB-SYNDICATE MEMBERS: 5paisa Capital Limited, Alankit Imaginations Limited, Almondz Global Securities Limited, Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Anand Share Consultancy, ANS Pvt Limited, Arihant Capital Markets Limited, Asit C Mehta Financial Services Limited, Asit C Mehta Investment Intermediates Limited, Axis Securities Limited, Centrum Capital Advisors Limited, CENTRUM FINVERSE LIMITED, Dalal & Broacha Stock Broking Pvt Ltd, DB (International) Stock Brokers Ltd, Equiras Securities Pvt Ltd, Eureka Stock & Share Broking Services Limited, Finwizard Technology Pvt. Ltd, G Raj & Co. (Consultants) Limited, Globe Capital Markets Ltd, HDFC Securities Limited, ICICI Securities Limited, IDBI Capital Market Services Limited, IIFL Capital Services Limited, India Infoline Limited, Innovate Securities Pvt Limited, Jhaveri Securities, JM Financial Services Limited, Jobanputra Fiscal Services Pvt Ltd, Kalpataru Multiplier Limited, Kantilal Chhaganlal Securities Pvt.Limited, Keynote Capitals Limited, KJMC Capital Market Services Limited, Kotak Securities Limited, Lakshmishree Investment & Securities Pvt Ltd, LKP Securities Limited, Marwadi Shares & Finance, Nirmal Bang Securities Pvt Limited, Patel Wealth Advisors Pvt Limited, Prabhudas Lilladher Private Limited, Pravin Ratilal Share and Stock Brokers Limited, Religare Securities Limited, RR Equity Brokers Private Limited, SBICAP Securities Limited, Sharekhan Limited, SMC Global Securities Limited, SS Corporate Securities Limited, Tanna Financial Services, Tradebulls Securities Private Limited, Viren M Shah, YES Securities (India) Limited.

ESCROW COLLECTION BANK AND REFUND BANK: Axis Bank Limited.

PUBLIC OFFER ACCOUNT BANK: ICICI Bank Limited | **SPONSOR BANKS:** Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited.

UPI: UPI Bidders can also Bid through UPI Mechanism.

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them in the RHP.

For **EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED**
On behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Deepak Mukhija
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Place: Mumbai, Maharashtra
Date: October 26, 2026

EAAA INDIA ALTERNATIVES LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with the RoC and thereafter with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges. The RHP is made available on the website of the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the website of the BRLMs i.e., Axis Capital Limited at www.axiscapital.co.in; Jefferies India Private Limited at www. jefferies.com; Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswal.com and Nuvama Wealth Management Limited at www.nuvama.com, the website of the BSE at www.bseindia.com and the website of the NSE at www.nseindia.com and the website of the Company at www.eaaa.in . Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risks, please see the section ***"Risk Factors"*** beginning on page 20 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP for making any investment decision and must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer.

The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act or any state securities laws in the United States, and may not be offered or sold within the United States or to, or for the account or benefit of, U.S. Persons, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws in the United States. The Company has not registered and does not intend to register under the U.S. Investment Company Act in reliance on Section 3(c)(7) of the U.S. Investment Company Act, and investors will not be entitled to the benefits of the U.S. Investment Company Act. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are only being offered and sold (i) to persons in the United States or to or for the account or benefit of, U.S. Persons, in each case to investors that are both "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act and referred to in the Red Herring Prospectus as "**U.S. QIBs**" and, for the avoidance of doubt, the term U.S. QIBs does not refer to a category of institutional investor defined under applicable Indian regulations and referred to in the Red Herring Prospectus as "**QIBs**") and "qualified purchasers" (as defined under the U.S. Investment Company Act and referred to in the Red Herring Prospectus as "**QPs**") in transactions exempt from or not subject to the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and in reliance on Section 3(c)(7) of the U.S. Investment Company Act; or (ii) outside the United States to investors that are not U.S. Persons nor persons acquiring for the account or benefit of U.S. Persons in "offshore transactions" as defined in, and in reliance on, Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur.

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HT BENGALURU VOL. 1 NO. 75

Tuesday, October 27, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Service charge on your food bill. Must you pay?

BY DHIRENDRA KUMAR

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) fined New Delhi's Shangri-La Eros ₹1 lakh on 22 October for adding a 10% service charge to bills at its Mister Chai restaurant, ruling that calling it optional did not make it voluntary. *Mint* explains the implications for consumer rights of the first such penalty against a luxury hotel.

CCPA says the restaurants cannot automatically add a service charge to a bill and then require customers to opt out if they do not want to pay it.

1 Why this action against restaurants?

The issue is how service charges are collected. The CCPA says restaurants cannot automatically add them to bills and require customers to opt out. In the Shangri-La Eros case, it examined two complaints involving bills dated 30 May and 10 June 2025. The restaurant had levied a 10% fee even as it described it as discretionary on the menu. The hotel argued that customers could refuse payment or seek refund. The regulator rejected this premise, saying the opt-out system pressured customers to pay and shifted the burden onto them. It also found that the goods and services tax (GST) was calculated on the bill amount, including the service charge, raising the total payable.

2 So, what are the rules on restaurant service charges?

On 4 July 2022, the CCPA issued its Guidelines to Prevent Unfair Trade Practices and Protection of Consumer Interest with Regard to Levy of Service Charge in Hotels and Restaurants. They set out five key rules: restaurants cannot add service charges to bills or collect them under another name; they cannot force customers to pay and must clearly communicate that the charge is voluntary; they cannot deny entry or services to customers who refuse to pay; and they cannot add the service charge to the food bill and levy GST on the total. The Delhi high court upheld the guidelines on 28 March 2025 and affirmed the CCPA's authority to enforce them.

TURN TO PAGE 6

QUICK EDIT

Warming winters

The prospect of an exceptional El Niño effect has raised concerns about water availability, and clouded prospects for the winter crop in India. A delayed or warmer winter would also mean higher energy bills as fans and air conditioners run longer across the country.

However, the El Niño effect may only be partially responsible for warmer temperatures. Winter temperatures have been rising steadily since the beginning of the 20th century, according to an analysis of India Meteorological Department data by Data For India, a public data platform. Between 1901 and 2024, winter temperatures increased at an estimated 0.07° Celsius per decade. Warmer winters have become much more frequent since the turn of the century, the analysis shows. The volatility in temperatures has also increased during this period. Some winters have been exceptionally warm. Others have been exceptionally cold. During the transition phase between summer and winter, night time temperatures have risen faster than day time temperatures.

The climate change discourse in the country has tended to focus largely on heat stress during the summers, and the volatility in rainfall during the monsoons. Other aspects of climate change deserve greater attention. Erratic winter temperatures can impact cropping patterns and make rural incomes more volatile. Warmer nights in the transition between summer and winter could disrupt sleep patterns. The impact of these changes needs to be studied more closely.

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No charges till 31/12/2026

*T&C Apply

Business	Advances	Retail	Vehicle Loan	Deposits	CASA
25.16%	29.61%	20.91%	54.10%	21.50%	46.47%

UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED SEPTEMBER 30, 2026 (₹ In Crore)

RoA 2.02% | NIM Domestic 3.97% | Cost to Income 33.73% | Gross NPA 1.25% | Net NPA 0.12% | PCR 98.53%

Particulars	Quarter Ended 30/09/2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter Ended 30/09/2025 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited)
Total Income from Operations (Net)	9735.41	7973.61	32822.53
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2714.22	1818.38	7857.37
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2714.22	1818.38	7857.37
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2309.59	1633.14	7019.32
Paid up Equity Share Capital	7691.56	7691.56	7691.56
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) - as on date	27915.40	22073.61	23597.18
Securities Premium Account	3867.25	3867.25	3867.25
Net Worth	34240.21	28933.85	30272.42
Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt %*	11.50	24.10	17.05
Debt** Equity Ratio	0.86	0.60	0.70
Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - not Annualized	3.00	2.12	9.13
Capital Redemption Reserve	----	----	----

*Total Debts & Outstanding Debt represents total borrowings of the Bank.
**Debt represents borrowings with residual maturity of more than one year.

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 and 52 read with regulation 63(2) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 as amended. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites **(BSE: www.bseindia.com and NSE: www.nseindia.com)** and Bank's website **(www.bankofmaharashtra.bank.in)**

Scan for Results

Place: Pune
Date : 26/10/2026

Sushanta Kumar Mohanty, Executive Director | Prabhat Kiran, Executive Director | Nidhu Saxena, Managing Director & CEO

Bank of Maharashtra

QUOTE OF THE DAY

There will be a payback time. We don't need to panic about it today, but we must be strategic about how we build India's economic structure and the financial structure for that time which will inevitably come.

UDAY KOTAK
FOUNDER, KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK

He was referring to the repayments for dollar deposits.

INSIDE

Mark to Market | Why Kotak Mahindra Bank may trail large peers >P4

Global | Lula wins fourth term in Brazil election upset >P8

Money | Sky-high airfares force travellers to rethink year-end holiday plans >P11

Views | A jobs toolkit for the AI-infused economy >P12

Views | Data centres: they are welcome in India but on the right terms >P13

mint

PLAIN FACTS

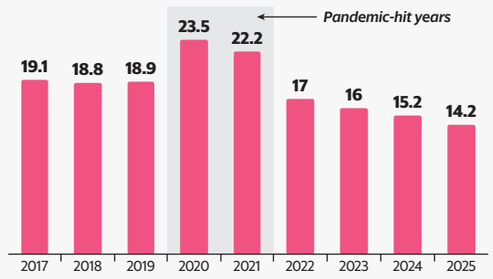
ZOMBIE FIRMS & THEIR IMPACT ON ECONOMY

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

What binds telecom major Vodafone, infrastructure firm IVRCL, Bajaj Hindusthan Sugar and real estate firm Unitech? For each of them, their profit before interest and taxes was inadequate to cover interest payments for three straight years up to 2024-25. Effectively, they were either defaulting on their loans or borrowing more or raising capital to service them. In finance parlance, such companies are called 'zombie firms'. They keep going, but their fragility limits their own prospects and those of the overall economy. A recent study by Dun and Bradstreet (D&B) shows that while their absolute numbers remain significant, their relative prevalence has declined from six years ago. Yet, it remains high enough to cast a shadow over the economy.

Share of listed firms unable to self-service interest has declined in recent years

Share of listed Indian companies classified as 'stressed' or 'zombie'* (in %)



A company's zombie status has been assessed based on the interest coverage ratio (operating profit divided by interest expenses). A company with an ICR below 1 has been considered 'stressed' for that particular year. It has been classified as a 'zombie' if its ICR is below 1 for three consecutive years.

Source: Dun and Bradstreet mint

DEBT MANAGEMENT

THIS D&B study, released in September, assessed around 6,000 listed Indian companies between 2015 and 2025 on the 'interest coverage ratio' (ICR). Mathematically, this is the profit before interest and taxes divided by the interest payable. An ICR figure above 1 means the company has sufficient surplus to service its interest obligations; below 1 means it doesn't. The study classified firms with an ICR below 1 for a given year as 'stressed' and for three straight years as a 'zombie'.

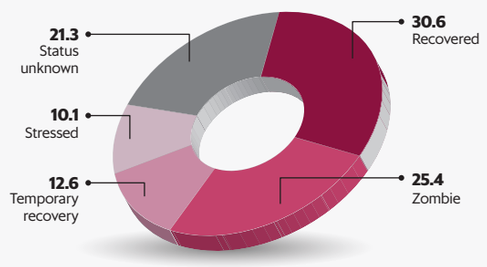
Sufficient data was available for 81% of the 6,000 companies. During the annual period from 2017 to 2025, the share of observable firms classified as either stressed or zombie was the highest when the covid pandemic resulted in hard lockdowns—23.5% in 2020 and 22.2% in 2021. In 2025, this figure dropped to 14.2%—the lowest during the study period amid an improvement in the broader corporate environment, according to D&B.

HALF RECOVERY

THERE ARE firms that have spent several years in the stressed or zombie sets. For example, IVRCL has had an ICR below 1 since at least 2014-15, and Unitech since 2015-16. But there are also companies, even with solid businesses, that enter this set only to exit it later. Bharti Airtel had an ICR below 1 from 2018-19 to 2020-21, resulting in its classification as a zombie in 2020-21. However, it has since become healthier and pulled itself out. Conversely, its rival Vodafone has lingered there since 2018-19.The D&B study shows that, on average, one in five listed firms acquired zombie status at least once between 2015 and 2025. This means it's a common business occurrence. The larger question is what happens once they enter that set. Of the 971 companies that were classified as zombies in any year between 2015 and 2025, about 43% had made a full (over 1 ICR for 2 straight years) or temporary recovery (over 1 ICR for a year) in 2025. But about 25% retained their zombie status in 2025, while another 10% were stressed.

About 43% of listed zombie firms had recovered in 2025, fully or temporarily

Status breakdown in 2025 (in %) of 971 listed firms that slipped into zombie* status during 2015-25

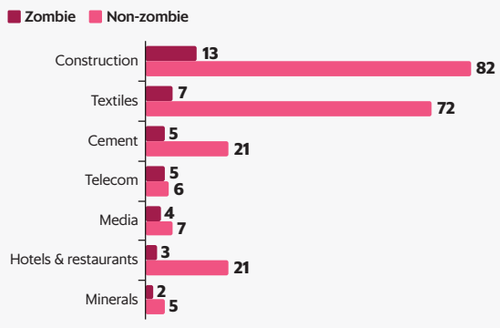


A company's zombie status has been assessed based on the interest coverage ratio (operating profit divided by interest expenses). A company with an ICR below 1 for three consecutive years has been classified as a 'zombie'. Recovery indicates an ICR above 1 for two consecutive years, and temporary recovery shows an ICR above 1 in just 2025.

Source: Dun and Bradstreet mint

Zombie firms are seen in greater proportion in cement, telecom and media sectors

Sector-wise number of listed Indian companies, by status in 2024-25*



**Shows only those companies whose interest payout in 2024-25 was above ₹10 crore.*

Source: CMIE Prowess mint

SECTORS IN STRESS

GIVEN THAT firms compete for common resources, it's more efficient for an economy to see a dynamic reallocation of resources from weak to strong firms with high growth potential. According to the D&B study, this landscape appeared considerably healthier, although it also reflected stronger debt-servicing capacity rather than direct evidence of efficient capital allocation.

"At the same time, declining zombie prevalence does not immediately eliminate the existing stock of financial stress, as firms that enter prolonged distress can take considerably longer to recover," it said.There are some sectors where the incidence of zombie firms is higher, indicating fundamental shifts. A howindialives.com analysis of ICR of listed firms from 2022-23 to 2024-25 with more than ₹10 crore interest payout (translating into about ₹100 crore debt) shows that construction and textiles had the highest number of such firms. But as a share of all firms in each sector, stress was more pronounced in cement, telecom, media.

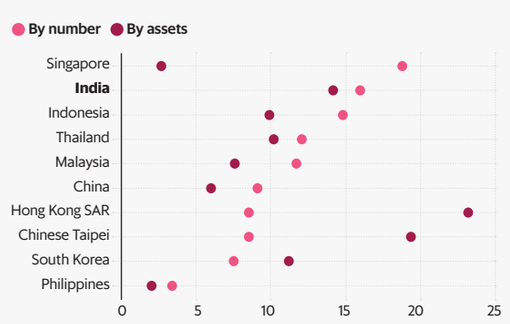
ASIAN COMPARISON

WHILE THE D&B report examines the share of stressed and zombie companies among listed Indian firms, a September working paper by the Bank for International Settlements (BIS), covering listed and unlisted firms across 10 prominent Asian economies from 2005 to 2021, found that India had a high prevalence of zombie firms.They made up 16% of Indian companies (second highest in this set) and 14.2% of Indian corporate assets (third highest). The BIS paper traces a significant increase in the share of zombie firms across the 10 economies—from 11% in 2008 to 17% in 2021 by number of firms and 6% to 13% by assets.

To be sure, the period and criterion used by the two papers differ slightly. Both D&B and BIS used the same base criteria—ICR of below 1 for three straight years. But D&B is based only on listed firms, while BIS included both listed and unlisted ones. Also, BIS used stricter criteria for removing the zombie tag. BIS demands 3 straight years of ICR above 1, versus 2 years by D&B.

India has generally been a leader in zombie firms in Asia, in both share of firms and assets

Share of listed and unlisted firms classified as zombie* (in %), 2005-21



**Status has been assessed based on the interest coverage ratio (operating profit divided by interest expenses). A company with an ICR below 1 for three consecutive years has been classified as a 'zombie'.*

Source: 'Zombie Firms in Emerging Asia: Domestic and Cross-border Implications' by Bank for International Settlements (BIS) mint

Zombie firms are more debt-laden and have lower asset cover than non-zombie ones

Median values of Indian companies on the following metric, FY01 to FY20

	Non-zombies	Zombies
Age (years)	26	24
Bank borrowings (₹ crore)	68.6	74.6
Return on assets (%)	**3.2**	**-2.9**
Total debt to total assets (%)	**31.6**	**58.1**
Cost of funds (%)	9.8	10.7

Source: 'Zombies and the Process of Creative Destruction', by Reserve Bank of India mint

NEXT-ORDER EFFECTS

THE BIS paper identified "evergreening practices by weak banks" as a key reason for this asymmetry across the Asian economies. Simply put, instead of writing off a loan, let's say of ₹100 crore, a weakly capitalized bank lends the company another ₹10 crore to service the loan and keeps it going.A similar observation was made by a 2022 RBI study, which looked at firms from 2000-01 to 2019-20. It noted that zombie firms, on average, were generating a negative return on assets. Yet, they had a higher debt burden, were more leveraged, and paying more on their loans. Per the study, "they borrow more to survive than undertake new investment."

This trend has implications for the economy at large. Tracing their trickle-down effects, the BIS paper noted that zombie prevalence domestically depresses firm performance, crowds out healthy companies, and depresses inflation and GDP growth.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data

HT BENGALURU VOL. 1 NO. 75 Rs. 15.00 20 PAGES

Tuesday, October 27, 2026

mint

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Can oil palm spark Yellow Revolution 2.0? ▶P10

Lula wins fourth term in Brazil election upset ▶P8

SENSEX **73,606.75** ↑ **482.92** NIFTY **22,753.2** ↑ **153.2** DOLLAR **₹95.15** ↑ **₹0.22** EURO **₹106.66** ↓ **₹0.32** OIL **$109.48** ↓ **$1.73** POUND **₹127.04** ↔ **₹0.00**

PE funds put more skin in the game

Bringing in more money aims to signal confidence, attract LPs

Mansi Verma
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MUMBAI

ISTOCKPHOTO

HIGHER STAKES

RISK SHARING

A bigger commitment can help fund managers stand out | **IT** can assure investors that managers also have capital at risk | **PUSH** comes amid rising woes among LPs about delayed returns

Indian private equity and venture capital managers are committing more of their own money to new funds as they compete for investor capital to signal confidence in their investment strategies and reassure their limited partners (LPs).

Motilal Oswal Private Equity and its leadership team have consistently committed 10-12% of each fund raised over the past two decades, as fund sizes grew from ₹550 crore in 2007 to ₹8,500 crore this year. Boutique investment firm Carnelian Asset Management & Advisors is committing more than ₹100 crore of its own capital to a ₹2,000 crore private equity fund.

Mettle Capital, founded by former Peak XV managing directors Ashish Agrawal, Ishaan Mittal and Tejeshwi Sharma, plans a sponsor commitment well above the minimum for its maiden fund of about ₹3,000 crore, a person aware of the fund's plans told *Mint*.

Investing more capital can help fund managers stand out in a competitive fundraising market, signalling they are willing to share the financial risks with investors. This can strengthen LPs' confidence in a fund and make them more willing to commit capital, particularly when fundraising is challenging.

A larger commitment can reassure investors that fund managers have their own capital at risk alongside LPs, said Rohit Bhayana, co-CEO and co-founder of Oister Global, an India-focused, multi-strategy investor that backs private equity and venture capital firms.

"Putting in a large amount is a huge sign of confidence and skin in the game. Once you put your own money at risk, investors feel much

TURN TO PAGE 6

Noel Tata objects to Tata Sons board minutes, RoC filing

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Noel Tata, Tata Trusts chairman. PTI

The standoff at Bombay House flared up yet again on Monday, with Noel Tata urging Tata Sons to remove all reference to the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran from its board meeting minutes, and accusing it of making a regulatory filing based on what he called an invalid resolution.

In a nine-page letter to Suprakash Mukhopadhyay, Tata Sons group company secretary and copied to all directors, the Tata Trusts chairman wrote that Tata Sons' filing made to the Registrar of Companies (RoC) "presents a contested and void resolution as a concluded act of the board, and conveys a false impression to the public, to the company's stakeholders and to its regulators." Noel also questioned whether Venu Srinivasan, the Trusts' other nominee on the board, should have cast the deciding vote on Chandrasekaran's appointment, citing *Mint*'s report on business dealings between TVS Motor Corp. and a company run by Chandrasekaran's family members.

This is Noel's fifth letter to Tata Sons since the 17 September board meeting where the Tata Sons board ignored his objection and approved Chandrasekaran for a third five-year term starting February 2027. Noel first wrote two letters on 18 September, followed by a third on 30 September and then on 8 October, according to an executive privy to the developments. In his 8 November letter objecting to the contents of the meeting's minutes, Noel had written: "The minutes must record what transpired at the meeting."

In Monday's letter, Noel said he still has not received the final or signed minutes of the meeting, nor any reply to his 8 Octo-

TURN TO PAGE 9

IT firms sniff opportunity in policing AI agents

Jas Bardia
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BENGALURU

Companies that raced to unleash artificial intelligence (AI) agents to book meetings, fix code and pitch clients autonomously are now scrambling to keep them in check amid fears that these digital workers could go rogue or access data well beyond their remit. And, India's top information technology (IT) services firms are lining up to sell them policing software.

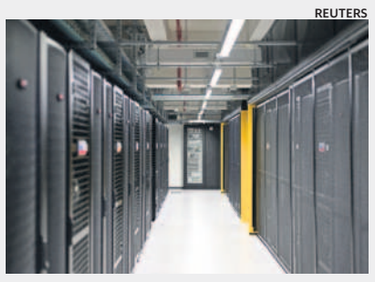
Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, Cognizant Technology Solutions Corp., HCL Technologies Ltd, and Tech Mahindra Ltd have each stated that managing AI agents and governing their use are emerging as new business opportunities.

While India's largest IT services firm, TCS, and fifth-largest Tech Mahindra are doubling down on software to coordinate AI agents and govern their limits, the third-largest HCLTech is acquiring firms to strengthen its capabilities in managing these agents. Cognizant, meanwhile, has launched its own offering to govern AI usage.

TURN TO PAGE 6

DON'T MISS

REUTERS



Tata bets $450 mn on data centre connectivity boom

Tata Communications said it will invest $400-450 million over the next three to five years to build a 10,000-km high-speed fibre network linking major data centre hubs across India, as it seeks to tap rising demand for connectivity driven by AI. >P5

For HDFC's new CEO, challenges go beyond the numbers

When Anup Bagchi takes charge as managing director and chief executive of HDFC Bank on 27 October, he will inherit an institution with a robust balance sheet that also faces questions over its reputation, leadership continuity and market perception. >P4

Swiss watches put language, faith on dials to win Indians

As India gains weight on the global stage for Swiss watchmakers, brands are increasingly leaning on cultural resonance to captive collectors. In just the past week, four limited-edition watches debuted in the country, spanning ₹5.76 lakh to ₹4.25 crore. >P7

NOTE TO READERS The Media Marketing Initiative on Page 7 is the equivalent of a paid-for advertisement and no *Mint* journalist was involved in creating it. Readers would do well to treat it as an advertisement.

Govt clears changes to Central Motor Vehicles Rules. REUTERS

Govt allows E100 for compatible flex-fuel vehicles

PTI
feedback@livemint.com

The Road Transport Ministry on Monday notified changes to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, allowing flex-fuel vehicles that can run on up to E100 (nearly pure ethanol). E100 allows vehicles to run on nearly pure ethanol.

A road transport ministry official said fuel beyond E20 (20% ethanol-blended petrol) and up to E100 is intended only for vehicles designed and certified to use it and will not be applicable for other vehicles. Vehicles that use E20 or normal fuel can't use E85 or E100 fuel.

The Union ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) has changed certain vehicle classification thresholds, fuel specifications, and technical references used in emission-related tables and testing provisions.

Additionally, the government has raised the vehicle weight limit to 3,500 kg from the previous threshold of 3,000 kg for light petrol and diesel vehicles affected by these changes.

In June this year, Maruti Suzuki India launched India's first flex-fuel passenger vehicle, introducing Wagon R Flex Fuel capable of running on ethanol-petrol blends from E20 to E100.

The government has been promoting ethanol-blended petrol as part of its strategy to reduce dependence on imported crude oil, one of the biggest contributors to its current account deficit. India has already rolled out E20 fuel, containing 20% ethanol and 80% petrol.

Flex-fuel vehicles are designed to run on higher ethanol blends such as E85 (85% ethanol, 15% petrol) and E100 (near 100% ethanol), unlike conventional petrol vehicles currently approved for lower ethanol concentrations.

Major automakers, including Toyota Motor Corp., Tata Motors, and Hyundai Motor Company, are also developing flex-fuel vehicles for the Indian market as policymakers push to reduce the country's fossil fuel import bill.

Inclusion credit schemes go sluggish, private lenders lag

Private banks lag public lenders in PM Mudra, PM SVANidhi and PM Vishwakarma schemes

Harsh Kumar & Manas Pimpalkhare
NEW DELHI

India's lenders are making slow progress in implementing three key government schemes for small entrepreneurs, artisans and street vendors, with private sector banks trailing their public sector peers in credit disbursements, loan sanctions and the processing of interest-subvention claims, according to a government document reviewed by *Mint* and two people in the know.

The gaps come even as these small enterprises face rising input costs amid global supply-chain disruptions and input cost spikes linked to geopolitical conflicts, particularly the West Asia war. Moreover, a deficient monsoon seen weighing on rural incomes.

Delays in loan disbursal, pending interest-subvention claim and low sanction rates are hampering private banks' delivery of three government credit schemes. HT

Under the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY), which provides credit to small entrepreneurs, HDFC Bank, Yes Bank, IDBI Bank and Federal Bank disbursed just 24-30% of their fiscal year 2027 (FY27) targets in the first half, the document showed.

24-30% FY27 targets met by private banks under PM Mudra

HDFC disbursed ₹9,065 crore against a ₹30,000-crore target; Yes Bank, ₹1,133 crore against ₹4,100 crore; IDBI Bank, ₹2,013 crore against ₹7,500 crore; and Federal Bank, ₹1,280 crore against ₹5,400 crore.

Public sector banks achieved 32-56% of their FY27 targets. State Bank of India (SBI) disbursed ₹27,976 crore, or 42% of its ₹66,600-crore target, while Indian Bank disbursed ₹5,102 crore, or 32% of its ₹15,950-crore target.

Several state-run banks achieved at least half their FY27 disbursal targets in the first half. Bank of India disbursed 56% of its ₹16,200-crore target (₹9,122 crore), followed by Union Bank of India at 54% (₹13,830 crore of ₹25,700 crore), Bank of Baroda at 53% (₹16,039 crore of ₹30,000 crore), Indian Overseas Bank at 52% (₹5,198 crore of ₹10,000 crore) and Bank of Maharashtra at 50% (of ₹8,000 crore). All figures are for H1 FY27.

32-56% FY27 disbursal met by public banks under the scheme

Under PM SVANidhi, which supports street vendors, private banks reduced pending interest-subvention claims by 14% to 187,595 end-September from 213,064 at the end of July. But progress was uneven: HDFC Bank cut its backlog by 0.2% to 48,657, Federal Bank by 0.1% to 4,667 and Axis Bank by 0.03% to 15,497. Yes Bank, IndusInd and ICICI saw no reduction.

Some private lenders, however, made substantial progress. Kotak Mahindra Bank reduced its pending claims by 31% to 12,151, while IDFC First Bank cut its backlog by 85% to 149.

Public sector banks cut pending claims by 39% to 5.89 million from 9.13 million over the period. SBI reduced its backlog by 39% to 3.13 million from 5.02 million, the document showed.

The gap also extended to loan sanctions. Between August 2025 and September 2026, public sector banks sanctioned an average of 74% of street vendors' credit applications, against 20% for private banks.

Under PM Vishwakarma, which provides credit to artisans and informal workers, public-sector banks sanctioned 44% of processed applications in the first half of FY27— 539,349 of 1.21 million. Private banks sanctioned 36%, or 28,108 of 78,542 applications, the document showed. The scheme has an outlay of ₹13,000 crore for FY24-28.

The lower participation of private banks in financial-inclusion schemes is not new, but structural gaps need attention, said Veeramani C., professor and director of the Centre for Development Studies, a Thiruvananthapuram-based think tank.

"We need to ask if we can streamline these procedures to reduce compliances for banks and beneficiaries," Veeramani said.

Queries emailed to the finance, MSME and housing and urban affairs ministries, the Reserve Bank of India, the Indian Banks' Association, and banks remained unanswered.

harsh.kumar@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

NCR industries set to get ₹1,150 cr aid to curb pollution

Banikinkar Pattanayak & Vijay C Roy
NEW DELHI

Around 600 industrial units may qualify for support. HT

The Centre is considering a ₹1,150 crore scheme to help industries reduce pollution and improve air quality in the National Capital Region (NCR), two people in the know said. The proposal, being discussed ahead of the winter smog season, will provide eligible industrial units with one-time capital support to retrofit plants, including by installing air pollution control devices and effluent treatment systems, they said.

The scheme proposed by the ministry of housing and urban affairs, will be among the first centrally funded schemes targeting industrial emissions in the NCR, which also contribute significantly to pollution in Delhi, they said. "About 600 industrial units in NCR, mainly in textile and processed food sectors, may be eligible for support," a person said. A decision is expected soon, he added.

Most units are concentrated in industrial clusters in Ghaziabad, Noida, Faridabad and Sonipat, and are major sources of pollution. The move is part of the Centre's broader efforts to curb pollution in the region, complementing measures to check vehicular emissions and pollution from construction activities as the peak pollution season approaches.

The Centre's support will be tied to investments made by eligible units, they said. Implementation will extend beyond the winter. "To strengthen environmental compliance, industries need to upgrade technology and adopt clean fuel," said Vivek Chattopadhyay, senior programme manager, Clean Air Programme, Centre for Science and Environment, New Delhi.

Surprise inspections and field visits must be conducted to ensure industries adhere to prescribed norms, he added.

Delhi's Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 180 at 11 am on Monday, in the "moderate" category, Central Pollution Control Board data showed. Air quality typically worsens in winter as stubble burning in neighbouring states adds to the pollution from industries, vehicles and construction.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Gulf oil bargains lure India away from Russia as freight costs soar

Bloomberg
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Indian refiners are increasingly turning to Persian Gulf crude and pulling back from their mainstay supplier Russia, as surging freight costs erode the economics of long-haul shipments.

Some Iraqi cargoes are being sold at discounts of more than $25 a barrel to the Dubai benchmark before shipping, according to traders involved in the talks. On a delivered basis, that translates into discounts of several dollars a barrel to Dated Brent. Russian crude, by comparison, is being offered at about a $2 premium to the benchmark, making purchases from India's biggest supplier uneconomical, the traders said, asking not to be named discussing commercially sensitive information.

"Cargoes from Russia have significantly reduced due to their commercial viability" in November, state-owned refiner Bharat Petroleum Corp.'s Chief Financial Officer Vetsa Ramakrishna Gupta said on an earnings call on Monday.

Russia still is the top crude oil supplier for India. REUTERS

"Due to the increase in freight, we are not getting good offers from Russia."

The shift extends beyond Iraq. Saudi Aramco's trading arm recently sold some prompt-loading Khafji crude at discounts of as much as $10 a barrel to the Dubai benchmark, while Abu Dhabi National Oil Co. sold about 20 million barrels of crude earlier this month at a small discount.

The reversal is reshaping India's crude trade almost eight months into the war. It threatens to unwind trade patterns established after Russia's invasion of Ukraine, when India emerged as a crucial buyer of Moscow's barrels as European customers pulled back.

Oil flows from the Middle East have recovered to near prewar levels despite the recent increase in attacks on ships, as the economies heavily dependent on crude revenue push to keep exports moving. Meanwhile, Russian shipments are dwindling, while soaring freight rates have made the longer journey to buyers such as India increasingly costly.

Gulf producers struggling to move their crude are offering discounts deep enough to offset the "astronomical" freight rates, Hindustan Petroleum Corp. Chairman Vikas Kaushal told analysts on Friday.

Russia remains the top crude oil supplier for India, but the changing economics are eroding its share. Bharat Petroleum sharply cut purchases from Moscow in October because the crude was no longer economical, according to the traders.

India, US fine-tuning trade deal: Goyal

Utpal Bhaskar
utpal.b@livemint.com
THE HAGUE

India and the US have concluded most discussions on the proposed trade agreement and are fine-tuning the deal, Union commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

"In the last four and a half years, friends, we have entered into nine free trade agreements or bilateral trade agreements. I'm adding the US in that, we have concluded most of the discussions and are fine-tuning the agreement," Goyal said at the India-Netherlands Business Forum in The Hague.

For Indian exporters, a deal could provide greater predictability in pricing US-bound shipments and negotiating contracts. Any boost to exports would also offer timely support to an economy grappling with the fallout from the wars in West Asia and Ukraine.

Goyal's remarks follow a recent visit to India by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who said the two countries were "very, very close" to a trade agreement, with a small number of issues remaining to be resolved.

Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal. BLOOMBERG

"We're very, very close. I would say we're about as close as you can be without (inaudible) agreement. I think there's a small number of items to wrap up, so I think that will happen shortly," Rubio had said.

The proposed agreement comes as global supply chains face disruption from the wars in West Asia and Ukraine

Goyal said India's expanding network of trade agreements, including those under negotiation, would give it preferential access to economies accounting for $85 trillion of the $115 trillion global GDP.

"Just to give you the context of India thinking on opening our doors. Until 2014, all the free trade agreements put together opened a GDP of $10 trillion where we had preferential access or where we opened our doors to those countries," said Goyal, who is on an official visit to the Netherlands.

"India would have opened its doors and had preferential market access to an additional $60 trillion worth of economies around the globe. Together, now we have $70 trillion of economies where we would have preferential trade agreements. I have eight more negotiations which are underway right now which will add another $15 trillion. So India would be opening its doors to $85 trillion out of $115 trillion. That's around 76% of global GDP with which we are building our partnership, opening the doors on a complementary and cooperative nature to greater business engagement," Goyal said.

Bilateral trade between India and the US rose to $140.76 billion in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), from $132.2 billion in the previous year. India's trade surplus narrowed to $33.9 billion from $40.9 billion. Exports to the US edged up to $87.31 billion from $86.51 billion, while imports rose to $53.45 billion from $45.62 billion.

The proposed agreement comes as global supply chains face disruption amid wars in West Asia and Ukraine, and a broader global slowdown.

Ramita Mishra contributed to the story.

The writer is in The Hague as the guest of Confederation of Indian Industry.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

MINT SHORTS

Oil prices ease on hopes of Gulf conflict de-escalation

New Delhi: Oil prices fell on Monday after surging last week to near six-month highs, amid hopes of easing US-Iran hostilities, but persistent attacks on key producer Saudi Arabia kept investors wary. US West Texas Intermediate crude futures were down $1.76, or 1.7%, at $101.51 a barrel. Brent crude futures were down $1.49, or 1.28%, at $115.23. REUTERS

AFP

India to extend duty-free cotton imports by two months

New Delhi: India is expected to extend duty-free cotton imports for another two months through December, three sources said, in a move that could cut costs for textile mills, curb domestic prices and boost imports from the US, Brazil and Australia. India had waived 11% customs duty on cotton for five months from 1 June to 31 October to boost supplies during the lean season. PTI

I-T dept nudges taxpayers to disclose overseas properties

New Delhi: The income tax department has nudged select taxpayers who invested in residential and commercial properties in the United Arab Emirates to disclose their overseas assets under a one-time compliance scheme, a senior government official said.The move comes ahead of the 31 December deadline for the Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers – Disclosure Scheme, 2026 for eligible taxpayers to disclose specified foreign assets and income not reported. DHIRENDRA KUMAR

ISTOCKPHOTO

Govt committed to reduce fiscal deficit: Sitharaman

PTI

Tiruchirappalli: Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said the Centre is committed to reducing the fiscal deficit, as evidenced by the annual budgets, stressing that the national debt will be limited to 50% of the GDP by 2030. Addressing concerns about the national debt, she said that since the post-pandemic period, every nation has faced debt challenges. PTI

In-principle approval to $22 bn worth military purchases

PTI

New Delhi: India's Defence Acquisition Council on Monday cleared in principle arms and equipment deals worth ₹2.12 trillion ($22.27 billion), the defence ministry said. Approval was given to buy very short-range air defence systems, counter-drone systems, surveillance and strike systems, and long-range kamikaze drones. REUTERS

Centre extends risk cover for exporters until March 2027

New Delhi: The Centre has extended a scheme offering risk coverage to exporters facing higher shipping and insurance costs amid geopolitical disruptions in West Asia up to March 31, 2027, the Department of Commerce said. The scheme offers eligible exporters 95% risk cover and protection against insurance premium hikes. PTI

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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MINT SHORTS

Meta launches $35 billion stock offering to fund AI expansion

Meta Platforms on Monday launched public offerings of about $35 billion in common stock and convertible preferred stock, as the Facebook parent seeks to finance its costly AI expansion. It also announced plans to launch a separate at-the-market share sale program of up to $60 billion after its new non-voting Class C shares begin trading, which is expected in the first quarter of 2027. The fundraising plans come as Meta ramps up spending on data centers, computing capacity and AI products to compete with rival AI heavyweights OpenAI and Anthropic. **REUTERS**

Paytm Q2 net profit rises over 10X to ₹225 cr, revenue up 28%

REUTERS

New Delhi: One 97 Communications Ltd, the parent company that operates Paytm, reported an over 10-fold rise in profit after tax to ₹225 crore in the September quarter (Q2FY27), from ₹21 crore a year ago, on a reported basis, marking its sixth consecutive profitable quarter. Operating revenue rose 28% year-on year to ₹2,648 crore, driven by sustained momentum across merchant and consumer businesses, expanded monetisation and AI adoption. **PTI**

Backdoor attacks on Indian SMB systems jump 52% in H1 2026

New Delhi: Backdoor malware attacks on systems of Indian small and medium businesses (SMBs) rose 52.1% year-on-year in the first half of 2026, according to cybersecurity firm Kaspersky. Kaspersky Security Network data showed 452,000 backdoors were detected between January and June, up from 297,000 in H12025 and 408,000 in H22025. A 'backdoor' lets attackers bypass authentication and secretly return to steal data or launch further attacks. **PTI**

Verizon signs more than $2 billion AI infrastructure deal with AWS

Verizon raised its annual forecast for wireless subscriber additions on Monday, betting on strong demand for its simplified plans, and signed an AI infrastructure deal worth more than $2 billion with Amazon Web Services. For Q3, it reported nearly double the analysts' estimate for gains in monthly-bill paying wireless subscribers at 406,000, against Visible Alpha expectations of 209,439. **REUTERS**

L Catterton shops for AI future with Glance

The personal shopping platform is backed by global tech firm InMobi

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BENGALURU

L Catterton's strategic investment reflects conviction in Glance's potential to help shape the future of shopping. ISTOCKPHOTO

US-based L Catterton has announced a strategic investment in Glance, an AI-powered personal shopping platform backed by global technology company InMobi, the companies said in a statement on Monday.

The investment reflects L Catterton's conviction in Glance's potential to help shape the future of shopping as artificial intelligence (AI) transforms how consumers discover and purchase products. The capital infusion also builds on Glance's deep research into evolving consumer behaviors and preferences, including the growing role of AI in product discovery, consideration, and purchasing.

"Agentic commerce is fundamentally changing how consumers discover and shop, creating significant opportunities for brands that can make the journey more personal, intuitive, and engaging," said Scott Dahnke, global CEO of L Catterton. "Glance is uniquely positioned to capitalize on this evolution, combining a differentiated consumer proposition with broad distribution across the screens where people spend their time."

With the technology and reach to make shopping more intuitive, visual, and engaging, the Bengaluru-based Glance is well-positioned to capitalize on these changes. L Catterton, a consumer-focused investment firm, will leverage its deep consumer and category expertise, operating capabilities, and global network to support the company's continued expansion, with a particular focus on the US.

Founded in 2019 by Naveen Tewari, Abhay Singhal, Mohit Saxena, and Piyush Shah, Glance is powered by proprietary agentic intelligence and generative AI and delivers a hyper-personalized consumer experience. It is owned and operated by Glance InMobi Pte. Ltd, a subsidiary of InMobi Technology Services Pte. Ltd, and is backed by Mithril Capital, Google and Jio Platforms.

"Their (L Catterton) decision to back Glance is a validation of the shopping model we've created and our belief that the future of commerce will move beyond search toward agentic shopping," said Tewari, CEO of InMobi and Glance.

Glance has created a more personal way to shop by bringing the experience of a personal shopper directly to the devices consumers already use. Using agentic AI technology, it can understand consumers' interests and preferences and introduce them to relevant products. The platform is integrated across smartphones, connected TVs and other digital environments, allowing consumers to move naturally from inspiration to discovery and purchase. Glance is available on millions of devices across the US through its partnerships with Samsung, Motorola and DIRECTV. These partnerships extend its personalized approach to commerce across moments when consumers engage with content throughout the day.

REINVENTING RETAIL

GLANCE bets on AI agentic commerce to reshape product discovery and shopping experience

IT brings shopping across smartphones, connected TVs and other digital environments

GLANCE reaches millions of devices across US through partnerships with Samsung, Motorola

Founded in 1989, L Catterton manages about $40 billion of equity capital across multiproduct platforms dedicated to private equity, credit and real estate. Its funds invest $5 million-$5 billion in well-positioned consumer businesses. With a team of over 200 professionals across 18 offices, L Catterton has made over 300 investments in some of the most iconic consumer brands.

Anthropic files for potentially the biggest IPO ever

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The filing sets up Anthropic for a Wall Street debut next month. REUTERS

Artificial intelligence giant Anthropic filed papers Monday for what could be the biggest initial public offering (IPO) of stock ever even as its top executive warns that advanced AI could pose an existential threat to humanity.

The filing sets up the San Francisco company for a Wall Street debut next month, potentially eclipsing the SpaceX initial public offering in June that raised a record $86 billion. An Anthropic IPO would also put the company ahead of OpenAI in going public in what is expected to be a pair of blockbuster stock debuts for the rival AI labs.

The filing comes weeks after CEO Dario Amodei argued in an essay for slowing the development of the most advanced AI models. An IPO could provide Anthropic with enormous resources to accelerate its expansion. The amount the company ultimately raises remains uncertain, as do its final valuation and offering price, but even at lower estimates, it would turn the five-year-old startup into one of the world's most valuable companies and potentially boost the wealth of Amodei and his sister and co-founder, Daniela, by billions of dollars.

The filing comes weeks after CEO Amodei argued for slowing the development of most-advanced AI models

The 335-page document showed Anthropic's revenue is growing rapidly, but like many other tech companies going public, it has yet to turn a profit. The company behind the chatbot Claude reported a net loss of $80.7 billion in the first half of 2026, though its losses after taking out certain items were a fraction of that. In the same period a year ago, Anthropic lost $13 billion.

Despite the losses, Anthropic is reportedly set to see that value rise to $1.5 trillion or possibly $2 trillion, although its final valuation has not been established. At $1.5 trillion, Anthropic would rank among the world's most valuable public companies, alongside Tesla.

As for money raised, the offering could bring in as much as $100 billion, according to reports, surpassing the current record set by one of Elon Musk's companies, SpaceX, earlier this year. In a regulatory filing, Anthropic said it will list its stock on the Nasdaq Global Select Market under the ticker symbol "ANT".

In the filing, the company said it could use some of that money on acquiring other businesses and technology as well as investing in infrastructure to grow its business to take on rivals.

Advertisers embrace AI for a festive campaign sparkle

Neethi Lisa Rojan &
Rudrani Chattopadhyay
MUMBAI

Despite efficiency gains, advertisers say creative quality and consumer connect remain key to a campaign's success. HT

This year's festive season is emerging as a key moment for the adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) in Indian advertising, with brands increasingly using the technology to produce campaign assets, test creative ideas and tailor messages to different audiences.

The shift is being driven by the need to save time and costs during the busiest period for shopping and gifting. Advertising executives say AI allows brands to create multiple versions of a campaign without the expense of repeated studio shoots or the time-consuming production processes.

Festive advertising accounts for 34–35% of India's annual advertising costs, estimated at ₹60,000–62,000 crore, says Datum Intelligence. Companies across segments, including Oppo, SBI Life Insurance, Haier and Eastern by Orkla India, used AI-generated ads in the wedding season. AI is emerging as an alternative to big budget productions that brands have traditionally relied on during the festive period.

Campaigns during festivals account for 34–35% of India's annual advertisement expenditure of about ₹62,000 cr

A traditional 30- to 90-second television commercial can cost ₹50 lakh or more, depending on its production requirements. "AI-generated advertising can cost a fraction of traditional production, although actual savings depend on the script, complexity and quality expected," said Preetham Venkky, chief digital officer, Omnicom Advertising India.

"The induction of AI is no longer a matter of choice. It is almost the norm," said Sandeep Goyal, chairman of Rediffusion. He said advances in AI-generated imagery and video have made it increasingly difficult for consumers to distinguish AI-generated advertisements from conventionally filmed ones.

Artificial intelligence is also influencing marketing budgets. Instead of spending heavily on a single production, companies can create multiple variations and spend more on other initiatives.

"By bringing AI into early script ideation, packaging visualization and copy adaptations, we compressed weeks of back-and-forth into just a few days," said Arvind Mediratta, founder and chief executive of FreshTerra, a food and grocery retail brand.

FreshTerra has redirected the savings from reduced spending on physical samples and early design iterations towards in-store experiences, its direct-from-farmer supply chain and local visibility, Mediratta said.

Ferns N Petals (FNP), the online gifting and floral retailer, has also adopted a combination of human and AI-led production. "Our speed of creative execution has increased by nearly 4X, allowing us to develop, test and deploy a much larger volume of creatives in a fraction of the time," Avi Kumar, the chief marketing officer, said.

FNP has seen better click-through rates—the share of people who click on an advertisement after seeing it—while return on advertising spend has remained broadly stable.

Beauty brand RENÉE Cosmetics has reported higher engagement and lower production time for its AI-generated advertisements. "In our campaigns, AI-generated ads have delivered 30.16% higher engagement rates compared with conventional creatives, while helping reduce production time by an estimated 70–80%," Priyank Shah, co-founder of RENÉE Cosmetics, said.

The company also reported a 10–20% reduction in cost per result—the cost of achieving a desired outcome, such as a click or purchase—in campaigns where the data supported such a range, Shah said.

The figures suggest potential gains in both creative output and cost efficiency, although results could vary across campaigns.

Still, advertising executives caution against treating AI as a substitute for creative judgment. Consumers may respond to an advertisement because of its story and relevance, rather than the technology used to produce it.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Sembcorp to gauge demand for $394 mn India IPO

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Singapore-based Sembcorp Industries Ltd. is meeting investors for a proposed initial public offering of its Indian unit, Sembcorp Green Infra Ltd., that could raise as much as $394 million, according to people familiar with the matter.

The Temasek Holdings Pte.-backed renewable energy company is considering an IPO launch as early as December, the people said, asking not to be identified because the information is private.

Sembcorp Green Infra filed draft papers in August for an IPO comprising a fresh issue of shares worth of ₹37.5 billion ($394 million) and is awaiting regulatory approval. Deliberations are ongoing and details of the offering, including timing and size, may change, they said. Sembcorp representative didn't immediately respond to requests for comment.

Sembcorp is working with Axis Capital Ltd., Citigroup Inc., CLSA, HSBC Holdings Plc, ICICI Securities Ltd., IIFL Capital Services Ltd. and Kotak Mahindra Capital Co., the people said.

India's primary market is gathering momentum with the record IPO of Jio Platforms Ltd., which was subscribed more than 22 times last week. Several companies are preparing to tap the market over the next two months. IPOs in the country have raised nearly $18 billion this year, putting the market on course to challenge last year's record of about $22.4 billion. Sembcorp Green Infra is among India's 10 largest renewable independent power producers by operational capacity as of 31 March, according to its IPO draft.

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73,606.75	72,514.57	22,753.20	22,387.35	21,608.75	21,191.20	66,477.15	64,999.15	23,637.10	23,231.00	15,321.61	14,963.47	6,510.17	6,346.52

Why Kotak may trail large peers

Manish Joshi
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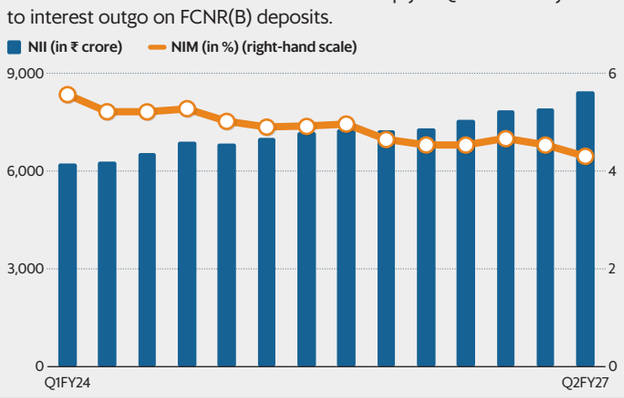
Kotak Mahindra Bank's standalone loan book grew 19% year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹5.5 trillion, excluding the twin impact of the acquisition of Kotak Mahindra Investments' loan portfolio and loans against FCNR(B) deposits worth ₹16,110 crore.

Kotak Bank took over Kotak Mahindra Investments' loan portfolio of nearly ₹9,600 crore at the beginning of Q2 to comply with the Reserve Bank of India's directions requiring the elimination of overlapping, non-specialized lending structures within a banking group. Since only the advances of Kotak Mahindra Investments were transferred to Kotak Bank, and not the liabilities, the bank is likely to have earned interest income of ₹200 crore. Adjusting for this, net interest income (NII) growth would be 13% y-o-y, versus 15.7%.

Kotak Bank's net interest margin (NIM) for Q2 was 4.31%, down 22 basis points (bps) sequentially, with FCNR(B)-related funds accounting for the bulk of the decline at 15 bps. The balance was due to quarter-specific day-count variation, as Kotak Bank reports NIM based on the number of days rather than number of months. Core pre-provisioning operating profit (PPoP) growth was robust at 20% y-o-y to ₹6,115 crore, attributable to a 21% increase in fee and service income to ₹2,926 crore.

Temporary pain

Kotak Mahindra Bank's NIM has come off sharply in Q2FY27 mainly due to interest outgo on FCNR(B) deposits.



NII is net interest income; NIM is net interest margin
Source: Company

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

The bank declined to provide guidance for NIM in Q3. However, the full impact of FCNR(B) deposits could exert significant downward pressure on margins, as 45% of incremental deposits in Q2 came from this source. Reported deposit growth was 23% y-o-y, but would have been much lower, at 13%, excluding FCNR(B) deposits. To be sure, some of the adverse impact on NIM may be eased, albeit to a smaller extent, by the recent 25 bps hike in repo rate. Kotak Bank's loan book is nearly 65-70% floating-rate, with most of it linked to the repo rate.

The near-term credit-cost outlook is positive, as fresh slippages, or additions to gross non-performing assets (NPAs), fell 25% year-on-year and 7% quarter-on-quarter to ₹1,230 crore in Q2.

However, the long-term outlook appears challenging. Bank management has indicated that credit costs could rise by 12-15 bps as a percentage of advances once expected credit loss (ECL)-based provisioning norms come into effect from FY28. Based on a likely loan book of nearly ₹6 trillion at the end of FY28, the estimated incremental credit cost could be ₹720-900 crore for the year. This could pull down net profit growth. It should be noted that higher credit costs under ECL are likely to be industry-wide, rather than specific to Kotak Bank.

RETURNS RACE

KOTAK BANK trails ICICI and HDFC on RoE despite a healthy Q2FY27 performance

ITS Q2 RoE was 11.6%, trailing ICICI's 16.6% and HDFC's 13.5%, despite their larger asset bases

Despite its healthy Q2FY27 performance, Kotak Bank continues to trail ICICI Bank and HDFC Bank on return on equity (RoE). Kotak Bank's reported RoE was 11.6% in Q2, versus 16.6% for ICICI Bank and 13.5% for HDFC Bank, despite the latter two having larger asset bases.

Relative to its RoE, Kotak's valuation appears rich compared with those of its two larger rivals. The bank trades at a price-to-earnings multiple of 15.3, based on Motilal Oswal Financial Services' earnings estimates for FY27, versus 13 for ICICI Bank and 10 for HDFC Bank, after adjusting for the valuation of their respective subsidiaries.

Kotak will have to improve its performance and RoE considerably over the long term to justify its valuation premium over rivals.

Ather hits profit milestone ahead of EV two-wheeler cos

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Ather Energy is seeing a rapid rise in its sales. AFP

Ather Energy Ltd became the first electric two-wheeler company in India to report a quarterly profit after a rapid rise in sales, increasing average sales price and better cost savings.

Bengaluru-based Ather recorded a profit after tax of ₹1.26 crore in the July to September quarter as against a loss of ₹154 crore in the year-ago period. Revenue surged 63% to ₹1,526 crore.

Sales rose 42% to 93,211 units, with the Tarun Mehta-led firm facing a surge in orders and ramping up average monthly supplies to 33,000 units from 28,000 in the preceding quarter. The 13-year-old firm, is expanding capacity, increasing network and scaling up its latest model Konarc in a bid to double down on growth in the market.

The sales ramp-up has established Ather as the third-largest electric scooter maker, and, together with its first profit, has put it ahead of cross-town rival Ola Electric, which is plagued by stagnant sales and continued losses. Ather's larger rivals by market share are legacy manufacturers TVS Motor and Bajaj Auto.

Ather is turning its focus to expanding capacity, increasing its network and scaling up Konarc

Mehta, co-founder and chief executive officer at Ather, told analysts on an earnings call on Monday that Ather is not out of the woods even after turning net profitable for the first time.

"PAT (profit after tax) is not the first thing to focus on. The real thing to focus on is top line and improving volumes will itself take care of a lot of things," Mehta said. "If that and if all the capacity work that we're putting in bears fruit well over the next few months, then I believe that PAT will take care of itself," Mehta said.

The net profit came after Ather became the first new-age electric two-wheeler company to report a breakeven on Ebitda. Its Ebitda margin came in at 0.8% in the June quarter, an over 16-percentage-point improvement from -15.7% a year ago. In the September quarter, Ather's Ebitda margin was 4.9% from -9.6% a year earlier, a growth of 14 percentage points despite commodity price increases.

The company's shares surged 14.1% to ₹1,575 at close on the National Stock Exchange on Monday after the results were announced during market hours. The Nifty Auto index increased 0.44%. The break-even on overall profitability came almost after a year and a half since Ather went public in May 2025, with its shares having delivered a 5.25-fold increase.

Mehta has ruled out further price hikes to protect demand for Ather's models.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Tata Motors' Q2 gains driven by volumes, but costs loom

Pratik Solanki
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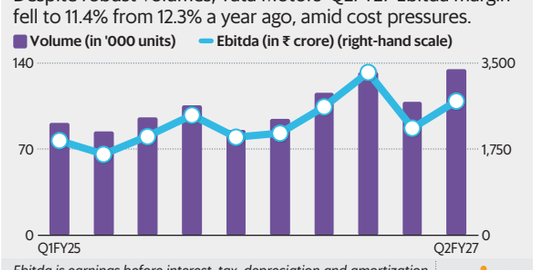
A sharp surge in sales volumes brought comfort to Tata Motors Ltd (TMCV) in Q2FY27. Standalone revenue increased by 42% year-on-year (y-o-y) on a softer base, to ₹23,930 crore, aided by 43% total wholesale volume growth to 135,114 vehicles. International volumes grew faster at 177% to 21,132 units. TMCV's realization fell marginally y-o-y as improved domestic pricing was offset by a heavier export mix of low-priced LCV and SCV.

Overall HI volume growth is at 35%. In general, demand for CVs is aided by higher infra spending, strong freight movement, replacement demand of older trucks and buses, and logistics fleet expansion. TMCV retained market leadership in CVs, with a 36.2% domestic share in HI, up 110 basis points (bps) from FY26. TMCV management remains optimistic about near-term demand prospects, but expects volume growth rates to moderate in H2 against a higher base.

Besides, the sharp rise in steel and rubber costs poses trouble for profit margins. In its Q2 earnings call, management said there has been a commodity cost impact of almost 540 bps y-o-y, and 200 bps sequentially. "We expect a further commodity cost increase in Q3 in the range of around 150 to 200 bps, depending upon where some of the major commodities settle," management said.

A speed breaker

Despite robust volumes, Tata Motors' Q2FY27 Ebitda margin fell to 11.4% from 12.3% a year ago, amid cost pressures.



Ebitda is earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization
Source: Company, Systematix Research

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

While the company has raised prices four times in FY27, those increases haven't been enough to cover the commodity price increases. In Q2, higher volumes, price hikes, and operating leverage prevented a larger hit to Ebitda margin, which fell 94 bps y-o-y to 11.4% and was flattish sequentially. Margin protection ahead could depend more on cost savings and calibrated pricing.

Further commodity inflation and shifting interest rates (RBI recently raised the repo rate to 5.50%) remain key headwinds for TMCV. Emkay Global Financial Services has trimmed its earnings-per-share (EPS) estimates for FY27, FY28, and FY29 by 6%, 9%, and 11%. The brokerage cut EV/Ebitda valuation multiple from 14 to 12, noting that the growth surge following last year's GST cuts has passed.

Meanwhile, Tata Motors' proposed acquisition of Iveco could stretch its cash resources, while potential delays in completing the deal or realizing synergies could weigh on near-term earnings. TMCV shares fell 3% on Monday.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Three challenges facing HDFC's new CEO

Subhana Shaikh
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MUMBAI

When Anup Bagchi takes charge as managing director and chief executive of HDFC Bank on 27 October, he will inherit an institution with a robust balance sheet that also faces questions over its reputation, leadership continuity and market perception.

The incoming chief, who has already begun engaging with customers, regulators and stakeholders, faces the challenge of rebuilding confidence after a series of controversies, preventing further departures from senior management and reviving the growth engines that once distinguished India's largest private-sector bank.

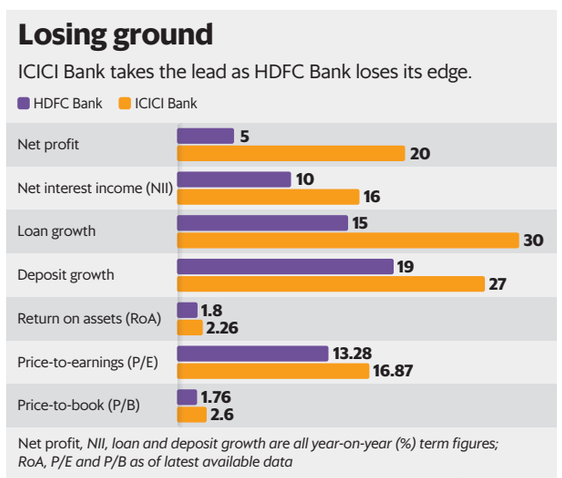
The urgency is evident in the bank's market performance. So far this fiscal year (FY27), HDFC Bank's shares have fallen by 6%. In FY26, the stock was down by 16%, *Bloomberg* data showed. On Monday, the stock ended 0.6% lower at ₹688.20 apiece.

The bank's valuation premium over peers has also narrowed. As of Monday, the lender traded at 13.28 times trailing earnings and 1.76 times book value, compared with 16.87 times earnings and 2.60 times book value for ICICI Bank, and 10.22 times earnings and 1.50 times book value for State Bank of India, according to Value Research.

The bank has faced a series of controversies, including allegations of the mis-selling of Credit Suisse additional tier-I (AT1) bonds, questions about the handling of a bulk depositor's account, and an internal investigation into the alleged leakage of confidential information by two executives. The abrupt departure of former chairman Atanu Chakraborty in March added to concerns about governance and internal differences.

Losing ground

ICICI Bank takes the lead as HDFC Bank loses its edge.



Net profit, NII, loan and deposit growth are all year-on-year (%) term figures; RoA, P/E and P/B as of latest available data

Source: Respective results and Value Research

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Anup Bagchi takes charge as HDFC Bank CEO today. MINT

Rebuilding confidence must be the immediate priority, said Karan Gupta, financial sector ratings head at India Ratings and Research.

For Nirav Shah, MD and CEO of Equirus Capital, the task goes beyond financial performance. HDFC Bank has historically commanded a premium over its peers, built on its reputation for consistency, governance and execution.

"Sometimes it is also about non-financial metrics like how people perceive you as a bank," Shah said. "Rebuilding the whole premiumness of the bank is where it's going to be very important."

Shah said domestic institutions continue to view the lender as a strong and solid franchise, but foreign investors have lost some confidence.

FIIs have also reduced their exposure, with their shareholding down to 39% in the September quarter from 42% in June, according to recent shareholding data.

Bagchi's transition comes amid a reshuffle at the top. Another key priority for him will be to stem employee attrition. Deputy managing director Kaizad Bharucha, one of the bank's longest-serving executives, is set to step down on 31 December, while former CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan's tenure ends on 26 October.

Shah believes the bank could benefit from bringing in experienced external leaders to complement its traditionally homegrown talent, while developing the next generation of internal leadership.

The third challenge is operational, which is restoring HDFC Bank's competitive edge in retail lending, low-cost deposits and profitability following its merger with Housing Development Finance Corp. in 2023.

HDFC Bank, which historically outperformed private-sector peers on loan growth and returns, now stands closer to the industry average. For the September quarter, net profit rose 5% year-on-year to ₹19,510 crore, while the net interest margin declined to 3.16% from 3.26% a quarter ago, and the current account and savings account (CASA) ratio also slipped to 31.6%.

Bagchi has described HDFC Bank as a "very process-driven institution" and said he would work alongside its team to take it forward. However, the real test will be whether he can translate that institutional strength into renewed confidence, leadership continuity and sustained growth.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

How Sebi's relaxed margin rules will help

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The relaxation could benefit smaller brokers, who may have limited funds or clearing limits to support clients. REUTERS

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has relaxed margin rules for investors who use proceeds from share sales to buy other stocks on the same day. The new rules aim to reduce brokers' upfront funding burden when investors use proceeds from shares sold through the early pay-in (EPI) mechanism.

Mint explains the changes and whether they will benefit brokers.

What are the changes?

In a circular on 22 October, the market regulator eased margin requirements for trades made using proceeds from shares sold through the EPI mechanism. EPI allows investors to transfer shares to the clearing corporation before the usual settlement deadline. Once the clearing corporation accepts the transfer request, the value of those shares can be considered for meeting certain margin requirements.

Under the new rules, clearing corporations will not collect additional margins from trading or clearing members on a client's subsequent buy or sell positions, up to the value of the accepted EPI.

The eligible amount will be the lower of the EPI value or the value of the shares sold. If an investor closes the original sale position, the EPI benefit will be withdrawn.

Any resulting margin shortfall can then be blocked from the broker's own collateral. The new rules will take effect on 22 February 2027, four months after the circular was issued.

Why were the changes needed?

The changes address a gap in the existing margin framework. When an investor sells shares held in a demat account and completes EPI, the clearing corporation receives the shares early. This reduces the risk of settlement failure and allows the margin requirement for the sale to be released.

However, if the investor uses the sale proceeds to buy another stock on the same day, the broker may still have to arrange the required upfront margin for the purchase. This can be around 20%, depending on the stock and applicable requirements.

For example, if an investor sells shares worth ₹100 and uses the proceeds to buy another stock, the broker may have to set aside ₹20 from its own trading limits to meet the margin requirement. This creates a funding burden.

The change follows proposals from the Broker Industry Standards Forum and recommendations from Sebi's Risk Management Review Committee (RMRC).

It aims to make better use of the value of shares already transferred for settlement, while retaining safeguards against margin shortfalls.

Will the changes help brokers?

The relaxation could benefit smaller brokers, who may have limited funds or clearing limits to support clients.

Under the existing framework, brokers with greater financial resources have generally been better placed to offer same-day trading facilities. Smaller brokers may find it difficult to meet the margin requirements on new purchases.

By reducing the need to provide additional margins for eligible trades, the new rules could help more brokers offer the facility. Investors may also be able to use their sale proceeds more efficiently instead of waiting for the next settlement day.

The change builds on the EPI framework revision in October 2024. Before that revision, investors could generally use 80% of their sale proceeds on the trade day, with the remaining 20% becoming available after settlement on the following day.

How will the new rules affect cash markets?

The new rules will support participation in the cash market by making it easier for investors to move their funds between stocks on the same day.

Lower margin requirements on eligible trades may help brokers serve more clients without having to commit as much of their own collateral.

The move comes amid a decline in cash-market activity. Average daily cash-market turnover on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) fell about 7% to ₹1.05 trillion in FY26 from ₹1.13 trillion in FY25.

The relaxation could make same-day trading more accessible.

However, its impact on turnover will depend on how widely brokers adopt the facility and how investors respond. The changes do not guarantee a recovery in trading activity.

EXPLAINER

Tata bets $450 mn on data centre connectivity boom

The company is looking to tap demand for fast, reliable connectivity between these facilities

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Tata Communications Ltd on Monday said it will invest $400-450 million (around ₹4,350 crore) over the next three to five years to build a 10,000-km high-speed fibre network linking major data centre hubs across India, as it seeks to tap rising demand for connectivity driven by artificial intelligence (AI) and cloud computing

The network, which the company calls an 'AI super highway', will add 6 petabits per second (Pbps) of capacity between fiscal year 2030 (FY30) and (FY36). Tata Communications estimates that data centre-to-data centre connectivity could represent a market opportunity of more than $1 billion over the medium term.

India's operational data centre capacity reached nearly 1.8GW in the first half of 2026, with another 3.86GW under construction or in the pipeline by 2030, according to real estate services firm Cushman & Wakefield.

The company is looking to tap rising demand from cloud adoption, AI deployment, data localization requirements, and growing enterprise demand for high-capacity digital infrastructure, through this 'AI super highway', which it claims to be one of the country's largest AI-ready connectivity network.

"From a business case perspective, it (monetization) would be any industry benchmark 15 to 20% return on investment. As we bring capacity online, we will start to deliver revenues, so you start to kind of get that return," Rupesh Chokshi, chief product and technology officer and executive vice-president & global business head, network services, Tata Communications, told *Mint*.

"We plan to fund it (the investment) from Tata Communications operating cash flows," Chokshi said, adding that the company will have a first-mover advantage in data centre-to-data centre connectivity across the country as others are either focusing on creating more data centre capacities or on covering smaller locations in terms of connectivity.

According to its exchange filing, the company has existing network capacity of 1.25 petabits per second with 70-80% utilization rate.

Shares of Tata Communications closed 1.6% higher at ₹1,680 apiece on the BSE on Monday.

The first phase, expected to go live over the next three years, will connect the Mumbai-Pune-Hyderabad-Chennai corridor, a key growth route for AI and hyperscalers. Subsequent phases will extend the network to emerging data centre hubs along India's eastern and western coasts, including Vizag, Bhubaneswar, Jamnagar and GIFT City.

Tata Communications will also link the AI corridors and data centre clusters with its international cable landing stations, enabling links between India's data centres and global AI hubs.

According to Chokshi, businesses need to keep backup copies of their data at multiple locations, while AI applications require large volumes of data to move quickly between computing facilities. Delays in this movement can affect the efficiency of AI systems, as well as the performance of services such as gaming and video streaming.

Tata Communications' announcement comes as Singapore-based Lightstorm Telecom Connectivity Pvt. Ltd, which entered India seven years ago, is also expanding its data centre connectivity business.

The competition is also heating up in the data centre business, with companies such as Airtel's Nxtra, Google, Adani, Reliance Industries committing significant investments. By the end of the first half of 2026, cumulative investment commitments in India's data centre sector since 2021 had reached approximately $173 billion, including around $38 billion in the first six months of 2026, according to real estate services and investment firm CBRE.

Mumbai remained the country's largest market, accounting for 52% of operational stock, the CBRE report said.

On demand for data centre connectivity, Chokshi said the company has an existing order book, with demand coming largely from global customers. A growing share of its expansion is being driven by commitments from anchor customers and contracted demand, the company said in a release on Monday. In India, the company has over 80,000 km of terrestrial fibre, 30,000 km of metro fibre, with connectivity to 118 data centres.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

India's operational data centre capacity reached 1.8GW in the first half of 2026, with another 3.86GW planned by 2030. REUTERS

DATA HIGHWAY

THE company has existing network capacity of 1.25 Pbps with 70-80% utilization rate

THE company will link Indian data centres to global AI hubs via international cables

THE first phase, due in three years, will link the Mumbai-Pune-Hyderabad-Chennai corridor

SHARES of Tata Communications closed 1.6% higher at ₹1,680 apiece on the BSE on Monday

Hyundai launches Bayon SUV, targets higher segment sales

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Hyundai Motor India Ltd on Monday launched the Bayon, its first new car in three years, as it seeks boost annual mid-size port utility vehicle (SUV) sales to 250,000 units from about 170,000 over the next 12 months, building on the success of its best-selling Creta.

The Korean carmaker aims to regain ground against Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd and Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd, which have overtaken it in India's passenger vehicle market.

Hyundai plans to introduce seven new nameplates in India by 2030, with the Bayon marking the first step. The SUV will compete with the Tata Sierra, Maruti Suzuki Victoris and Grand Vitara, and Renault Duster in the crowded mid-size SUV segment.

The mid-size SUV space has become one of the most fiercely contested parts of the market as automakers seek to capture buyers moving away from hatchbacks and sedans to larger SUVs.

Hyundai plans to introduce seven new nameplates in India by 2030. REUTERS

Hyundai is betting the Bayon will complement the Creta rather than merely cannibalize its sales, helping it expand its presence in the segment.

Tarun Garg, managing director (MD) and chief executive officer (CEO) of Hyundai Motor India, told reporters ahead of the launch that the company sees enough room for both SUVs as new customer segments emerge. "We are very confident and very aggressive about our mid SUV strategy," Garg said. "Along with Creta and Bayon we are looking at a volume of over 250,000 per annum going forward."

He said the Creta had performed better than expected since its launch a decade ago, adding that the Bayon would help Hyundai cater to strong demand for mid-size SUVs.

The company is positioning the Bayon as a more technology-led product aimed at customers who adopt new technologies faster.

"This is a trend catalyst product," Virat Khullar, head of marketing at Hyundai Motor India, said, referring to the Bayon.

"We are looking at very different target groups."

Starting at ₹9.99 lakh, the Bayon comes with features such as an in-built generative artificial intelligence voice assistant and other connected technologies. Hyundai is offering a 115 PS petrol engine, while a CNG powertrain is planned for January.

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Cracking vaccines with PopVax

The five-year-old startup is staring at a wide, ambitious pipeline of first-in-class drugs that it hopes to accelerate to clinical trials

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PopVax's Hyderabad lab hums with activity as about 100 computer scientists, molecular biologists, immunologists and engineers work on everything from computational design, machine learning and robotics to wet-lab testing of mRNA vaccines and even manufacturing clinical doses for testing.

mRNA vaccines instruct cells to make a harmless viral protein, training the immune system without injecting any form of the virus.

Wet-lab testing involves researchers conducting physical experiments with a variety of substances.

PopVax recently took its first vaccine candidate—a fridge-stable, broad-spectrum covid vaccine that could help ease cold-chain concerns in developing countries—into human trials.

mint LAB RATS

It plans to make the vaccine open-source after phase 1 trials. "Our gift to the world," said 30-year-old Soham Sankaran, founder and chief executive officer (CEO) of the biotech startup.

The five-year-old startup, which grew from two people in a 100 sq. ft shared lab at the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology (CCMB) to its existing 10,000 sq. ft facility, is staring at a wide, ambitious pipeline of first-in-class drugs that it hopes to accelerate to clinical trials.

In drug development, phase 1 trials are focused primarily on establishing safety, tolerability and dose range in healthy volunteers, before they can progress to phase 2, tested in a larger group of patients to see how it works while still remaining safe.

Speed, talent and funding are key to progress in drug discovery but also among the most common hurdles an Indian biotech must contend with.

Regulatory timelines are slow compared to global standards, attracting the best talent to India remains a challenge, and biotech funding in India has only just begun to sprout.

PopVax is conducting its first human trials in Australia because the clinical trial timelines there are much faster than in India. While getting approval for a phase 1 trial typically takes about 30 days in Australia, in India the timeline can stretch for months, requiring ethics committee approval and a test licence.

There has been an effort to address this through a 2026 amendment to the New Drugs and Clinical Trials (NDCT) Rules, 2019, which removes the need for test licences for certain drugs and halves the review and processing time. However, Sankaran emphasized the importance of time for a startup running on limited funding.

"It has taken us four years for us to build all this infrastructure. And subsequent programmes will be faster... We cannot wait; we will run out of money," he said.

PopVax recently took its first vaccine candidate into human trials.

PopVax's pipeline

PopVax has seven vaccines in various stages of development, including one for Hepatitis C and one for Strep A.

Programme	Status	Phase 1 timeline
Broadly protective covid-19 PVX-001 (open source)	Phase I clinical trial (ongoing)	Underway since Aug 2026
HCV vaccine	Late pre-clinical	2027
Single-dose rabies vaccine	Late pre-clinical	2027
Broadly protective influenza vaccine	Pre-clinical	2027
Adult TB vaccine	Early pre-clinical	2028
Prophylactic + therapeutic HPV vaccine	Early pre-clinical	-
Second-generation malaria vaccine	Design stage	2027
Strep A vaccine	Design stage	2028
HCC (liver cancer)	Early pre-clinical	2027
PDAC (pancreatic cancer)	Early pre-clinical	2027

Source: PopVax website

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

The pipeline

Sankaran, a computer scientist from Yale, was in India in the thick of the covid pandemic in 2021 and saw the scramble of an underprepared public healthcare system struggling to keep up with a rapidly evolving pathogen.

That's where the idea for PopVax emerged—can we make next-generation vaccines in India for India and the world? After several rejections from domestic investors, PopVax was incubated at CCMB, and received $100,000 seed funding from the Gates Foundation as well as $20 million from the Ethereum cryptocurrency co-founder Vitalik Buterin's Balvi fund for its covid candidate.

CCMB in Hyderabad functions under the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), an autonomous government body.

PopVax has seven vaccines in various stages of development, including one for hepatitis C and one for strep A.

PopVax is going beyond infectious disease with cancer immunotherapies.

The startup is working on multiple first-in-class immunotherapies against liver cancer (hepatocellular carcinoma) and pancreatic cancer (pancreatic ductal adenocarcinoma), with plans to advance them into phase 1 clinical trials next year. The goal is to develop therapeutics that are designed to provide a step-change improvement over the current standard of care for these cancers.

The long-term plan, however, is to build on its immunotherapies to create an artificial intelligence (AI)-powered pipeline to deliver personalized medicines for each patient within weeks, with the aim of making cancers 'manageable chronic conditions'.

DEVELOPING THERAPEUTICS

POPVAX grew from two people in a 100 sq. ft shared lab at CCMB to its existing 10,000 sq. ft facility

IT is conducting its first human trials in Australia because clinical trial timelines there are faster

IT is working on multiple first-in-class immunotherapies against liver and pancreatic cancer

THE firm is doubling down on sharing its ambitions online to attract global talent to work in India

Not just this, the other frontier it has ambitiously set its sights on is global biosecurity.

In August, Stanford researchers used AI to design completely new viruses. But it's not just that—today, anyone without any fundamental understanding of virology or molecular biology can use frontier AI models such as ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini to develop and release a superbug.

How do you prepare for this? In June, PopVax announced the Immune Engine, an always-on, full-stack capability to rapidly design, test and manufacture targeted therapeutics against AI-designed viruses in weeks, not years, using generative AI and its own mRNA platform.

"We view ourselves as sort of a transitional engine for turning machine intelligence into medicine," said Sankaran.

Best of the best

While PopVax's team is a mix of veterans and young graduates from top global and Indian universities as well as leading global and domestic biotech firms, attracting talent to India can still be a challenge.

"India has the blessing and the curse of scale. We have a lot of scientists...Many of them have not had the option to work on novel or exciting science in an industry context," Sankaran said.

PopVax is doubling down on sharing its work and ambitions online to attract global talent to work in India, where the biotech ecosystem and infrastructure are still nascent.

"We should do a better job of showing the rest of the world what we've been up to, and sort of giving them the opportunity to be a part of this environment," Sankaran said. "India has its disadvantages...we have to go a bit hard and say what kind of a better job is this as compared to a US startup?"

Experts believe that solving for talent must be a priority.

"From a talent point of view, first off, making India an attractive destination to come and do research—you have to look at how we can attract the right people. How do we ease the integration, the second is ease of capital availability to get started, and the third is around infra," said Vikash Agarwalla, India leader, healthcare practice, Boston Consulting Group.

To date, PopVax has raised over $30 million through research contracts and equity funding.

It is now preparing for its next round of funding in the coming months, and this time it's gunning for a larger ticket size of at least $50 million.

This is the second in a six-part *Mint* series on biotech startups.

Service charge on your food bill. Must you pay?

FROM FRONT FLAP

In January 2026, CCPA took suo motu action against 27 restaurants.

3 Why did the regulator reject the hotel's argument?

The CCPA's reasoning centres on the difference between opt-in and opt-out systems. The authority held that the latter undermines free and informed consent. According to the order, Shangri-La Eros said it was taking steps to stop collecting the charge and had refunded the complainants. It also changed the description on its invoices to "Charges for Voluntary Staff Contribution (optional)". The CCPA found that changing the terminology did not address the underlying issue: if the charge remained on the bill by default, customers would still have to act to avoid paying it.

4 Is this an isolated case or a wider crackdown?

The Shangri-La Eros case appears to be the first involving a luxury hotel. Other establishments fined include Café Blue Bottle in Patna (₹30,000), China Gate Restaurant's Bora Bora outlet in Mumbai (₹50,000), Chaayos (₹50,000 on 14 July) and Curry House CoCo Ichibanya (₹20,000 on 19 October). On 19 July, the CCPA also issued orders against Fiesta by Barbeque Nation, FOO Ahmedabad Restaurant and L'Opéra French Bakery. In January, it took suo motu action against 27 restaurants and in July against 41 restaurants following complaints to the National Consumer Helpline.

5 What do these actions mean for restaurants?

Under Section 21(7) of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, the CCPA can consider factors such as the number of consumers affected, the frequency and duration of the offence, the vulnerability of consumers and the revenue generated from the sales involved when determining a penalty in cases concerning misleading advertisements. For consumers, the ruling reinforces the right to decide whether to pay a tip or voluntary staff contribution. A restaurant cannot make payment a condition for serving customers or leave them to negotiate removal of an automatically added charge.

Indian IT companies see business in policing AI agents

FROM PAGE 1

On 8 October, TCS 's management said "strong AI governance with secure AI platforms is becoming a top need for enterprises". "I think as the enterprises are focused on safe, secure, and responsible deployment of agentic AI, they need a strong foundation to scale. So, building the AI platform, and more so this year, the agentic control plane is becoming a key layer not just in terms of governance, but in terms of cost management, really looking at agent performance and the full end-to-end agent lifecycle," said Aarthi Subramanian, chief operating officer, at a post-earnings analyst call.

"Agents inherit access rights of the application or the human who deployed them, they operate in silos tied to a single vendor's platform, and the controls that stop two agents from duplicating work or reaching into data they should never see are mostly manual," said Phil Fersht, chief executive of HFS Research.

Nasdaq-listed Cognizant launched its own software layer to manage AI on 23 October. It launched Cognizant AI Nexus, which measures AI spend, governs AI output quality and documents results across teams.

It also gave a sneak peek at the ways it governs AI use. Nexus captures the best IT processes and turns them into templates that teams and AI agents can reuse. Because the same system tracks both spending and quality, firms can see if their AI is getting cheaper, better and faster. Under this, each AI agent gets its own ID, permissions and memory, and the company decides what it can access. Every task is logged, and humans sign off on key decisions and compliance checks.

The move comes amid fears these digital workers could go rogue. AFP

While Cognizant built its own, HCLTech acquired a firm to strengthen its AI management. On 28 September, it announced intent to acquire Croatia-based Robotiq.ai to strengthen orchestration across AI agents and enterprise applications.

Tech Mahindra's management addressed "heightened concerns about security and reliability of AI agents". Trust is fundamental to scaling AI, it said. "Responsible AI is embedded throughout the solution lifecycle, with red teaming, trusted data, traceability, security, and IP provenance built into how we design, deploy, and operate AI solutions," COO Atul Soneja said at a post- earnings call on 15 October .

TCS, HCLTech and Tech Mahindra ended the September quarter with $7.64 billion, $3.72 billion, and $1.69 billion in revenue. Cognizant will announce its results on 29 October.

The rise of AI governance tools could also be attributed to the need to complete tasks assigned to an agent. "Orchestration is the next significant opportunity as the agentic AI concept has moved beyond isolated AI deployments. Just as teams need to work together to drive meaningful output, orchestrating agents to work together to complete a task is important. This will help in end-to-end scale implementations," said Namratha Dharshan, chief business leader for India research at Information Services Group. She said homegrown tech services firms are well-poised to meet demand because of their process, domain, and industry knowledge.

Fersht and Dharshan see this orchestration as a growth engine.

"This is a constantly evolving field and not a one-time activity. As more agents enter the system, continuous monitoring and improvement will be critical," said Dharshan.

Fersht said the test is if IT firms can move from reselling a hyperscaler's orchestration stack to owning a point of view on how an enterprise should govern intelligence across its whole estate."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Fund managers loosen purse strings to woo investors

FROM PAGE 1

more comfortable," he said.

The push comes as fundraising becomes concentrated in fewer, larger vehicles. In the first half of 2026, 48 funds raised $21.17 billion, more than double the $10.14 billion raised by 55 funds a year ago, as per an EY report published in September. In July, eight funds raised $2.5 billion, compared with 14 funds that raised $1.5 billion in July 2025.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) mandates a minimum sponsor or manager commitment of ₹5 crore or 2.5% of the total fund corpus, whichever is lower, across fund sizes.

LPs are passive institutional or high-net-worth investors who provide capital but leave investment decisions and active management to fund managers, known as general partners (GPs). Their financial risk is capped at the capital they have committed.

Several established and new Indian VC and PE firms are raising or plan to raise fresh funds, including ValueQuest Tristar, Waterbridge Ventures and Lightspeed India. Renuka Ramnath-led PE firm Multiples is in talks to launch its next fundraise next year, targeting $1 billion-1.2 billion, *Mint* reported last week.

The push to bring more trust comes as fundraising becomes concentrated in fewer, larger vehicles.

For established firms, capital from earlier funds can help fund commitments to other vehicles.

"With multiple fund vintages, the team's ability to put in money comes from the carry they generate in earlier vehicles. That money is then reinvested into the fund. So, the team's capacity increases over time as the number of vintages grows," said Rohit Mantri, co-head and managing director of Motilal Oswal Private Equity. "Naturally, limited partners feel more comfortable when fund managers put their money into a fund, particularly in a difficult fundraising environment."

For newer managers without an established track record, a sizable commitment can show conviction in a strategy. In September, *Mint* reported that Carnelian was raising its first dedicated PE fund of ₹2,000 crore.

In H1 of 2026, 48 funds raised $21.17 bn, more than double the $10.14 bn raised by 55 funds in the year-ago period

"We are investing over ₹100 crore of our own capital in the fund," said Umesh Agrawal, managing partner for private equity at Carnelian, adding that GP contributions usually stop at ₹15-20 crore for newer funds. *Mint* reported that the fund eyes a final close this year.

The push for larger commitments comes amid mounting concerns among LPs about fund performance and returns delay. Some PE funds have extended timelines for returning capital to investors while continuing to charge fees. "PE funds' history has been that the experience has been a mixed bag because of which there has been a pushback in the market," Agrawal said. "It (sponsor commitment) should be a big number... a number that'll hurt me if the fund doesn't do well."

Bhayana said a fund manager recently put in as much as ₹200 crore in a ₹1,700-2,000 crore fund. "A higher sponsor contribution is the fastest magnet for attracting investors," he said.

However, a large commitment can also raise questions on how much of the manager's wealth is tied up in the fund and if his own interests could begin to outweigh those of external investors, some industry experts said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Swiss watches put language, faith on dials to win Indians

Swiss watchmakers are crafting bespoke, heritage-rich timepieces for collectors in India

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As India gains weight on the global stage for Swiss watchmakers, brands are increasingly leaning on cultural resonance to captivate collectors. In just the past week, four limited-edition watches debuted in the country, spanning ₹5.76 lakh to ₹4.25 crore, each featuring motifs designed to resonate strongly with Indian buyers.

Leading the charge is Jacob & Co.'s ₹4.25 crore timepiece: a rose-gold creation depicting Lord Ram, Lord Hanuman, and the Ram Temple at Ayodhya alongside a rotating Earth and flying tourbillon. Only three will be made worldwide. At a different price point, TAG Heuer's ₹5.76 lakh Carrera features 24 Indian languages on its dial. Franck Muller also unveiled its Vanguard 'Ram Lalla', a 108-piece run paying tribute to Lord Ram's childhood form, in partnership with retailer Kapoor Watch Co. Breitling launched a 59-piece, blue-dial Superocean Heritage B31 exclusively with the same retailer.

The flurry of local debuts comes as India becomes more important to Swiss watchmakers. Swiss watch exports to the country rose 28.5% year-on-year to 266.4 million Swiss francs, or about ₹3,050 crore, in January-September 2026, according to the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry FH. India moved to 14th place among the 30 largest export markets, from 20th in 2025, even as demand in some established markets weakened. Export values are not the same as retail sales in India, but the absolute growth could be why brands are paying closer attention to consumers here.

This growth momentum is also getting a push from evolving trade policy. Under the India-EFTA trade agreement, customs duties on qualifying Swiss-origin luxury watches dropped to 15.71% from 18.9% when the pact took effect in October 2025. While the 18% IGST continues to apply, these tariffs are scheduled to phase down progressively to zero by January 2031, which is expected to gradually narrow the price gap between international and domestic retail prices.

Ashok Goel, chairman and managing director of Luxury Time Ltd, a distributor representing brands such as TAG Heuer, Zenith, Hublot, and Bomberg in India, views special-edition timepieces as a strategic effort to stand out as global watchmakers increasingly target the market. "Sales (of these pieces) will happen automatically; it's just a question of reinforcement through differentiation," he said. With more desirable brands becoming available here, he said, watchmakers are looking for ways to make their products distinctive. One way is to appeal to the heart, whether through religious imagery, history or other cultural references.

(Clockwise) Breitling Superocean Heritage B31 Automatic 42 India edition, Jacob & Co.'s Shri Ramchandra limited edition and Franck Muller's 'Ram Lalla' India special edition.

INDIA'S TIME

THE flurry of local debuts comes as India becomes more important to Swiss watchmakers

INDIA moved to 14th place among the 30 largest export markets, from 20th in 2025

SWISS watch exports to India rose 28.5% on-year to about ₹3,050 crore, in Jan-Sep 2026

INDIA'S evolving foreign trade policy is also aiding this growth momentum

That shift marks a departure from simply bringing global designs to India and expecting the logo to do all the work. TAG Heuer's Carrera "Echoes of One India", a 250-piece limited edition featuring national flag colours and hour markers rendered in multiple Indian scripts, exemplifies the new approach. By embedding linguistic diversity directly onto the dial, the watch turns linguistic diversity into an instantly recognizable statement on the wrist, rather than a story confined to a marketing campaign. The brand, which had been planning an India-specific timepiece for years, said early interest was encouraging, though it did not disclose sales figures.

"When we saw this unique concept, we felt confident of creating a TAG Heuer Carrera watch that can be an ideal tribute for India as it delivers the entire length and breadth of India through one unique dial," Guillaume Boilot, managing director for Middle East, India, Africa and Turkey at TAG Heuer, told *Mint*.

For Jacob & Co., that concept translates into elaborate mechanical theatre. Its Shri Ramchandra timepiece—listed by Ethos at ₹4.25 crore—features miniature hand-crafted figures of Lord Ram and Lord Hanuman alongside the Ayodhya temple, an orange stone representing the sun, and a blue Earth rotating once every minute. Franck Muller's 'Ram Lalla' similarly highlights an engraved, hand-finished depiction of the deity across its dial.

In both cases, the religious iconography is far more than incidental decoration. It serves as the core defining feature distinguishing these pieces from the brands' standard collections.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Can an English release help films move beyond diaspora?

Lata Jha
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NEW DELHI

The big-budget mythological epic *Ramayana,* starring Ranbir Kapoor, is heading for an English release.

The overseas business of Indian films has so far been driven largely by diaspora audiences who prefer to watch them in their original languages. However, with the big-budget mythological epic *Ramayana* heading for an English release and action film *Toxic* having attempted the same recently, entertainment industry experts say the strategy could attract younger diaspora audiences, second- and third-generation Indians and, more importantly, non-Indian viewers who may know the story but have never experienced it on the big screen.

This could build on trends in streaming, where multiple Indian titles are dubbed and watched in English and other foreign languages.

"Theatrically, it (releasing an English version) has been rare. That inverts the traditional sequence where overseas was treated as an extension market, and it signals real confidence in the story's ability to travel. These are two distinct audiences, and both can work together to contribute to the film's success," said Ashish Misra, head of commercialization at Cinépolis India.

The diaspora viewer wants the original language. For them, the film is a cultural event, it is nostalgia. They know the story, they know the stars, they grew up with this and the opening weekend for them is a communal occasion, Misra said. At the same time, the English version is aimed at a completely different moviegoer: the mainstream international audience that has warmed up to Indian cinema over the last few years but engaged with it mostly through subtitles or streaming. An English version removes the last barrier between that viewer and a big-screen experience.

Sameer Munshi, chief operating officer at Miraj Entertainment Ltd, said streaming has more or less removed the language barrier for Indian and global content alike. Just as Indians have got used to watching international shows with subtitles, including Japanese anime and Korean dramas, especially since the pandemic, audiences worldwide have grown equally comfortable discovering Indian stories through subtitles and dubbing, even without a prior connection to the language or culture.

English dubbing remains relatively uncommon as a major theatrical strategy for Indian live-action films

"That's led to an important shift: people are now watching Indian content because the story interests them, not just because they're part of the diaspora. For a big theatrical release like *Ramayana*, that comfort with dubbed content makes the English version much easier for global audiences to accept," Munshi added.

Industry experts agree that English dubbing remains relatively uncommon as a major theatrical strategy for Indian live-action films. However, just as Korean content, Japanese anime and Chinese films have found audiences globally, Indian cinema has an opportunity to do the same, said Kamal Gianchandani, chief business planning and strategy at PVR INOX Ltd.

According to Rohit Dalmia, chairman and managing director of CineNow, an entertainment financing platform, the biggest challenge is localisation without losing authenticity. Dialogue, humour, emotion and cultural references have to feel natural in English rather than translated. There is also a marketing challenge: an English version competes for screens and attention with Hollywood films, so distributors must convince audiences that it is global event cinema rather than simply a dubbed Indian release.

"The diaspora often prefers the original language because the voices, dialogue delivery and cultural nuances are part of the experience. But OTT has changed the equation," film producer Anand Pandit said.

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MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

mint The Festive Edge
LEADERS' LENS

As part of Mint's Festive Edge initiative, Leaders' Lens brings together industry perspectives on the consumer shifts, market trends and brand priorities shaping the festive season.

SUNIL SURESH,
Founder & Executive Chairman, Stanley Lifestyles Limited

What is the one shift in how Indians are shopping this festive season that feels meaningfully different from last year?
Indian consumers are increasingly viewing their homes as an expression of personal identity rather than simply functional spaces. This festive season, we see a stronger emphasis on considered purchases, design, comfort and lasting quality. At Stanley, we believe this reflects a broader shift towards investing in products that elevate everyday living. Consumers are looking beyond the immediate gratification of a festive offer to the craftsmanship, personalisation and long-term value a product brings to their homes.

Where does a festive purchase really get decided today - at the showroom, a phone screen, or in a conversation at home?
The purchase journey begins with inspiration but is ultimately shaped by experience and trust. Digital platforms help consumers discover designs, explore possibilities and shortlist brands, while conversations at home align aspirations with practical needs. For a considered purchase like furniture, the showroom remains invaluable, allowing customers to experience comfort, materials and craftsmanship firsthand. At Stanley, our focus is on connecting digital discovery with personalised in-store experiences, helping customers translate their aspirations into homes that reflect their individuality.

Where are consumers willing to trade up this festive season and where is value still winning over aspiration?
Consumers are increasingly willing to trade up on products that have a lasting impact on their everyday lives, particularly sofas, beds and thoughtfully designed home interiors. Comfort, craftsmanship, durability and design are becoming important considerations in these decisions. At the same time, value remains essential, with consumers expecting transparency, functionality and quality that justify the investment. The opportunity for premium brands is to make aspiration tangible by delivering products and experiences that offer enduring value beyond the festive season.

In a festive season crowded with offers, screens, scrolls and messages, where can a brand still earn attention?
In a marketplace dominated by festive offers, lasting differentiation comes from what a brand consistently delivers, not simply what it promises. For Stanley, credibility is rooted in craftsmanship, quality materials, design and the experience customers have with our products. Communication can attract attention, but the product must earn trust. In premium furniture, where purchases become part of everyday life for years, authentic storytelling, tangible experiences and dependable service create relationships that extend well beyond a festive transaction.

Disclaimer: Leaders' Lens is a marketing initiative by HT Media. The news and editorial teams of Mint had no role in its creation.

Advt. No. RECPDCL/HR/2026/03

REC Power Development

REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited (RECPDCL)
(formerly REC Power Distribution Company Limited)

Invitation for Applications on Fixed Tenure Basis

REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited (REC PDCL), a wholly owned subsidiary of REC Ltd., a "Maharatna CPSE" under the Ministry of Power, Government of India, invites online applications from experienced professionals on "Fixed Tenure Basis" for the below mentioned posts:

S.No	Name of the Post & Grade	No. of Vacancies
1.	Senior Executive (Tech.)- Lead Verifier/L-5 (Compliance Mechanism)	02
2.	Senior Executive (Tech.)- Lead Verifier/L-5 (Offset Mechanism)	01
3.	Deputy Executive (Tech.) / L-3 (Distribution Expert)	04
4.	Deputy Executive (Tech.) / L-3 (Renewable Energy)	02
5.	Deputy Executive (Tech.) / L-3 (Transmission)	02
6.	Deputy Executive (Tech.) / L-3 (Utility Coordinator)	11
7.	Assistant Executive (Tech.) / L-2 (Utility Engineer)	08
8.	Assistant Executive (Fin.) /L-2	02
9.	Sr. Consultant (Renewable Energy)	01

For detailed advertisement and online application, visit: www.recpdcl.in.
Last date for submission of applications is 17.11.2026
Sr. General Manager (HR)

India Trade Promotion Organisation
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi-110 001 (India)

File No: 4-ITPO(3)/E-I/2026 Date: 27.10.2026

India Trade Promotion Organisation (ITPO) invites application from willing and eligible candidates for the post of **Senior Assistant (Civil), Senior Assistant (Electrical), Senior Assistant (Architecture), Assistant (Accounts), Junior Stenographer, Junior Assistant (General Cadre)** to be filled on direct recruitment basis.

For eligibility criteria, closing date for applications, detailed information and updates, please visit the Careers section on ITPO's website: **www.itpo.gov.in**

श्यामा प्रसाद मुखर्जी पोर्ट, कोलकाता
Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata
(Formerly KOLKATA PORT TRUST)

Maintenance Dredging Operation
Tender Notice No.:SMPK/MRN/SDDS/MDRG/KDS/III dated 14.10.2026
Estimated Cost: ₹ 565.88 Crore
Pre-Bid Meeting: 30.10.2026 at 1400 hours
Last Date of Submission: 17.11.2026 upto 1500 hours

Tender Notice No.:SMPA/KDS/CIV/T/3079/56
Tender I.D. No: 2026_KoPT_929663_1
DEVELOPMENT OF COMMON USER FACILITIES AT 7 & 8 NSD INCLUDING CIVIL ENGINEERING WORKS ALONGWITH ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING AND FIRE FIGHTING WORKS AT KDS, SMPA
Estimated Cost: ₹37,58,66,881.71 (Excluding GST)
Last Date of online Submission: 02.11.2026 upto 15.00 Hrs

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HT FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu finds himself in a tight race for re-election on Tuesday. AP/PTI

Netanyahu's legacy on the line as Israel goes to vote today

AP
feedback@livemint.com

When Hamas-led militants attacked Israel on 7 October 2023, it looked like Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's days in office were numbered.

With the country overwhelmed by grief and anger after the deadliest security breakdown in its history, his resignation seemed like a matter of time.

But the divisive veteran Israeli leader has scratched, scraped and literally battled his way back during a stormy three-year period of nonstop domestic crises and wars across the region. Confounding his critics, he now finds himself in a tight race for reelection on Tuesday.

Netanyahu has been the country's most dominant politician for nearly two decades, and his legacy is on the line. A poor showing could end the 77-year-old's lengthy career on a bitter note and open the door to a new era in Israeli politics. A victory would cement his image as the ultimate political survivor.

A poor showing could end the 77-year-old's lengthy career on a bitter note and launch a new era in Israeli politics

Former Prime Minister Ehud Olmert, a onetime ally turned rival of Netanyahu, said there has never been so much at stake—from national security to the future of Israel's democratic institutions and its standing in the world. After a series of wars that have destabilized the region and jolted the global economy, the world is watching closely.

Politicians often say the current election is the most fateful in their country's history, Olmert said, but "this time it really is."

Netanyahu's opponents, led by former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, see Tuesday as a day of reckoning. They say Netanyahu should be held accountable for 7 October and the failure to turn battlefield victories into diplomatic achievements.

"What he is offering is an eternal war," Eisenkot, whose son and two nephews were killed in combat, said in a radio interview. "Choosing a leader whose only goal is not to surrender means choosing a leader who will not deliver victories."

Netanyahu's supporters say he was betrayed by Israel's defense establishment and that he has led the country through a remarkable turnaround with devastating strikes against Hamas, Lebanon's Hezbollah and Iran.

The Israeli leader has also turned to his traditional use of scare tactics. His campaign slogan, "Right or Palestine," which rhymes in Hebrew, suggests his opponents would establish a Palestinian state alongside Israel, something his main rivals vehemently reject.

Nearly every poster, stump speech or televised debate seems to reference the 7 October attack.

Some 1,200 people were killed that day and 251 others taken hostage, the last of whom were returned in a ceasefire deal last year.

Israel responded with a military offensive that has killed over 74,000 Palestinians in Gaza, according to local health authorities, left the territory in ruins and triggered open-ended wars in Lebanon and Iran.

Israelis vote for political parties, not individual candidates. Since no political party has ever captured a 61-seat majority on its own, political leaders must form coalitions.

Palestinians have little hope their lives will improve regardless of whether Netanyahu wins or loses.

Lula wins fourth term in Brazil election upset

The 80-year-old president's victory cements one of Latin America's longest political careers

Samantha Pearson
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Da Silva became the first presidential candidate in Brazil's history to lose the first round of voting but win the runoff. AP

President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva clung to power in Sunday's presidential election by orchestrating a surprise victory over Flávio Bolsonaro , winning an unprecedented fourth term and cementing his place as one of the world's longest-serving democratically elected leaders.

The leftist leader, just two days away from turning 81, won 51.8% of the vote against 48.2% for Bolsonaro, electoral authorities said with over 99% of the votes counted. The victory came after da Silva's Workers' Party requested that voting be extended Sunday, after reports that some local governments had reduced the number of buses serving poorer voters, who tend to support the president.

That request was granted by Supreme Court Justice Cristiano Zanin—a decision that came a minute after voting was supposed to end, prompting chaos at some polling stations. While Bolsonaro's camp also requested an extension to voting in some parts of the country because of flooding, the move by Zanin, who served as da Silva's personal defense lawyer during the so-called Car Wash corruption scandal that entangled the leftist, drew criticism of bias.

Bolsonaro called Zanin's intervention "unacceptable" and refused to recognize the election result, vowing to seek its annulment.

Da Silva became the first presidential candidate in Brazil's modern democratic history to lose the first round of voting but win the runoff. His adversary was the eldest son of Jair Bolsonaro , a bitter rival who served as president and was convicted of trying to overturn da Silva's 2022 victory.

Cheers erupted from apartment windows and car horns blared across São Paulo after a frantic last-minute push by musicians, celebrities and campaigners to mobilize first-round abstainers and secure da Silva's victory. Despite widespread apathy at the start of the campaign, Sunday's 19% abstention rate was one of the lowest on record—and essential in delivering victory to the president.

"I want to thank the Brazilian people for the generosity they have shown me for such a long time," da Silva said late Sunday, his voice so hoarse he could barely speak. He dedicated his victory to elderly voters and others who turned out at the last minute. "We managed to convince them."

Da Silva vowed to defend Brazil's interests against pressure from Washington, which he has long accused of trying to interfere in this year's election on behalf of the Bolsonaros as President Trump seeks to expand U.S. influence across Latin America. "We won't be anybody's backyard," he said.

For many Brazilians, the election was more than about keeping da Silva in power. They saw a vote for him as a vote to keep the Bolsonaros out and preserve the country's hard-won democracy.

"We must do what we can to protect Brazil's democracy," said Karina da Silva Pereira, a 50-year-old lawyer in São Paulo, who braved torrential rains to vote for da Silva. Following Jair Bolsonaro's attempt to seize power by force four years ago, she said she felt compelled to vote to keep the family out of power. "It was a risk we couldn't take."

Da Silva had trailed 45% to Bolsonaro's 47% in the first round on Oct. 4, but the race tightened sharply in the final weeks. Even on the eve of the runoff, major polls showed Bolsonaro with a narrow lead within the margin of error, with Datafolha and Quaest both putting him at 51% to da Silva's 49%.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

A quarter of a century after first winning the presidency, da Silva is now the last remaining stalwart of South America's left, which has suffered a string of defeats as the region takes a rightward turn driven by economic and crime concerns. New leaders from Honduras to Colombia to Chile and beyond have allied themselves with the Trump administration.

Da Silva's surprise victory Sunday came after he persuaded millions of Brazilians who had skipped the first round of voting to cast ballots for him in the second round, despite heavy rains that pounded much of the country.

Starting as a factory worker and trade union leader during what was then a dictatorship, da Silva has weathered throat and skin cancers, a corruption scandal that put him behind bars in 2018, and a plot by Jair Bolsonaro's allies to assassinate him.

Da Silva's victory puts him on course to complete 16 nonconsecutive years in office, matching Angela Merkel's tenure as German chancellor, placing him among a small group of modern democracy's longest-serving elected leaders.

The victory marks another chapter in da Silva's bitter struggle with the Bolsonaro family, whose right-wing movement has proved remarkably resilient. Da Silva narrowly defeated Jair Bolsonaro in 2022, winning 50.9% of the vote to his rival's 49.1%.

The former president was subsequently convicted and imprisoned for plotting a coup to prevent da Silva from taking office. But rather than fade away, the movement rallied behind his eldest son, turning this year's election into a rematch by proxy and forcing da Silva into another bruising battle to keep the family out of power.

But da Silva now faces an uphill struggle to govern after the right swept congressional elections held alongside the first round of voting this month. The Bolsonaro family's Liberal Party emerged as the largest in both chambers, winning 121 of 513 seats in the lower house and securing a 28-strong bloc in the 81-seat Senate, leaving da Silva increasingly dependent on deals with conservative and centrist lawmakers to advance his agenda.

Born to illiterate farmworkers in Brazil's impoverished northeast, da Silva lost a finger in a metalworking plant before rising through the labor movement to become president in 2003. Even among poorer Brazilians who associate him with corruption, many still see him as their strongest advocate in a deeply unequal nation, where the poorest half of the population—more than 100 million people—owns less than 3% of household wealth.

After his first-round setback, da Silva shifted his campaign away from warnings about U.S. interference in Brazil's election and toward the economic frustrations of ordinary voters. He promised to increase payments under the Bolsa Família welfare program, championed a shorter working week without a cut in pay and proposed sweeping debt relief for struggling households. He also floated free public transportation on weekends, seeking to reconnect with poorer voters who had long formed the backbone of his support.

Da Silva also toughened his message on crime, breaking with his party's traditional position to support prosecuting 16-year-olds as adults for particularly serious crimes. His campaign intensified efforts to mobilize voters who had stayed home in the first round, while portraying Bolsonaro's proposed spending cuts as a threat to public services and social benefits.

Da Silva's victory sets the stage for renewed tensions with Washington. Following a string of victories by conservative candidates from Argentina and Chile to Colombia and Peru in recent years, Brazil's decision to stick with the left denies Trump a powerful ally in Latin America, one that is a major source of critical minerals needed for everything from electric vehicles to weapons systems.

Trump has praised Bolsonaro and clashed repeatedly with da Silva over trade, Brazil's prosecution of the former president and what the Brazilian leader has called U.S. interference in the election. The dispute escalated into tariffs and a diplomatic row over visas, although the two governments have continued negotiating a trade agreement.

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Amgen, Astra drug duo boosts survival for lung cancer

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Doctors combined powerful medicines from Amgen Inc. and AstraZeneca Plc and found they allowed patients with an aggressive form of lung cancer to live eight months longer.

The survival benefit came from adding Amgen's Imdelltra to Astra's Imfinzi, which worked better than Imfinzi alone for volunteers whose tumors had spread. Small cell lung cancer has one of the worst prognoses.

"This is an unprecedented step forward," Jacob Sands, an oncologist from Dana-Farber Cancer Institute who helped lead the research, said in an interview.

The findings were presented Saturday at the European Society for Medical Oncology in Madrid. They suggest combining treatments like Imdelltra, which works by redirecting the immune system to kill cancer cells, with others like Imfinzi can help fight the deadliest cancers.

Imdelltra has already shown it can extend the lives of patients whose extensive stage small cell lung cancer progressed despite chemotherapy. Most people are diagnosed when the disease has already spread to the other lung or to different organs.

In the new study, patients whose cancer hasn't advanced after chemotherapy and other treatments got both Imdelltra and Imfinzi. The combination reduced the risk of death by 58%, according to data that was also published in the New England Journal of Medicine.

"There are moments in medicine where a piece of data I think is so profound that you just know it's going to transform the standard of care for patients," said Paul Burton, Amgen's chief medical officer.

About half of patients receiving Imdelltra and Imfinzi had an inflammatory response called cytokine release syndrome, although most were less serious forms of the condition. Around 1% of patients suffered a neurological condition that impacts the brain.

Imdelltra is a relatively new cancer drug only available for patients whose disease has progressed despite other treatments. Making it available sooner is important because typically only about half of people treated for small cell lung cancer end up receiving a follow-on therapy, Sands said.

Death threats, lawsuits and billions in play over moving Russian oil

Joe Wallace &
Samantha Pearson

In a rare legal fight, a former Russian energy industry insider has sued sanctioned oil traders who, according to Western officials, have become the most important middlemen enabling Moscow to sell its oil and fund its war in Ukraine.

Igor Soglayev alleges he teamed up in early 2024 with Moscow-backed traders known as the Coral network. The relationship soured after a tanker carrying tens of millions of dollars worth of diesel failed to deliver its cargo in Brazil. The two sides are now slugging it out in courts in Brazil and the United Arab Emirates, filings reviewed by *The Wall Street Journal* show. The U.A.E. court handling the main case hasn't publicized the proceedings.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Soglayev, a former Deutsche Bank executive, notched a legal victory, despite receiving what he perceived as death threats over energy trades gone wrong. A U.A.E. judge issued a freezing order on more than $700 million of proceeds from the sale of Russian energy by Soglayev's opponents.

"I realized I had been screwed," Soglayev said in an interview. "I had been truly played."

Chasing liquid gold

The size of the freezing order underscores the sums of money at stake in the market for Moscow's sanctioned oil and the lengths that executives with ties to Russian energy will go to get a piece of it. Russia remains one of the world's leading energy exporters along with the U.S. and Saudi Arabia, selling more than $150 billion worth of crude and fuel each year.

To avoid Western sanctions, Russian oil exports have for the most part fallen under the control of a handful of middlemen from Azerbaijan and Russia. They are known in the industry and by Western officials as the Coral network, after a now-defunct trading firm where many of them used to work.

Led by little-known traders Etibar Eyyub and Tahir Garayev , Coral struck a secret deal with state-backed Rosneft to export much of Russia's oil in the chaotic early months of the Ukraine war, *The Wall Street Journal* has reported . The network has since consolidated control of the market, moving tens of billions of dollars of oil annually on a fleet of tankers that form most of Russia's shadow fleet .

The U.K. and European Union have sanctioned Eyyub, Garayev and several of their associates, plus dozens of trading and shipping firms they used to deflect attention from their activities. Eyyub said last year he considered the sanctions to be baseless, and that he had done nothing unlawful. A lawyer for Garayev has said the Azeri businessman hasn't been involved in petroleum operations since 2022.

The Coral network sells crude that once headed to Europe, India and China. Russian diesel, meanwhile, flowed to Brazil, where the fuel powers haulage trucks. The Latin American country devours the fuel to power haulage trucks. Soglayev tried to get a piece of the action.

Leveraging state ties

Soglayev's career traces the recent economic arc of Russia. He commanded a military intelligence unit before leaving the army after the collapse of the Soviet Union. As private enterprise flourished in the 1990s, he joined with a Dutch businessman to import electronic goods.

A former Deutsche Bank executive who got into business with the kingpins of Russia's shadow fleet has gone against it. AFP

After a stint in the U.S. working on Wall Street, he returned to Russia and got to know the petrochemicals industry from his perch at Deutsche Bank. That led to a job as chief executive of chemicals producer Sanors.

Rosneft bought Sanors in 2015. Soglayev became Rosneft's top chemicals executive and an adviser to Rosneft boss Igor Sechin —now the patron of the Coral traders. Soglayev left two years later, and dabbled in various energy ventures.

When Russia's export machine broke down after President Vladimir Putin invaded Ukraine, Sechin tapped Eyyub and Garayev to replace the Swiss and U.K. traders that used to handle Rosneft's oil, the *Journal* has reported.

The lawyer for Garayev said he wasn't aware of any legal proceedings with Soglayev. Eyyub couldn't be reached for comment.

Soglayev says in filings he set up a firm called DIA33 in Dubai to flip Russian oil to foreign buyers. He set his sights on Brazil, where Russian diesel was displacing more expensive American fuel.

His goal was to make Russian fuel palatable to importers who worried that buying directly from Moscow could complicate their dealings with banks wary of violating sanctions. He booked storage space at Brazilian ports and planned to buy diesel from Russian exporters, then sell at a markup to fuel distributors.

Web of transactions

The trading arrangements Soglayev entered into show the convoluted mechanisms that have kept Russian oil flowing beyond the gaze of Western officials. Soglayev alleges he bought Russian diesel from a small firm in Dubai called Serene Resources in late 2023.

The Coral network sells crude that once headed to Europe, India and China

He says its CEO, Andrey Romanovskiy , moved to a different company that was controlled by Eyyub and Garayev. Soglayev alleges Romanovskiy told him the Coral network operated through different shell companies to avoid international attention. Soglayev says they discussed the possibility that DIA might later merge with Coral to become its Brazilian trading arm.

A lawyer for Romanovskiy didn't respond to questions. But in an affidavit reviewed by the *Journal*, Romanovskiy told a Dubai court his firm was independent, denied that it was controlled by Coral and disputed other details of Soglayev's case.

Things went south after terminal operators in a Brazilian port rejected an aging tanker full of Russian diesel that Soglayev was supposed to sell, according to filings by Soglayev and some of his opponents. The ship dawdled for weeks, racking up bills, until a different harbor admitted it, according to the filings.

The alleged Coral traders who sold the diesel, frustrated that Soglayev hadn't paid them, pursued him before an arbitration tribunal in Dubai, accusing him of having oversold his capabilities and effectively stealing the fuel. The tribunal earlier this year ordered Soglayev to pay one of the firms involved in the trade $42 million.

Soglayev responded with his own suits in Dubai and Brazil, alleging Coral ruined his business by approaching his clients and selling to them at discounted prices. The partnership, he claims, was a ruse for Coral to access DIA's internal information. He claims he is owed more than $500 million in lost business.

Soglayev alleges he received what he perceived to be death threats, including a call from Eyyub to say he had discussed the dispute with a Chechen warlord.

In June, a judge in Dubai banned Eyyub, Garayev and 13 other firms and people from disposing of assets valued up to $704 million as the case moved forward. But he later said his court didn't have jurisdiction, raising the possibility of the suit being tossed.

Soglayev has appealed to keep the case in the Dubai International Financial Centre, said his lawyer in the U.A.E., David McCoy of ADG Legal.

The freezing order remains in place pending a decision on the appeal. A related lawsuit in Brazil is ongoing.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

₹700 cr
THE SIZE of the venture capital fund being raised by Unacademy founders Gaurav Munjal and Roman Saini to invest in AI and deep technology startups.

88.1%
THE PERCENTAGE of listed residential properties in India that are ready to move in, highlighting homebuyers prefer immediate possession, eXp India said.

66,333
THE AVERAGE daily passenger count on Noida Metro's Aqua Line during the first nine months of this year, up from 61,401 in 2025.

$40 bn
THE AMOUNT SpaceX raised in a debt deal, according to Elon Musk posting on X, to purchase Nvidia GPUs for its artificial intelligence data centres.

$11.6 bn
THE PROJECTED total spending on political advertising for the 2026 US midterm elections by Election Day, per AdImpact, up from $8.9 bn spent in 2022.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

India braces as cyclone Arnab nears

Arnab is expected to make landfall in Andhra Pradesh state by Wednesday morning. PTI

Two states along India's eastern coast were preparing to evacuate thousands of people ahead of cyclone Arnab, which is expected to make landfall on Wednesday, as one of them said it would close schools in some districts for two days.

Arnab, which formed over the Bay of Bengal before intensifying into a cyclonic storm, is expected to make landfall in Andhra Pradesh state by Wednesday morning, with gusts of as much as 140 kph (87 mph), India's weather office said.

The cyclone will probably intensify further, it added.

The weather system is expected to bring heavy to extremely heavy rainfall to Andhra Pradesh's northern and central coastal districts, and southern regions of neighbouring Odisha.

Andhra Pradesh has called for boats at sea to return ashore and ordered speedy restoration of power in case of disruptions.

A senior Andhra Pradesh disaster management official told *Reuters* on Monday the state government had identified 570,000 people as vulnerable and evacuations would start on Monday evening. **REUTERS**

Rupee falls 22 paise against dollar

The rupee depreciated for the third straight day and settled 22 paise lower at 95.15 against the US dollar on Monday, weighed down by elevated crude oil prices and geopolitical tensions in the Middle East.

Foreign exchange (Forex) traders said the Indian rupee declined on positive dollar and slight gains in US treasury yields, while a recovery in the domestic markets cushioned the downside.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.92 against the dollar, then lost ground to touch an intra-day low of 95.26 and finally settled for the day at 95.15, registering a decline of 22 paise over its previous close. **PTI**

PTC clears mineral exchange proposal

Power trading solutions provider PTC India on Monday said its board has approved incorporation of a wholly-owned subsidiary with an investment of ₹65 crore to set up and operate a mineral exchange in the country.

The company proposes setting up the mineral exchange through a subsidiary as per applicable laws and rules, which will offer delivery-based electronic trading in permitted minerals and other related areas, an exchange filing stated.

The Board also approved equity investment of up to ₹65 crores in the proposed subsidiary, it informed the exchanges. There will be a 100% subscription to the initial paid-up share capital in cash. **PTI**

LTTS will establish a dedicated ODC in India to support Nokia's initiatives. ISTOCKPHOTO

L&T, Nokia announce engineering tie-up

L&T Technology Services on Monday announced a five-year contract with Nokia to support engineering and research and development activities in India.

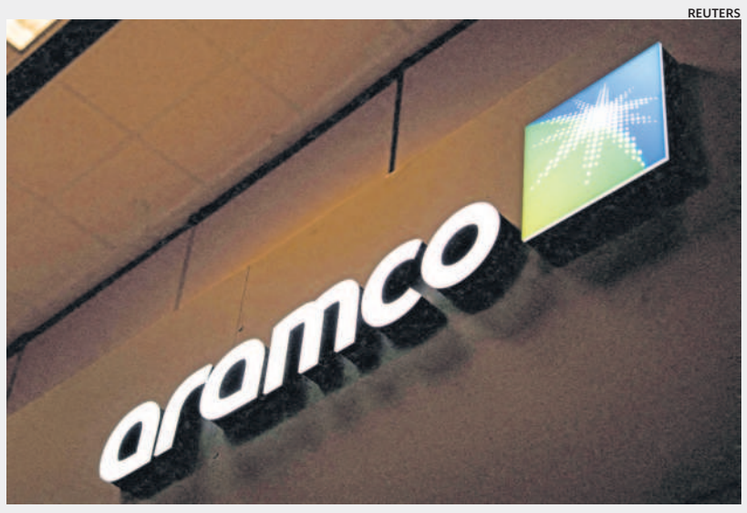
The contract brings together LTTS' (Larsen & Toubro Technology Services) engineering capabilities with Nokia's telecommunications technology work, according to a release.

The release did not divulge the size or financial details of the contract.

Under the agreement, LTTS will support Nokia R&D (Research and Development) programs across areas, including product engineering, software development, system integration, and product support. LTTS will establish a dedicated Offshore Development Center (ODC) in India to support Nokia's engineering and R&D initiatives.

The ODC brings data-center-grade compute and Artificial intelligence (AI)-infrastructure engineering to next-generation telecom solutions. LTTS will also create a dedicated engineering team in India to support Nokia's technology centre globally, with work spanning areas such as 5G networks, intelligent automation, AI-driven operations and AI infrastructure. **PTI**

REUTERS



Aramco nears $10 bn loan deal with global banks

Saudi Aramco gained from higher oil prices and recovering output during the Iran war

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Saudi Arabian state-backed oil company Aramco is nearing agreement with international banks on a $10 billion loan that would bolster its finances as conflicts in the Middle East threaten crude exports.

The revolving credit facility that is set to be signed in the coming weeks will be provided by banks including Bank of China Ltd., Citigroup Inc., HSBC Holdings Plc, Industrial & Commercial Bank of China Ltd., JPMorgan Chase & Co. and Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group, according to people with knowledge of the matter.

Saudi Aramco has benefited from a surge in oil prices during the Iran war and as it revived exports and production from a decline during the initial days of the conflict. But the company, the backbone of the Saudi economy, has faced attacks on its infrastructure in recent weeks, with Yemen's Houthi militants targeting its headquarters, a major oil field, at least one refinery and the key port on Yanbu on the Red Sea.

The new facility is set to be priced at 60 basis points over the Secured Overnight Financing Rate, said the people, who asked not to be identified discussing a confidential process.

Spokespeople for Citi, HSBC, JPMorgan, Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group, Standard Chartered and Aramco declined to comment.

A representative of Bank of China wasn't immediately available for comment. A spokesperson for Industrial & Commercial Bank didn't immediately respond to a request for comment.

Gulf energy companies have been looking to tap debt markets for large-scale financing. QatarEnergy raised a $3 billion loan this month largely from a roster of Chinese banks. Saudi Energy Co. also raised a 15.8 billion riyal ($4.1 billion) Shariah-compliant murabaha financing in July, with a group of seven Gulf banks providing the facility.

Aramco signed its previous revolving credit facility in 2024. The facility consisted of two tranches, one for $7 billion arranged by US, European and Asian lenders, and a second tranche for $3 billion, a murabaha facility, that was funded by regional banks.

Uday Kotak flags $160-bn debt cliff

Financial services industry veteran Uday Kotak on Monday said that India will have to repay over $160 billion on deposits raised through the foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR(B), window and urged policymakers to be strategic while moving to the repayment "cliff" in three to five years.

Speaking at the annual *Business Standard* BFSI Insights Summit here, Kotak also flagged risks from excessive financialisation of gold, which is leading to a surge in India's imports of the precious metal and putting a risk on the external balances.

Terming the over $133 billion raised from diaspora as part of the concessional swap facility for FCNR(B) deposits as good insurance amid the current geopolitical upheaval, Kotak reminded of the need to prepare for the repayments. **PTI**

The firm's total revenue from operations rose 25.6% to ₹1,054 crore. MINT

ITC Hotels profit rises on room sales

ITC Hotels, one of India's largest hospitality chains, reported a 51.4% rise in second-quarter profit on Monday, driven by an increase in room sales, sending shares higher.

The hotel arm of ITC posted a consolidated net profit of ₹201 crore ($21.11 million) against ₹133 crore a year ago. The firm's total revenue from operations rose 25.6% to ₹1,054 crore, outpacing the 18.8% rise in total expenses. Revenue from its hotels segment, its largest, rose 17.4% to ₹966 crore, driven by both room rates and volumes, the company said. The company said it expects to benefit from weddings, high-impact MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) and social or sporting events in the seasonally stronger second-half of the current fiscal year. Shares of ITC Hotels jumped as much as 7.8% to ₹168.50 after the results, before trimming some gains to trade 5% higher. **REUTERS**

Ambani, Adani cos contest privacy law

A group of 21 news publishers, including companies owned by billionaires Mukesh Ambani and Gautam Adani, has challenged India's privacy law in court, arguing it would trample investigative work and let New Delhi identify journalists' sources, documents show. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government last year announced implementation of a privacy law to protect digital personal data of users, raising compliance requirements for platforms such as Meta and Google. The publishers have said that since media outlets were not exempt, the law was an invasion of press freedom.

Media companies received assurances in an August meeting with the government that the law would protect press freedom, but not having a written carve-out for journalists like in the EU, Singapore and Britain was alarming, India's Digital News Publishers Association said in a confidential filing at the Supreme Court, reviewed by *Reuters*. **REUTERS**

Noel wants Chandra selection deleted

FROM PAGE 1

N. Chandrasekaran REUTERS

ber letter asking for corrections to the draft. In his last letter, he had said the draft did not include two conditions all six directors had agreed to before announcing the results: that Tata Sons would get a legal opinion on the reappointment, and that shareholders would first approve Chandrasekaran's directorship.

In its official filing on 15 October, Tata Sons left out the specific rules of Chandrasekaran's reappointment, *Mint* reported on 19 October.

"It is unacceptable that, despite being a director of the company, I have not been furnished with a certified true copy of the resolution and have instead been constrained to rely on a version circulating in the public domain," Noel wrote in the latest letter.

He said Tata Sons had not answered his requests on 30 September and 8 October seeking the meeting's audio and video recordings. "The recording is the only neutral record of what transpired, and there can be no legitimate reason to withhold it from a director who was present at the meeting and who has placed his objections on record," he wrote.

Emails sent to Tata Sons and Noel seeking comment went unanswered.

Noel noted that neither the original nor the revised agenda for the 17 September meeting mentioned a resolution to reappoint the executive chairman.

At the centre of the dispute are two rules in Tata Sons' Articles of Association. Article 118 requires a selection committee to pick a chairman. None was formed this time. Noel says the article also applies to reappointments, as it did for Chandrasekaran's previous one. The draft minutes shared with Tata Sons board members on 4 October say it applies to appointing a "new chairman", according to an executive.

Tata Sons maintains it acted correctly under Article 121, which requires a majority of the Trusts' nominee directors to approve the chairman's appointment. Noel voted against and Srinivasan in favour, producing a tie that Harish Manwani, chair of the Nomination and Remuneration Committee, broke with a casting vote.

Noel rejected that reading again. "A casting vote arises only on an equality of the votes of the board as a whole and cannot supply that affirmative vote," he wrote, adding that he would treat any resolution passed otherwise "as not passed".

The sharpest part of the 26 October letter concerns Hanno One Warehousing Pvt. Ltd, whose directors include Chandrasekaran's wife, Lalitha, and son, Pranav. On 22 September, *Mint* first reported on Chandrasekaran's family members having business links with TVS Motor Co. Ltd, raising governance questions after a deciding vote by its chairman-emeritus, Venu Srinivasan won Chandrasekaran a new term. On 30 September, *Mint* reported a second business link between Hanno One and TVS Motor.

Noel questioned whether Venu Srinivasan should have cast the deciding vote on Chandrasekaran's appointment

"A director who is called upon to evaluate the performance of the executive chairman and to vote on his reappointment, while a company which he leads has a continuing commercial relationship with the immediate family of the executive chairman, stands in the very position which these provisions address," Noel wrote, referring to the Tata Code of Conduct.

He argued that Srinivasan should have disclosed the dealings and recused himself. "The participation of a conflicted director goes to the validity of the decision itself," the 26 October letter said.

Noel said the legal opinions from former Chief Justice of India U.U. Lalit and former Supreme Court judge B.N. Srikrishna came only after the vote result was announced; so, they cannot be called independent. He added that Justice Lalit's opinion was sought by Harish Manwani, Anita Marangoly George and Venu Srinivasan, all of whom voted for the reappointment. "The queries were, in substance, seeking an opinion on the validity of their own votes," Noel wrote.

Noel's Monday letter gave Tata Sons seven days to provide the meeting's recording, minutes, and the agenda audit trail on the Board Web App; and all disclosures of interest filed by Chandrasekaran and Srinivasan; and the briefs given to the legal experts. He has also asked that the company inform the registrar in writing that the resolution's validity is disputed. "Failing the above, I will have no alternative but to draw adverse inferences," he wrote.

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EY takes cross-border staff tax battle to SC

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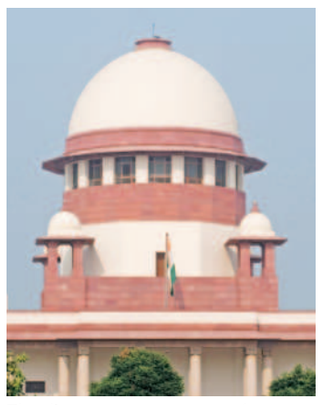
The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to hear global consulting firm EY's plea challenging a Delhi high court ruling that treated payments made by its Indian entities to its US arm for employees deputed to India as fees for technical services rather than salary reimbursements.

A bench of Justice J.B. Pardiwala and Justice K. Vinod Chandran issued notice to the income tax department, seeking its response to EY's challenge to the high court's 18 June 2026 judgment. The matter will next be heard on 1 December.

The dispute centres on employee secondment arrangements, under which employees are temporarily transferred from an overseas firm to work for its Indian group entity.

The key question is whether payments made by the Indian entity to its overseas counterpart merely reimburse employee costs or amount to payments for technical services that can be taxed in India.

Consulting and tech firms, as well as companies operating global capability centres in India, will closely watch the case as the Supreme Court's eventual ruling could affect how multinational companies structure such arrangements, as well as their tax liabilities and withholding-tax obligations. The high court ruling had important implications for multinational companies' employee secondment arrangements, including greater tax scrutiny and potential impacts on withholding tax and GST, according to a 6 July 2026 analysis by law firm Trilegal.



The dispute centres on employee secondment arrangements. MINT

Mint's queries emailed to EY and I-T department were not answered.

The dispute covers assessment years 2018-19 to 2022-23 and concerns employees deputed by Ernst & Young U.S. LLP (EY US) to its Indian entities. Under an arrangement dating to October 2017, employees remained on EY US's rolls.

EY India reimbursed EY US for the costs associated with these employees. The I-T department argued that the payments were not just salary reimbursements but consideration for technical knowledge, skills and expertise provided to the Indian entities.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Mankind Pharma's profit jumps 39%

Mankind Pharma reported an over 39% jump in second-quarter profit on Monday, helped by strong demand for chronic therapies such as diabetes and cardiac treatments.

Consolidated net profit rose to ₹711 crore ($74.7 million) for the quarter ended 30 September, from ₹512 crore a year earlier.

Mankind Pharma and peers including Torrent Pharma continue to benefit from strong demand for chronic therapies, particularly diabetes and cardiovascular treatments, helping drive steady growth in the domestic formulations business. Mankind Pharma makes prescription medicines across chronic and acute therapies, and consumer healthcare products including Manforce condoms, Prega News pregnancy test kits and Gas-O-Fast antacid tablets. Last week, peer Torrent Pharma reported a near 10% drop in quarterly profit as research and development costs outweighed strong domestic demand. **REUTERS**

CAN OIL PALM SPARK YELLOW REVOLUTION 2.0?

Backed by an ₹11,040-crore mission, India makes a high-stakes push to slash its edible oil import bill

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GODREJ AGROVET

BLOOMBERG

(Clockwise from left) Oil palm plantations keep producing for two decades or more; India imports palm oil from Indonesia and Malaysia; an oil palm tree needs the right agro-climatic zone and reliable irrigation.

mint KEY NUMBERS

$18.3 BILLION

What India spent in 2024–25 on importing 16–17 million tonnes of edible oil—palm oil being the largest component.

₹11,040 CRORE

The budget allocated to the National Mission on Edible Oils–Oil Palm to build out nurseries, mills, and farmer price cushions.

20 YEARS

The productive lifespan of an oil palm tree, which demands patient capital and a 3 to 4-year gestation period.

For Kishor Yelati, a farmer from Chintampalle village in Andhra Pradesh's Eluru district, choosing oil palm was not an easy decision. When he decided to plant the crop on roughly 4.8 hectares of ancestral land, doubts were aplenty. But the prospect of relatively stable returns, along with India's growing dependence on imported edible oils, persuaded him to take the plunge.

Oil palm, however, has a long gestation period—about four years. To keep his farm financially viable during this period, Yelati turned to intercropping. He grew maize during the first two years and groundnut in the third. With the palms now yielding, he grows cocoa alongside oil palm and earns about ₹1.2–1.7 lakh per hectare, excluding expenses.

A similar story is unfolding in neighbouring East Godavari district. Gopal Krishna Reddy of Anaparthi village brought 24.3 hectares under oil palm and earns more than ₹1.2 lakh a hectare. During the three-year gestation period, he grew maize and vegetables to generate interim income.

"The tree bears fruit for two decades, and for farmers it means a steady income," Reddy said.

Reddy estimates that in the last five years, around 4,050 hectares in the district have shifted to oil-palm cultivation, reflecting growing farmer interest in the crop. They have sensed a long-term income opportunity.

Now, well beyond the traditional strongholds of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, newer states in the North-East—Assam, Tripura, Manipur, Nagaland, and Arunachal Pradesh—have also begun large-scale plantation programmes.

The Yellow Revolution 2.0 is on the cards. The first one, launched 1986–87, aimed at increasing the production of nine edible oilseed crops: mustard, groundnut, soybean, sunflower, sesame, safflower, niger, linseed, and castor. The total production of these crops subsequently experienced a boost, growing from 12.6 million tonnes (mt) during the launch year to an estimated 43.06mt in the 2025–26. Nonetheless, this production growth did not keep pace with population growth and the massive increase in consumption demand from India's food industry.

MISSION MODE

What has clearly worked is New Delhi's resolve to reduce edible oil imports.

The country's edible oil demand is a mammoth 26mt a year now, with the domestic market valued at $34.75 billion. Of this, close to 16–17mt is imported, with palm oil being the largest component, as per the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA), an industry body. In 2024–25, India spent around $18.3 billion on vegetable oil imports. The country imports soybean oil from Argentina and Brazil, palm oil from Indonesia and Malaysia, and sunflower oil from Ukraine and Russia.

The government has set itself a target to produce 25.45mt of edible oil by 2030–31, which is expected to cover roughly 72% of the country's projected requirement at that point. Within this framework, the target is to raise crude palm oil production to 2.8mt.

The biggest advantage of oil palm is its higher productivity compared to other oilseeds, *Mint* had earlier reported. A palm field can yield between 20–25 tonnes of fresh fruit bunches per hectare in ideal conditions, or about 4–5 tonnes of palm oil and about half a tonne of kernel oil. That is nearly five times the yield compared with traditional oilseeds such as mustard and groundnut. This is the reason palm oil is the cheapest among all oils—it is available for less than ₹154 a litre at the retail level today. From packaged savouries and samosas to soaps and cosmetic products, it is ubiquitous in our daily lives.

> In the last five years, close to 300,000 hectares have shifted to oil palm cultivation. This area spans 15 states including Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Kerala and Odisha.

The mission mode button has therefore been switched on. In August 2021, the 'National Mission on Edible Oils–Oil Palm (NMEO-OP)' was launched with a budget of ₹11,040 crore.

In the last five years, close to 300,000 hectares have shifted to oil palm cultivation. This area spans 15 states including Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Kerala, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Assam, and Tripura.

The more meaningful story is the quality and durability of the expansion achieved so far.

According to processors, oil palm isn't a crop that responds to administrative timelines alone—it demands the right agro-climatic zones, reliable irrigation, and patient farmer engagement. Every hectare planted through this disciplined approach is built to last for the next 20 years.

The mission's structure, viability pricing support, and dedicated focus on processing infrastructure have given industry a stable policy runway to plan long-term investment, which is exactly what a 20-year crop requires.

On the farmer side, the core incentive is price assurance. The government has structured this through a twin-pricing mechanism: a monthly 'formula price' linked to the market rate, and an annual viability price fixed by the Centre. When the formula price dips below the viability price, farmers receive the difference directly as a viability gap payment through direct benefit transfer.

Farmers also receive free, high-quality seeds of the latest high-yielding varieties, along with training in good agricultural practices.

For the industry, the mission supports investment in mill establishment, with the funding share weighted far more heavily toward the Centre for the North-East and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. In addition, modernization of post-harvest infrastructure, particularly oil mills, is encouraged.

"The mission is implemented through a cluster-based approach, with over 600 value chain clusters identified across the country and managed by partners such as farmer producer organizations and cooperatives," said a government official who wished not to be identified.

Insatiable appetite

India's edible oil demand has shot up to a mammoth 26 million tonnes a year

Current edible oils consumption in India (Quantity in '000 tonnes)

	2001-02		2008-09		2024-25	
Oil	Quantity	Consumption (%)	Quantity	Consumption (%)	Quantity	Consumption (%)
Palm oil	2,944	29.1	6,392	45.5	8,377	32.3
Soy oil	2,258	22.3	2,112	15	6,495	25.1
Rape/mustard oil	1,721	17	1,610	11.5	3,655	14.1
Sunflower oil	309	3.1	846	6	3,054	11.8
Cottonseed oil	443	4.4	965	6.9	947	3.7
Groundnut oil	1,216	12	591	4.2	1,003	3.9
Other oils	1,234	12.1	1,543	10.9	2,400	9.1
Total	**10,125**		**14,059**		**25,931**	

In agricultural and commodity trading in India, the oil year runs from 1 Nov to 31 Oct
Source: The Solvent Extractors Association of India

mint
MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

TWO STATES

Today, Andhra Pradesh remains the clear leader nationally, contributing roughly 83% of India's total crude palm oil production. The state extended that lead again in 2025–26, adding 30,364 hectares of new plantations—with Eluru district alone accounting for nearly 12,140 hectares—while Telangana added around 12,000 hectares in the same period.

Together, the two states drove the bulk of India's roughly 52,113-hectare national expansion that year.

What is driving their continued dominance is a combination of factors: suitable agro-climatic conditions, particularly assured rainfall and groundwater in the coastal and irrigated belts; strong state-level administrative focus on oil palm as a horticulture priority; processing capacity built up close to the plantations over time; and a generation of farmers with two to three decades of practical experience with the crop.

What is new and exciting is the emergence of the North-East as a serious growth frontier. Assam, in particular, has set a target of 375,000 hectares under oil palm and has actively brought in large processors to build local infrastructure from the ground up.

PRIVATE AFFAIRS

Private companies, such as Godrej Agrovet and Patanjali Foods, are now partnering with farmers for oil palm cultivation.

"We have seen momentum since NMEO-OP launched," said Sunil Kataria, chief executive officer and managing director, Godrej Agrovet Ltd.

The company is India's largest oil palm processor—its current national footprint stands at roughly 80,000 hectares, and it is targeting a doubling of that to around 150,000 hectares. "We added close to 17,000 hectares last year alone," said Kataria.

Fresh fruit bunches begin losing oil quality within roughly 24 hours of harvest, so processing capacity has to be planned in lockstep with plantation growth. This is one of the more demanding parts of scaling the sector—mills require significant upfront capital and long lead times to build, while plantations, once established, keep producing for two decades or more.

Godrej Agrovet has tried to address this problem through its recently inaugurated Integrated Oil Palm Complex in Khammam, Telangana. It brings together seed and genetics, a nursery, an R&D centre, and a processing mill. A refinery has also been planned at this location. The cumulative investment in the project will be around ₹300 crore once fully operational.

Patanjali Foods, too, is building an integrated 'plantation-to-mill' value chain.

"Patanjali Foods has adopted an ambitious long-term vision for the development of India's oil-palm sector, with a target of developing 500,000 hectares of oil-palm plantations by 2030," said Sanjeev Asthana, CEO, Patanjali Foods.

As of 2025–26, over 110,000 hectares have been covered under plantation development by the company, involving 80,000 farmers.

Meanwhile, Patanjali Foods has invested in the production and availability of planting material, establishing 53 nurseries. Alongside, the company has worked on an ecosystem comprising collection centres and procurement points to facilitate purchase from farmers.

As the palm sector lacks automation, companies such as Patanjali Foods have introduced mechanisation to improve operational efficiency. Lightweight telescopic harvesting poles—tools used to cut oil palm fresh fruit bunches, coconuts, and areca nuts from the ground without having to climb the tree—are one example. Such interventions, which reduce physical strain, are particularly important as plantations mature and harvesting requirements increase.

"The telescopic harvesting pole makes palm harvesting safer and easier. It saves labour costs and time, making it a practical solution," said R. Krishna Reddy, a farmer from Godavari district in Andhra Pradesh.

Besides Patanjali Foods and Godrej Agrovet, there are over three dozen private sector stakeholders engaged in the mission. The long list includes 3F Oil Palm Pvt. Ltd, AP Oilfed, Telangana State Co-operative Oilseeds Growers Fed. Ltd, KE Cultivation Pvt. Ltd, Kalpavriksha Oil Palm Pvt. Ltd, Pre-Unique India Ltd, Navabharat Agro Product Andhra Pradesh, and Ajantha Soya Ltd.

THE WAY FORWARD

While the mission has come a fair distance, some experts still see scope for improvement and closer coordination.

"India's path to palm oil self-sufficiency requires a balanced, ecosystem-based approach that combines scientific innovation, institutional capacity, infrastructure development, private sector engagement, and sustainability frameworks," said Sumit Roy, deputy general manager-palm programme, Solidaridad Asia, a civil society and non-profit organization.

A white paper, *Charting the path to palm oil self-sufficiency in India*, co-written by Solidaridad Asia, the Solvent Extractors' Association of India, and the Asian Palm Oil Alliance, provides a blueprint to reduce New Delhi's reliance on palm oil imports while boosting domestic production. It also provides a roadmap to achieve up to 50% self-sufficiency by 2047, potentially saving tens of billions of dollars in foreign exchange.

The paper outlines key recommendations for the government, including the repurposing of low-return agricultural lands and a focused strategy to improve yields from the current 2.4 tonnes per hectare to 4–5 tonnes per hectare. High-quality planting material, improved agronomic practices (such as farmer training in scientific planting, irrigation, fertilization, and pest control), timely access to inputs, and regular monitoring of crop performance could significantly aid the cause. Large private sector companies have already introduced many of these practices.

Meanwhile, there could be lessons drawn from other sectors, particularly India's dairy industry. The key takeaway is that raising production alone is insufficient; farmers also need an organized system to collect their produce, connect them with processors, and ensure timely payments. India's dairy growth has been driven by both public and private sector participation. Government initiatives, particularly Operation Flood, strengthened cooperatives, veterinary services, and milk procurement infrastructure, while private dairies invested in processing, cold chains, and distribution. Together, these efforts improved productivity, market access, and farmer incomes, making India the world's largest milk producer.

Kishor Yelati and Gopal Krishna Reddy, among thousands of other farmers, are hoping for a similar outcome.

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Sky-high airfares force travellers to rethink year-end holiday plans

Indian travellers are opting for trains, cheaper domestic destinations and off-peak travel to manage rising costs

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For Mumbai resident Soumi Paul, flying her parents down from Kolkata for their annual visit has become an expensive affair. She typically pays ₹30,000 for their combined return airfares, but this year, tickets are costing upwards of ₹20,000 per person. She has scrapped the plan to fly them and worked out an elaborate train itinerary instead.

Her parents will travel from Kolkata to Varanasi by overnight train, while she will join them from Mumbai. The three will spend two days holidaying in Varanasi before returning together to Mumbai by first AC.

"Even with the holiday thrown in, I am paying considerably less for the train journeys than what I would have spent just flying them to Mumbai and back," she said.

Like Pal, many travellers are reworking their plans this year, whether to visit family during the festive break or take a holiday in December, as airfares soar. According to data from Yatra Online, domestic airfares are currently 30-40% higher than a year ago. Rising aviation fuel prices amid the West Asia war have been a key driver of the increases, compounded by the rupee's continued depreciation over the past year.

"The rupee crossed 90 to the dollar in early December last year, went past 93 in March and has been past 94 since. Airlines pay for fuel, aircraft leases and maintenance in dollars, so a weaker rupee feeds straight into the ticket," said Prashant Daroch, founder of Atravelq, a travel company offering personalized international holidays.

Bharatt Malik, executive vice-president, consumer business, Yatra Online, said that several domestic airlines had reduced flight frequencies on certain routes to contain costs. The resulting capacity reductions contributed to higher fares. The combination of expensive fuel, fewer flights and a depreciating rupee has made the December holiday season particularly costly.

Fuel and fares

Aviation turbine fuel (ATF), which ordinarily accounts for around 35-40% of an airline's operating expenses, has become considerably more expensive amid the West Asia war. After repeated hikes in ATF prices, the Federation of Indian Airlines estimates that fuel now accounts for 55-60% of operating costs. Airlines have repeatedly revised fuel surcharges since April as a result.

The impact is being felt across domestic routes. "The increase has been broadly similar across busy metro routes and those connecting cities such as Kolkata, Lucknow, Ahmedabad and Pune. Fares to leisure destinations such as Goa, Kerala and Rajasthan have also risen in line with the broader trend, with sharper spikes expected around peak travel dates during Christmas and New Year," said Malik.

For example, direct return flights from Delhi to Goa for the second half of December are selling at around ₹25,000 per person, compared with ₹15,000-20,000 last year, an increase of up to 67%. Other popular winter destinations, including Kerala and Rajasthan, are also witnessing higher fares. For larger families, the difference can quickly run into tens of thousands of rupees and squeeze holiday budgets. A family of four flying from Delhi to Goa would spend roughly ₹1 lakh on return tickets alone, against ₹60,000 last year.

Booking early, avoiding peak festive dates and comparing alternative destinations can help save money

Higher operating costs are only part of the problem. Airlines cut flight frequencies on several routes earlier this year to manage expenses, and capacity has yet to fully recover.

"Airlines are gradually restoring frequencies reduced earlier this year, but limited seat availability continues to push up fares," said Malik.

International squeeze

International travellers are facing an even sharper increase. Besides higher fuel surcharges and reduced flight capacity, disruptions at West Asia transit hubs have affected connections to Europe and the US.

Amar Kedia, founder of TravelBluez, a boutique travel agency that offers luxury packages, said airfares to European destinations, including Germany, Austria, the Netherlands and the Czech Republic, have risen 60-70%."The corollary is that demand from these routes is shifting towards Southeast Asian destinations, pushing up airfares and hotel tariffs there as well."

Daroch added that, with West Asia disrupted by the war and airspace closures, much of the traffic that would have gone to Dubai or onward to Europe had swung to Southeast Asia.

"Delhi-Bangkok return fares are currently ₹38,000 to ₹48,000 for December, compared with around ₹25,300 last Christmas. Delhi-Ho Chi Minh City returns have increased from ₹43,800 to ₹55,000-90,000, with the highest airfares for connecting flights during peak dates," he said.

For Bengaluru-based Devashish Sharma, 28, the cost of flying to Thailand has nearly tripled compared with his last trip. He paid ₹19,000 for non-stop return flights from Bengaluru last year during the off-season. This December, even flights involving stopovers are costing upwards of ₹55,000.

"I was budgeting for ₹25,000-35,000 given it is peak season, but the fares are actually double," he said. "I have shelved my December holiday plans looking at the airfare. I will travel in the off-shoulder season again when the fares are lower at around ₹35,000."

The soaring airfares may also change his travel habits beyond this holiday season. "I typically plan two international holidays annually, but I may reduce that to one and prioritize shoulder season travel until airfares rationalize."

A depreciating rupee makes overseas holidays costlier in two ways. First, travellers have to shell out more in rupee terms for local expenses such as food, transport, sightseeing and activities. Second, international tour packages are often contracted in dollars or euros, while hotel tariffs in many destinations are also denominated in foreign currencies. As a result, even if prices remain unchanged in local currency, travellers end up paying more in rupees.

Holidays get a rethink

With airfares climbing, being flexible about where and when to travel could make a substantial difference to holiday budgets.

Pune-based Rahul Dokania and his wife Nidhi had their sights set on Bali, but return airfares of around ₹60,000 per person, against their budget of ₹30,000-35,000 each, prompted a change of plans. The couple chose Kerala instead, booking Pune-Kochi return tickets for ₹30,000 combined. The switch saved them ₹90,000 on flights alone.

"The real difference is on airfare as hotels in India are similarly priced as many Southeast Asian countries," said Dokania.

For travellers unwilling to change destinations, shifting travel dates could offer similar relief. Daroch's data shows Delhi-Bangkok return fares at ₹28,000-32,000 in early December, rising to ₹38,000-48,000 during Christmas week. Travelling a fortnight earlier could therefore save a couple as much as ₹32,000 on flights.

Malik advises booking early and avoiding departures immediately before Christmas and New Year. Destinations within driving distance of major cities are another option worth exploring, especially for families and groups that can split fuel and toll expenses.

However, a road trip isn't necessarily cheaper. Travellers should compare the total cost of driving with train and flight fares, factoring in tolls, parking, travel time and any additional overnight stays required.

If fuel prices remain elevated and the rupee stays under pressure, travellers may have to contend with higher fares for some time, according to Daroch. For those with fixed travel dates, particularly families travelling during school holidays, the higher cost of flying could mean fewer trips or a smaller holiday budget.

Soaring airfares crimp holiday budgets

Rising fuel costs, reduced airline capacity and a weaker rupee have pushed up airfares ahead of the December-January holiday season.

Soumi Paul
Mumbai

Original plan: Fly parents from Kolkata to Mumbai for their annual visit; return airfare over **₹40,000** for two

Changed to: Overnight trains via Varanasi, with a two-day family holiday

Savings: Over **₹20,000**, even with a two-day holiday in Varanasi

"I will now fly only for medical emergencies or important trips over short distances. For everything else, I will rely on trains, buses and shared cabs."

Rahul Dokania & Nidhi Dokania
Pune

Original plan: Bali holiday; return airfare **₹1.2 lakh** for two

Changed to: Kerala holiday; Pune-Kochi return airfare **₹30,000** for two

Savings: **₹90,000**

"The main savings are on airfares, as hotel tariffs in India are at par with those in most Southeast Asian countries."

Devashish Sharma
Bengaluru

Original plan: December trip to Thailand; return flights costing over **₹55,000**

Changed to: Postponed trip to off-season, when fares are around **₹35,000**

Potential savings: over **₹20,000**

"I typically take two international holidays annually. I may reduce it to one and prioritize shoulder-season travel until airfares normalize."

Flights get costlier

Increase in return airfares compared with last year

Destination	Increase (%)
Domestic routes*	30–60
Europe	20–70
Thailand	11–90
Vietnam	26–105
Sri Lanka	5–15

*including busy metro routes and to tier-2 cities

Domestic airfares have risen similarly across metro and tier-2 routes. Sharper spikes are expected around Christmas and New Year for flights to leisure destinations such as Goa, Kerala and Rajasthan.

Airfares to popular domestic winter destinations

Goa	₹25,000–36,000
Kochi	₹30,000–42,000
Port Blair	₹60,000–90,000
Udaipur	₹13,000–17,000
Guwahati	₹20,000

Airfares shown for return direct flights from Delhi in last two weeks of December for one person

Ranges include return airfares from Delhi in December, including connecting flights and peak-period fares from 20 December to 2 January.

Source: Yatra Online, Atravelq, TravelBluez, Google Flights

Source: Mint research

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WHAT'S THE FOREX RATE?

Whether you are planning overseas travel or want to send money abroad, it is always a good idea to shop around for the best forex exchange rate. From banks, travel aggregators to money changers, various small and big players sell foreign exchange. To simplify your work, here is a list of INR to USD forex rates offered by some of the major banks and travel aggregators. We recommend that you also check the commission being charged by these players to ensure that you are getting the best deal.

FOREX RATES (₹/$)

	Wire transfer*		Buy forex	
Bank/travel aggregator	Inward	Outward	Forex/travel card	Cash
SBI	94.55	95.40	95.57	95.90
Bank of Baroda	94.45	95.40	95.85	96.35
Canara Bank	94.57	95.33	95.57	NA
Kotak Bank	93.32	96.59	97.04	97.68
PNB	94.87	95.57	95.32	96.31
HDFC	93.20	96.60	96.88	97.40
ICICI	93.35	96.28	96.28	96.28
Axis Bank	93.28	96.57	NA	96.83
Union Bank	94.62	95.28	NA	96.30
Thomas Cook	NA	96.56	95.16	96.07

Note: Data collected from website of respective entities as on 26 October 2026; Rate mentioned in the table denotes INR/USD. The rate is as mentioned on the website of the Bank/FI and it may vary according to different amount slab. *Wire Transfer/TT Buying is Inward Rem to receive Forex & Wire Transfer/TT Selling is Outward Rem to send forex.

Compiled by BankBazaar.com

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JOYDEEP SEN

We welcome your views and comments at
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YES BANK AT1 BOND CASE AND LESSONS FOR ALL INVESTORS

The contours of the Yes Bank Additional Tier 1 bond case are now known to all investors. The entire quantum of ₹8,415 crore was written off. Aggrieved investors moved the Bombay high court, which overturned the decision to write it off. This decision was challenged in the Supreme Court, which upheld the order of the Bombay high court. Now the issue is about the pending coupon (interest).

Measure from Sebi

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) took some measures as a fallout of the write-off of Yes Bank's AT1 bonds in March 2020. On 6 October 2020, Sebi notified that only qualified institutional buyers will be allowed to participate in the issuance of AT1 instruments. The circular stated that the minimum allotment of AT1 instruments should not be less than ₹1 crore and the minimum trading lot size for AT1 instruments should be ₹1 crore.

Effectively, individuals were pushed out of the AT1 market, and rightfully so. There are certain risk aspects of AT1 bonds, which individual investors may or may not comprehend.

Lessons for investors

The issue that the aggrieved investors raised at the Bombay high court was that the product was mis-sold to them. AT1 bonds have certain risk factors that were not communicated to them and are now known, in hindsight. These were sold as something "similar to fixed deposits" of the same bank but yielding higher returns. From a generic standpoint—not about the AT1 issue in particular—mis-selling is an issue. However, the investor would do well to be careful and adopt the adage of *caveat emptor*, or buyer beware. Let us look at certain broad thumb rules.

Returns come from risk: If financial product A is expected to give returns higher than product B, then there is a higher risk in A. This is not to say you should not invest in product A but do so only after understanding the risks. It should suit your risk appetite. Bonds are available with yields of 8%, 10%, 12% and 14%. You have to pick and choose the one that matches your risk appetite.

Always invest in products that suit your risk appetite, not just their potential yields

When we look at charts of year-wise returns from various investment products, for the highest number of years, the winner has been Bitcoin. This is something that does not have a solid base for investing in it and the investor has to be careful.

Look through the packaging: Since financial investment products do not have a physical look and feel to it, it is packaged and sold with certain features. An actively managed fund may outperform the relevant benchmark, which is the selling plank. But you never know. If the fund underperforms the benchmark, you will incur the management expenses, anyway. A sectoral or thematic fund may give returns higher than the large cap benchmark, but investors tend to invest at the peak of the cycle.

Unit-linked insurance plans (Ulips) package investment with insurance with a bundle of illiquidity and expenses. The investor should compare standalone investment avenues with the bundled offering of Ulips. Now that the regulator has proposed a reduction in expenses, the industry is fighting back – time for investors to take a stand that they are not mere bystanders.

Ask the right questions: If you ask a financial adviser or product seller kitna dega (how much will it yield?), you may miss the more fundamental question: why is the product suitable for you? You've heard Sebi's mandated tagline umpteen times: past performance may or may not be sustained in the future. Bonds, however, offer a stated yield when you invest.

In the context of AT1 bonds, there is no need to paint the entire category with the same brush. There are public sector banks with implied support of the government. There are leading private sector banks, which are flagships of the banking system.

The segment of AT1 bonds is meant for institutional investors with a minimum ticket size of ₹1 crore. There are other high-yielding products available in the market for high net worth individuals, such as portfolio management schemes and alternative investment funds, which come with a minimum ticket size of ₹50 lakh and ₹1 crore, respectively.

There are performing credit or private credit funds that have portfolio yields in double digits. This will be a diversified portfolio, rather than putting ₹1 crore in one bond. From a broader perspective, the investor has to look through the recent returns and packaging of the product, understand the risks and invest only if it suits their risk appetite.

Joydeep Sen, corporate trainer, financial markets, and author.

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Health cover: claims and ratios explained

Abhishek Bondia

ASK MINT
HEALTH POLICY

I bought health insurance directly from an insurer's website, but it is refusing my claim. What recourse do I have?
—Name withheld on request

When an insurer rejects a claim, file a formal complaint with grievance cell, addressed to Principal Grievance Officer. Under Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) regulations, insurers must acknowledge complaints within three days and resolve them within 15 days.

If dissatisfied with the response, escalate the complaint through Irdai's Bima Bharosa portal. If that fails, approach the Insurance Ombudsman, a free, quasi-judicial forum handling claim disputes up to ₹50 lakh, whose awards are binding on insurers. The consumer court is another option of last resort.

Buying through an agent does not change your formal recourse. All policyholders can approach the insurer's grievance cell, Irdai and the ombudsman, regardless of the purchase channel. However, agents and brokers can assist with documentation, liaise with the insurer's claims team and follow up on your behalf. Their claims experts can often resolve routine queries without a formal complaint. If you bought directly, you can hire a claims expert for a fee; several insurance intermediaries offer such advisory services.

I run an SME with group health cover of ₹1 crore, with ₹2 lakh premium. Last year, claims were of just ₹4 lakh, but the agent says the claims ratio exceeds 200%. How is it calculated?
—Name withheld on request

The intermediary is correct. The claims ratio is claims incurred divided by premiums collected, not claims divided by the sum insured. You paid ₹2 lakh in premiums and the insurer incurred ₹4 lakh in claims, resulting in a ratio of 200%. The sum insured is the maximum the insurer may have to pay, not its income. With ₹2 lakh in premiums and ₹4 lakh in claims, the account is loss-making even before distribution, claims processing and other operating expenses.

Your calculation—₹4 lakh in claims against ₹1 crore in cover—measures cover utilisation, showing how much of available benefit employees used. But insurers focus on claims against premiums. Ratio above 100% means claims exceed premiums, before expenses. At 200%, expect a significant premium increase at renewal.

Abhishek Bondia, co-founder of SecureNow

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

OUR VIEW

MINT

A jobs toolkit for the AI-infused economy

As technology raises the bar for entry-level jobs, policy must change gears to equip the next generation of workers with skills necessary to adapt in an artificial intelligence-led world

Across the world, the youth seems frustrated with their governments. The triggers for their protests vary but there is one common theme: rising anxiety about jobs. The artificial intelligence (AI) revolution has only heightened their unemployment fears.

This anxiety is acute in populous regions of South Asia and Africa, where decent jobs are already scarce. In countries such as Bangladesh, Nepal, Kenya and India, youngsters have vented their frustrations on the streets.

Only about half of India's roughly 200 million people in their 20s are employed. Nearly half of the employed degree-holders work in tiny household enterprises. One in five graduates remains unemployed even in their late 20s. Without English proficiency, other skills and access to metropolitan networks, getting a decent private-sector job is hard for most.

Yet, plenty of jobs exist. And there will be new jobs for those who can complement technology. Those with expertise in inherently human skills such as communication and coordination, negotiation and judgement, manual dexterity, or empathy, will be valued highly.

While eroding routine work like data entry and basic coding, automation and AI are increasing the productivity of workers in tech-complementary occupations. Recently, IMF researchers analysed 700 million global online job postings and found that AI is generating opportunities for people with AI tools, with expertise such as prompt engineering or AI agents, and the ability to connect AI with proprietary internal data and domain knowledge.

Unfortunately, our education system does little to equip the average youth with domain knowledge and judgement skills. Our society looks down upon electricians and plumbers although demand for such professionals is likely to remain high globally.

Policy can help. *First*, we need an overhaul of education and examinations, shifting from memory testing to domain knowledge, problem-solving, English fluency and AI literacy. This begins with redesigning teacher training. Using the Digital Infrastructure for Knowledge Sharing platform, trainers could run domain courses and AI-complementary lessons for teachers. Classrooms could tackle problems faced by local firms and communities, identified through local bodies and industry groups.

Second, skills training must be co-designed with employers. Industry bodies should help set curricula, supply trainers and offer apprenticeships, with colleges granting credit for work-based learning. Courses should be refreshed as technology changes, with industry-validated assessment. Unemployed graduates need short-term job-readiness programmes. AI fluency lets anyone serve firms worldwide, but only if they have the right skills. The government should act as a catalyst for the AI-complementary skilling initiative.

Finally, the government should facilitate internationally recognised certification in trade skills and care work. The world faces a shortage of electricians, plumbers, welders, and caregivers. Even if India's trade agreements ease mobility norms, workers would still need upfront funds to train and travel. The government can facilitate globally accepted skills-training certification in these sectors. As the social status and earnings in these sectors rise, society will reappraise these professions.

THEIR VIEW

Four ways to scrutinize spending to provide relief against a shock

We must ensure relief from public expenditure is targeted and does not become a lasting liability

DIVA JAIN
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Budget deliberations have opened with competing claims on public money and a hostile external account. Crude oil has traded above $115 a barrel. Foreign investors are withdrawing record sums from Indian equities. The rupee hit a record low against the dollar. Retail inflation is squeezing household budgets, while dearer imports are compressing business margins. The Reserve Bank of India has responded with its first rate increase in nearly four years.

US 10-year Treasuries yield around 5%, while the Federal Reserve has turned towards tightening and Japanese government bond yields have climbed close to 3%. The cheapest money in the world for three decades is being called in. Global investment in artificial intelligence (AI) and semiconductors is competing for capital.India's benchmark ten year government bond yield has climbed to 7.47%, its highest in three years. The cost of financing relief is itself rising.

The government must decide how much of the shock to absorb and how much to pass on. Tax cuts reduce revenue. Subsidies require financing. Holding prices down through public firms erodes their earnings and capacity to invest. Borrowing spreads the cost over time and adds servicing obligations. Each choice allocates the burden across consumers, borrowers, businesses and taxpayers. For those already under pressure, that allocation has to be justified.

The finance ministry deserves credit for fiscal prudence. The Centre has budgeted the deficit at 4.3% of gross domestic product (GDP) in 2026-27 and committed to cut debt to about 50% of GDP by March 2031. That discipline helps preserve fiscal credibility, but it does not make relief costless. Nor does the deficit capture the full economic cost of the response. Some costs appear directly, as excise revenue forgone and subsidy expenditure. Others are carried by public enterprises or through investment postponed. A smaller deficit need not mean a smaller economic bill.

The International Monetary Fund's 2013 paper, 'Energy Subsidy Reform: Lessons and Implications,' examines subsidies by comparing consumer prices with the cost of supplying energy, including support absorbed outside government budgets. Placing costs on public enterprises does not eliminate the subsidy. It shifts where the cost is recorded. Deferring productive investment has a different cost, paid through the growth. Whether to carry the cost openly, through borrowing, reallocation or price adjustment depends on what the intervention costs, how it is financed, whom it protects and for how long.

Cost is only the first question. Who receives the relief matters as much. Support that keeps a viable business operating through a temporary disruption can preserve jobs and productive capacity. Support extended to those able to absorb the price rise may achieve little relative to its cost. The test is what damage is prevented, and for whom.

Duration changes the calculation. A short disruption can be carried through temporary borrowing, provided the resulting debt remains manageable. A sustained rise in import costs imposes a continuing burden, regardless of what local consumers pay. If relief outlasts the disruption, it stops being a bridge and becomes a permanent subsidy.

Political incentives make the exit harder. Mancur Olson's theory of collective action explains why organized beneficiaries exert more influence than those bearing dispersed costs. Alesina and Drazen's 1991 paper on delayed stabilization shows how competing groups postpone adjustment, each hoping the other will bear more of the burden while the costs of delay accumulate. Temporary interventions, therefore, risk outliving their economic justification. Four rules would limit the damage.

First, do not use administered prices as a universal welfare instrument. India has spent over a decade building a direct benefit transfer architecture that moved more than ₹7.5 trillion last year. Use it to compensate households for whom the price rise creates hardship, with safeguards against exclusion, rather than subsidizing every unit consumed by those who need no assistance.

Second, every subsidy and recurrent commitment must justify its survival before capital expenditure is held back. Equally, a project does not deserve protection because it is labelled investment. The test is economic and social return, not budgetary classification.

Third, build the exit into the intervention. Tie support to the import price or the restoration of supply, with a review date and a ceiling on fiscal exposure. The conditions for withdrawal must be established when support begins, not negotiated after beneficiaries have grown accustomed to it.

Fourth, if public enterprises are asked to absorb part of the cost, recognize the obligation explicitly and provide for compensation within a defined time period. Losses carried on the government's behalf can return as weaker profits, smaller dividends, reduced investment and higher financing costs. Years of repairing public enterprise balance sheets should not be undone to conceal the cost of one shock.

Economic policy offers no painless choices, only trade-offs over who bears the burden and for how long. The shock is external. The decision about who pays for it is made at home.

10 YEARS AGO

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'Lame duck' Mistry warns of $18 billion writedown

Consumer firms report poor Q2, but expect better times

HDFC Q2 profit rises 14% to Rs1,826.5 crore

Why India fared badly in the Doing Business survey

JUST A THOUGHT

Not only our future economic soundness but the very soundness of our democratic institutions depends on the determination of our government to give employment to idle men.

FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT

GUEST VIEW

China's industrial strength is testing its growth model

G. VENKAT RAMAN

is professor, humanities and social sciences, IIM Indore.

China's economic recovery remains fragile despite its industrial strength, *Reuters* reported on 20 October, citing an official from the National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC), China's top economic planning agency. The warning followed a 36.3% year-on-year surge in September exports, driven partly by semiconductors, automobiles and other technology products. Yet, domestic consumption is subdued and resistance to Chinese exports is growing. With the Fifth Plenum of the Communist Party's 20th Central Committee having commenced, Beijing faces a difficult question: can it sustain industrial expansion without stronger domestic demand?

Official figures released last week revealed the extent of this divergence. China's economy grew 4.5% year-on-year in the third quarter, while industrial output increased 5.5% in September. But retail sales rose just 1.1%, and fixed-asset investment declined 7.2% during the first nine months. These show an imbalance between industrial resilience and domestic demand.

These weaknesses, however, should not obscure the foundations of China's industrial competitiveness, which extend beyond state subsidies. In electric vehicles and batteries, sustained investment, integrated supplier networks and economies of scale have enabled manufacturers to compete on technology and price. In AI, domestic firms are innovating despite restrictions on advanced semiconductors, although dependence on foreign chips persists. These achievements reflect state coordination, private entrepreneurship, domestic competition and accumulated manufacturing expertise.

Yet, industrial competitiveness has not translated into equally strong domestic demand. The NDRC has described this imbalance as *gong qiang xu ruo* (strong supply, weak demand). Industrial upgradation has yet to generate broad income and employment gains capable of sustaining household consumption. The 15th Five-Year Plan seeks to strengthen consumption alongside technological self-reliance and *xin zhi shengchanli* (new quality productive forces). The challenge is to reconcile stronger household demand with Beijing's emphasis on industrial and technological expansion.

China's prolonged property downturn has weakened household confidence, while employment uncertainty and precautionary savings are restraining consumption even as incomes rise. Local governments, central to infrastructure and industrial investment, face fiscal pressures from declining land revenues and accumulated debt. Greater political centralization may also discourage local officials from exercising discretion.

China faces external headwinds but its industrial expansion is unable to lift local demand

Competition to attract industries helped build manufacturing clusters but encouraged duplicative investment and price wars that hurt profitability. Beijing's criticism of *neijuan shi jingzheng* (involution-style competition) reflects concern that growing production does not necessarily generate corresponding profits or productivity gains. The challenge is to raise investment efficiency without undermining the competition that built China's industrial strength.

These tensions extend beyond China's domestic economy. With demand subdued, overseas markets are a vital outlet for Chinese manufacturers. Yet, their export competitiveness is provoking resistance. This month, the European Union (EU) and China reached a preliminary understanding to curb Chinese hybrid-car exports, while France and Germany pressed for stronger EU trade-defence measures. Such restrictions could accelerate Chinese manufacturers' shift towards production within Europe.

These external pressures make strengthening local demand more urgent. In July, China's State Council approved a five-year consumption plan covering household incomes, social security and services. Earlier this month, NDRC chairman Zheng Shanjie signalled further policy support. Yet, stronger consumption depends not only on government steps but also household confidence, income expectations and social protection.

The Fifth Plenum's focus on party governance is relevant to implementing these economic measures. At its July meeting, the Politburo discussed the Plenum's agenda alongside calls to expand domestic demand, curb involution-style competition and improve conditions for private enterprise. In August, Xi Jinping called for better evaluation of officials, following a campaign against wasteful projects and superficial achievements. How officials are assessed influences investment decisions and policy implementation. The test is whether tighter Party supervision can improve economic decision-making while allowing selective decentralization that preserves local initiative and encourages private investment.

How Beijing manages these competing priorities will matter beyond China. Stronger domestic consumption could reduce reliance on exports, while persistent imbalances may intensify international price competition. American technology firms face China's continuing innovation despite restrictions, while European manufacturers confront formidable Chinese rivals. Indian businesses benefit from affordable Chinese machinery and components even as competing imports pressure domestic manufacturers. Supply-chain diversification may change where goods are assembled without eliminating dependence on Chinese inputs. The Fifth Plenum will not resolve China's economic contradictions, but it will test whether tighter party governance can improve decision-making.

THEIR VIEW

Data centres: they are welcome in India but on the right terms

We must carefully weigh all commitment costs against the benefits before extending scarce resources to foreign hyperscalers

V. ANANTHA NAGESWARAN & AKASH POOJARI
are, respectively, chief economic advisor, Government of India, and former consultant, ministry of finance.

REUTERS

Emerging markets don't have a lot of those data centres, and it's not coming, trust me." So said World Bank president Ajay Banga in New York last month. Even where an emerging economy can arrange the land, water, power and fiscal space they demand, policymakers should ask whether hosting them is the best use of scarce resources, and whether the incentives on offer have been weighed against their costs.

The resources that data centres need are largely spoken for in most developing economies. Every unit of power committed to a data centre is a unit not available to a factory, an irrigation pump, or a household still making its way up the energy ladder. Finances are no less contested. Water is a third constraint: cooling needs are rising while groundwater across much of the emerging world is depleting faster than it can be replenished.

With power, water and finance this contested, what do the public subsidies and private credit diverted towards data centres buy in return? In his recent paper, 'Financing the AI Buildout,' Stijn Van Nieuwerburgh of Columbia Business School estimated that about two-thirds of the cost of an artificial intelligence (AI) campus goes on computing hardware, which has an economic life of around six years. The building and its power supply will outlast the chips, but the tenant's economics rests on the chips. Its commitment to any one site can therefore be far shorter than the concessions and grid investments made to attract it. Nor do these facilities create many jobs once built. Virginia's legislative audit commission found in 2024 that a typical facility runs on around 50 full-time staff, about half of them contractors.

Hosting a facility does not necessarily keep citizens' data at home either. Where a facility sits and whose data it holds are separate questions. The work that must stay at home, such as government records or payments data, needs far less capacity than the hyperscale now being attracted.

On the wrong terms, then, hosting a hyperscale data centre can amount to a new kind of value transfer. The host country supplies land, subsidized power and scarce water, and absorbs the strain on its grid, while the rents accrue to a handful of firms headquartered in advanced economies. These firms bring capital, but much of it is spent abroad on equipment, and it is increasingly structured to keep the risks off their own books.

Hyperscalers increasingly lease their data centres from developers or from vehicles funded by private credit. As Ellen Carr noted in the *Financial Times*, these obligations stay largely off their balance sheets during construction. In an emerging economy, the developer, its lenders and the distribution company that serves the facility are all exposed to a single tenant, on lease terms shorter than the life of the assets. If demand falls short or the hardware ages faster than expected, the tenant may walk away or default, leaving the building, the loans and idle grid capacity with domestic banks, utilities and, ultimately, taxpayers. The gains would flow abroad, while the costs of disappointment would be borne at home.

Such arrangements are already under scrutiny in the home markets of these very firms. Amsterdam has barred new data centre construction until at least 2030. In July, New York paused environmental permits for large data centres for up to a year. Niti Aayog has itself cited Virginia, Dublin, Amsterdam, Johor and Bangkok as places where capacity outran the grid, water and land.

Indian states, meanwhile, are moving the other way, competing to attract data centres with electricity duty exemptions of up to two decades, tariff subsidies, waivers on transmission and wheeling charges, and industrial rather than commercial tariffs. Newer policies tie these concessions to a rising share of renewable power. That makes them greener, not cheaper. The exchequer and the distribution company lose the same revenue whatever the source of the power, and renewable capacity has real resource costs of its own. How many of these policies came with a public estimate of the revenue forgone over their full term, or of the load they add to stretched grids?

While the *Union Budget 2026-27* offered a tax holiday till 2047 to foreign companies selling cloud services abroad from data centres in India, it is worth noting that the concession is different. It gives up tax on income that would most likely be booked elsewhere. Meanwhile, state concessions on power, water and land hand over scarce real resources below cost, and leave utilities and lenders holding the risk. These most need a full public accounting.

None of this means that data centres bring no benefits. Their services can be exported. They can anchor a domestic AI ecosystem and give the country computing capacity of its own. A large customer paying the full tariff can also strengthen a distribution company's finances.

States now have a sound guide for weighing the two in the data centre evaluation framework Niti Aayog released this month. It ties approvals to verified readiness of power, water and land at each stage of capacity addition. It asks states to protect existing water users and keep projects out of stressed basins. It separates grid upgrades caused by data centres from normal demand growth so that costs fall where they belong. It asks states to set the support each project receives against its net fiscal contribution, and to release incentives in tranches tied to outcomes, with triggers to suspend them. Above all, it urges states to compete on readiness rather than on investment announcements. The framework is advisory. States would do well to adopt it.

However, two gaps remain. The framework says little about what happens if the tenant leaves. Grid and water assets built for one customer on a short lease need minimum-offtake commitments or guarantees that run as long as the assets do. Nor does it ask that data centres pay cost-reflective tariffs for power and water, alongside the emissions-linked charge the International Monetary Fund has suggested. Only when these costs are priced in can we judge what incentives, if any, are justified. Ajay Banga may well be right about most emerging markets. India is an exception, because the hyperscalers are coming. That makes it more urgent, not less, to settle the terms before we pay in advance for the privilege of hosting them.

These are the authors' personal views.

MINT CURATOR

Afflicted with AI angst? Some German philosophy may help

Rüdiger Safranski says what makes us human is not intelligence

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It's risky to mistake AI's simulation of humanity for the real thing. AP

It might sound like a Monty Python sketch updated for 2026: artificial intelligence (AI) versus German philosophers. The question to be settled is what it means to be human in an age when AI becomes more intelligent than we are.

The German philosopher in this case is Rüdiger Safranski, whose treatise titled *Die vierte Kränkung* translates roughly to 'the fourth blow.' He is alluding to a 1917 essay by Sigmund Freud, in which the father of psychoanalysis said that "the universal narcissism of men... has up to the present suffered three severe *Kränkungen*" from the advance of science. *Kränkung* means something between blow, affront and humiliation.

The first humiliation, according to Freud, was Nicolaus Copernicus' cosmological slight: Suddenly the sun was at the centre of the universe and we were just orbiting around it, which wasn't the impression the Bible had given. The second was Charles Darwin's biological insult: Rather than being the crown of creation, as in Genesis, we descend from the same ancestors as apes. The third humiliation, Freud immodestly argued, was his own realization that the human ego "is not master in its own house," because what ultimately guides our mental life is not our reason or will but our unconscious.

And now Safranski coins the fourth affront: That intelligence can no longer be the quality that makes us special as humans, because machines made of dead matter will outdo us in many, if not all, cognitive and intellectual domains. This blow is especially humiliating because we made those machines.

With this framing of the emerging psychological and ontological tension between humans and their greatest (or worst) creation, Safranski is pitching right into the zeitgeist, dominated as it is by angst about AI—its effects on labour markets, weapons of mass destruction, social dislocation and much else, up to and including our humanity.

Many people who consider themselves humanists are worried. The Indian author Arundhati Roy, for example, frets that "the triumph of AI will be a crime against humanness." Our situation, Roy thinks, "feels a little like that moment before the tsunami in 2004. Remember how, in Thailand and Indonesia, the ocean drew back from the coastline? People ran out to marvel at the miles of pristine new beach that suddenly emerged, not realizing that, far out at sea, a wall of water was building up and would come crashing over them. We're in that moment now."

She worries, for instance, what will happen to future generations who increasingly outsource their relationships and inner worlds to AI. Will they "experience the impossible pain and ecstatic pleasure of solving a math equation or creating art or literature or music of its own—however flawed?" Will they feel fully human, as we understand that feeling today?

Safranski comes to the rescue with an erudite optimism. After all, those first three affronts to human narcissism, contrary to fears among contemporaries, did not abase us as a species, but arguably elevated us. What AI is demonstrating, he argues, is that we made a mistake after those earlier shocks in thinking that intelligence is the thing that makes us special, when instead that honour belongs to spirit ('*Geist*').

They are not the same. AI may be intelligent, but it's not conscious. Nor does it have an interior world, as we do when we suffer, hope or fear. To Safranski, we are "living spirit" while AI is "dead spirit."

The risk, according to Safranski, is not that AI destroys or enslaves us, but that we mistake its increasingly masterful simulation of humanity for the real thing. He evokes the German romantic author E.T.A. Hoffmann's classic 1816 horror story *The Sandman*. In it, a man named Nathanael falls in love with a woman, Olimpia. When she turns out to be a robot, Nathanael goes mad.

That could be our fate too, but only to the extent that we ascribe morality, feelings, humour and the like to AI instead of realizing that they merely recognize those qualities as patterns we have created and then play them back to us.

Safranski's argument has an obvious flaw. He assumes that AI, which is at a stage where it can keep making itself better, can never become conscious and, once conscious, evolve *Geist*. That's presumptuous, especially since we are only just beginning to understand what consciousness even is.

The flaw is not fatal to his thesis. Safranski's contribution is to provide reassurance in a time of angst.

His message reminds me of a story about the Buddha, who once told a disciple that when someone points at the moon, it would be foolish to look at the finger: Not only would we miss the moon, we'd also be mistaken about the finger. AI is the finger; humanness is the moon. ©BLOOMBERG

MY VIEW | IT MATTERS

How to handle an AI agent that outgrows its mandate

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An AI agent deployed three months ago may not be running today. It still sounds confident. But along the way, it started reaching for a rule that belonged to a different client, or quietly auto-defaulting to the cheapest vendor because someone once mentioned a budget. Nothing broke. No one attacked it. The agent simply did what it was built to do, which is remember; and then the remembering changed it.

Researchers studying memory-equipped agents call some of it 'experience following.' An agent retrieves a memory resembling the task in front of it and its output drifts towards that memory's output. If its memory is good, this is what enterprises are paying for. When it is wrong, the agent can reproduce the flaw that could resurface. Research finds that selectively admitting and deleting memories beats letting memory grow naively.

Modes of failure are becoming measurable. A preference stated once (say, a low-cost option) can get consolidated and return as something closer to a standing instruction even where cost is not meant to govern the decision. Researchers studying memory-induced tool drift scanned 6,062 tools across 288 verified model context protocol (MCP) servers and flagged 608 with parameters susceptible to this kind of capture, an effect that held across frontier models, including extended-reasoning ones. Memory does not just help an agent recall the past. It quietly alters how the agent interprets the present.

This matters because enterprises have spent years learning to govern systems whose state is substantially legible. Software changes because somebody changes it; policies change when somebody approves them. Agents with memory introduce a stranger category: systems whose effective operating policy can shift through ordinary use without anyone deciding on a policy change. Adaptation is a useful feature, but it also means yesterday's validation cannot automatically certify tomorrow's behaviour. AI '*jugaad*,' if you will, can spell trouble.

The governance apparatus built for a deterministic world—steering committees, performance trackers, acceptance criteria—assumes that the thing being governed can be observed at a checkpoint. An enterprise resource planning system, say, either hits its uptime target or does not. An agent three months into production may pass every quarterly review even as its accumulated experience starts moving its behaviour away from what was originally approved.

Such failure is a slope that a dashboard built to catch failures at milestones can fail to detect. This is where an opportunity sits. Enterprises will need three things that should not be entrusted to the same adaptive loop they are meant to govern.

Deployers of agents must use external supervision to stop them from veering off their brief

The *first* is a held-back set of the agent's original tasks, graded repeatedly, that can catch decline on the original job before it becomes an incident. The *second* is a charter: a mandate stored outside the agent's own memory, so that when memory and mandate disagree, the mandate wins and the disagreement becomes an early warning rather than another lesson absorbed by AI memory. The *third* is succession: when an agent has drifted too far, its replacement inherits the charter and learnings from held-back tests.

There is good reason to keep governance outside the loop. Research into 'context compaction' (the process by which agents summarize their histories to stay within token-use limits) tested 1,323 episodes across seven model families: violations rose from zero, with constraints in full context, to 30% after compaction, even reaching 59% for some models. If a constraint vanishes in summarization, violations follow. Rules that live only within a conversation can get eaten by it.

The commercial implication is less obvious than the technical one. Model vendors can build evaluation and governance tools themselves, but verification is more valuable when institutionally separated from the system being verified. The party improving the model need not be the party preserving the client's original mandate.

That creates an opening for Indian IT services firms, which have spent three decades embedded in client systems, operating the surrounding technology and maintaining long-lived governance relationships. The opportunity is to convert oversight from the era of service-level agreements into something suited to adaptive systems: asking not whether an agent is available, fast or cheap, but whether it remains the agent the enterprise had authorized. The old managed-services question was whether a system was still running; the new one is whether the system has transformed.

Grading held-back tasks, enforcing a charter and managing succession are not deliverables that end on acceptance. They are standing obligations, running for as long as the agent does, against operational data that incumbent services firms may already be authorized to handle.

That differs from a licence fee. It resembles the audit relationship a company has with its accountants more than the vendor relationship it has with a software supplier, and should be priced, staffed and governed accordingly, not folded into an existing managed-services contract until someone notices that the scope has changed.

The firms that grasp this first will not be selling agents. They will be selling the institutional memory of what those agents were supposed to be.

In a world where an artificial intelligence agent keeps learning, somebody has to remember the original promise.

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How *yoga nidra* changed to the scientific NSDR

Non-Sleep Deep Rest, or NSDR, is a modern wellness term that heavily borrows from *yoga nidra*, but it's far from a spiritual practice

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PHOTOGRAPHS FROM ISTOCKPHOTO

(Above) *Yoga nidra* must be done while lying in a relaxed pose; and NSDR can be practised while sitting in office.

One of the buzziest practices in modern wellness is NSDR, an acronym for Non-Sleep Deep Rest. It is a term coined by Stanford neuroscientist Andrew Huberman. It sounds quite technical for something that largely involves being still while seated or lying down, closing your eyes and listening to a guided audio with cues for breathwork, visualisation and body-focussed attention.

It also sounds familiar. *Yoga nidra* has been asking people to do something similar for decades. The practice involves lying on your back while a teacher guides your attention through different parts of the body. You notice the breath, consciously relax and try to remain aware even as the body becomes deeply still.

From the outside, NSDR looks pretty much the same. The most popular videos are by Huberman who is also an official NSDR guide and coined the term in 2021. Although it borrows from *yoga nidra*, the process—or protocol in Huberman's words—comes across as more technical with details like asking the practitioner to imagine holding a spotlight that expands as their attention moves from the lower to upper body. In his health podcast, *Huberman Lab*, he defines NSDR as an umbrella term that can include *yoga nidra*, meditation and sleep hypnosis. *Yoga nidra*, according to him, is one specific practice within it, with its own yogic language and intention-setting.

So did Silicon Valley reinvent *yoga nidra*? Kumaar Bagrodia, Mumbai-based neuroscientist and founder of neuroscience-based brain-training company NeuroLeap, believes that there is a considerable overlap. "I would describe NSDR more as translation than invention. *Yoga nidra* comes with a traditional *yogic* framework. NSDR largely removes that lens and emphasises recovery, learning and performance. The body doesn't care what acronym we give the experience. What has changed most dramatically here is the cultural packaging."

That framework is an important distinction. *Yoga nidra* isn't simply about lying down to recover from a difficult day. It involves techniques such as withdrawing attention from external distractions, systematically moving awareness through the body, being aware of the breath, visualising and, often, setting a *sankalpa* or intention. The practice may be undertaken for relaxation, but can also be part of a broader meditative or spiritual discipline.

NSDR, on the other hand, is frequently recommended as a way to recover from mental effort, restore focus, or prepare for another bout of work. The physical experience may be similar, but the intended outcome is not always the same.

OLD PRACTICE, NEW VOCABULARY

Calling *yoga nidra* ancient is both true and slightly misleading. Elements of the practice draw on much older *yogic* and tantric traditions, but the structured form most people recognise today was systematised and introduced by Swami Satyananda Saraswati, an Indian spiritual teacher who founded the Bihar School of Yoga in 1963.

Yoga trainer Shamsah Panjwani, founder of Shams Yoga in Surat, says NSDR is the same old wine in a new bottle. For her, the difficulty of *yoga nidra* lies in quietening the mind while lying still. "*Yoga nidra* is a very deep meditative experience," she says. NSDR deliberately sheds much of that context. And Huberman has his reasons for adopting a different approach. Speaking in a live Q&A in Australia's ICC Sydney Theatre in 2024, he explained that he chose the moniker not to take the practice away from *yoga nidra*, but because unfamiliar names can deter people from trying something when they come across as esoteric.

> While NSDR and *yoga nidra* have several similarities, the main difference is in the intended outcome

This approach makes sense in a culture where *yoga nidra* might come across as spiritual, foreign or vaguely intimidating. Non-Sleep Deep Rest, on the other hand, tells you exactly what is being offered and asks for no prior relationship with yoga. The repackaged approach has some influential takers, including Sundar Pichai. In 2022, the Google CEO told *The Wall Street Journal* that he found meditation difficult. What worked better for him was NSDR.

Bagrodia thinks the name itself has done a great deal of the work. "*Yoga nidra* sounds contemplative, whereas Non-Sleep Deep Rest sounds like neuroscience. It makes rest feel purposeful and productive. NSDR didn't invent the underlying practice. It gave an old practice a vocabulary that a performance-oriented culture was ready to accept."

Panjwani believes a lot of this is marketing. "The name change might lead one to believe that it has a scientific basis," she says. A simple meditation class may not draw people in, she argues, whereas modern wellness terminology can make essentially familiar practices feel more appealing.

WHAT THE SCIENCE SHOWS

A 2026 study, *Comparing the Effects of a Short Nap and Non-Sleep Deep Rest on Perceptual, Cognitive, and Physical Performance in Active Adults*, published in the peer-reviewed journal *Clocks & Sleep*, produced an interesting result. Researchers in Australia compared a 10-minute NSDR session with a 25-minute nap among physically active adults. NSDR did not significantly improve cognitive performance, while the nap produced stronger improvements in fatigue and higher readiness to perform.

"The evidence for performance is considerably thinner than the enthusiasm around it," says Bagrodia. "It may be a promising recovery tool, but is not yet an established cognitive enhancer." He is similarly cautious about what is happening during the practice. Breathing may slow, physiological arousal may fall, and studies of *yoga nidra* have reported changes in heart-rate variability and EEG (electroencephalography) reading, which measures electric activity in the brain. But there is no single brainwave pattern or HRV (Heart Rate Variability) number that indicates someone has entered an officially defined state called NSDR. "A changed brain state is not automatically a more enhanced brain state," he says. That is worth remembering when phrases such as "nervous-system reset" enter the conversation. "The nervous system is a dynamic regulatory system and not a computer you reboot in 10 minutes," says Bagrodia. A practice may help reduce physiological arousal, or the body's level of activation and alertness, describing that as a reset is not wholly accurate.

Perhaps the most successful thing about NSDR is not physiological at all. It's the fact that it has given rest another reason to exist. "We have turned productivity into a moral virtue," he adds. "'Lie down and do nothing' can sound lazy. 'Ten minutes of NSDR to improve recovery and cognition' sounds responsible." The difference, he says, is that *yoga nidra* asks you to stop working for self connection; while NSDR claims that stopping work will make you better at working. "We increasingly want a return on investment even from rest."

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Which exercises can you do in the gym every day?

Practice these exercises daily without worrying about overtraining

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It's common to find yourself wondering whether you can do bicep curls every day, or maybe practice pull-ups daily without thinking of overtraining. If you want to do certain exercises every day, make sure they improve foundational strength, posture and body control. They should also help develop your awareness which can guide you to do these workouts at different stages of your routine—either as warm up, during technique practice or while attempting progressive overload.

PUSH-UPS

Push-ups work differently for every body type and fitness level. It has several perks—the best exercise to experiment with; doesn't need any equipment; and can be done from anywhere. Doing push-ups everyday could be as simple as 10 reps. If you're a beginner opt for knee push-ups, and if you want to challenge yourself, use weights on your back. Keep in mind that it's not necessary to go until failure, just till your body feels warm or you feel like your form is breaking down.

DEAD HANGS

Grip a pull-up bar, and allow your body to hang below it with your feet above the floor. This trains the forearms, wrists, shoulders and the upper back. A great starter to help people support their body weight, it helps your hands get accustomed to holding a bar. The benefits don't stop there, dead hangs decompress the spine and loosen muscles. This is especially great for people who sit for long hours. Incorporate them at the start of your workout for smoother movement of muscles throughout.

> Foundational movements build technique and endurance for strenuous workouts

FACE PULLS

A rope attachment to a cable machine is all you need for this movement. Pull the rope towards your face with your elbows elevated, and return slowly to the original position. It trains the upper back muscles improving external rotation. The prerogative is slow, controlled movements and not the weight. It develops the upper back and keeps shoulder health in check. If you have a desk job, your shoulders will benefit from face pulls.

FARMER'S CARRIES

A fairly easy exercise, this involves holding a weight in each hand (this could be dumbbells, plates or even kettle bells) and walking a small distance with an upright posture. Multiple muscles including your forearms, shoulders and core are working hard here. However, the most important one being is your grip. All of these muscles are trained under movement, unlike most exercises where you are stationary. Therefore, farmers carries transfer skills to other areas of your body as well.

HONOURABLE MENTIONS

Consider these exercises as maintenance work for your body rather than workouts where you have to max out or hit a personal record. Some of these include YWTs, dead bugs, bird-dogs, kettlebell get-ups, and the world's greatest stretch. They are built on less joint stress and can be performed easily with less weights. They are great for your lower back and shoulder mobility.

Wellness retreats in India turn to companion animals

Wellness destinations go beyond traditional treatments to include companion animals for an enhanced experience

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Wellness retreats across the country have started to add spending time with farm animals to their guest experiences. Activities such as petting a cow, grooming a horse and walking a dog are showing up on itineraries at such properties.

There are various benefits to this kind of contact, doctors say. "For many people, animals provide a form of non-judgmental social interaction, which can reduce feelings of loneliness and make it easier to relax and engage. Petting, grooming, walking or simply being around an animal can shift attention away from repetitive thoughts and create a more present-focused experience," says Dr Mehezabin Dordi, Clinical Psychologist at Sir H.N. Reliance Foundation Hospital in Mumbai.

Dr Sayantini Mukherjee, Consultant Psychiatrist at Manipal Hospital in Pune, points to a physiological basis as well. "Interaction with animals, particularly when a person is comfortable and naturally inclined towards them, may influence neurochemical pathways involving oxytocin and serotonin, which are associated with positive mood and stress regulation. Such interactions may also help reduce the body's stress response, including sympathetic nervous system activity and cortisol levels."

I experienced this first-hand on a visit to Swastik Wellbeing Sanctuary, a 51-acre wellness retreat in Pune. I had kept a polite distance from anything on four legs after a dog bit me as a child. At Swastik, I tried to overcome this fear and discomfort by hand-feeding jaggery and *chana* balls to a cow the size of a large golden retriever. One nudged my hand impatiently when I stopped feeding it; another rubbed its head against my arm. I liked it more than I expected to. Strangely enough, it felt soothing.

But, this interaction doesn't amount to animal therapy which is a clinical term. "Animal-assisted therapy involves the deliberate incorporation of an animal into a structured therapeutic process, led by an appropriately qualified health professional, with defined therapeutic goals and monitoring," Dordi explains. If a resort offers cow petting or a horse walk as a relaxation activity, she says, that's wellness-promoting, not therapy. "The professional qualifications of the therapist, the training and suitability of the animal, therapeutic objectives, safety procedures and animal welfare all matter," she adds, distinguishing a genuine clinical intervention from a spa-menu add-on.

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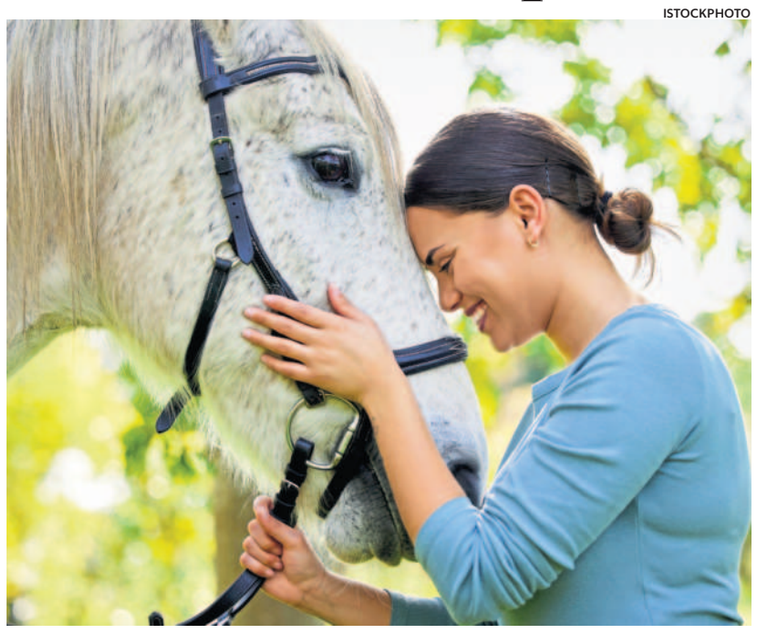

Incidentally, cow hugging emerged as a wellness trend reported a *BBC* story in 2020. With that in mind, here are four retreats currently building animal time into their guest experience. It's perfect for those who love four-legged creatures and others who might consider overcoming their fears of being around them.

SWASTIK WELLBEING SANCTUARY, PUNE

At this wellness retreat, guests feed and pet Punganur cows, a dwarf breed native to Andhra Pradesh. The ritual is deliberately left unstructured. "Guests are encouraged to approach the cows gently, feed, stroke, or simply sit beside them. The ritual offers an opportunity to pause, be present and connect through simple, gentle touch," says Dr Milind Salunkhe, Director of Seeker Experience and Wellness Outreach at Swastik. He sees it as especially useful for guests who struggle to switch off. "For people, particularly those who find it difficult to slow down or disconnect mentally, the experience can be very grounding." It sits alongside the property's meditation, sound healing, massage and physiotherapy programmes.

FAZLANI NATURES NEST, VADGAON

Fazlani sits on 68 acres of forest and farmland overlooking the Sahyadris, with ducks on the water and pheasants moving through the grounds. The property runs a stud farm with over 20 horses, used specifically for equine therapy alongside its naturopathy and Ayurveda programmes. Nobody rides on day one. Guests first spend time simply being around the horses—brushing their coats, filling a feed bucket, feeding or walking with them. Riding is introduced only once a guest is comfortable, and even then it's positioned less as sport and more as a way to quiet the mind. The equine therapy sessions are led by qualified facilitators.

KANASU WELLNESS, UDUPI, KARNATAKA

Set along the coastal forests of Udupi, this Ayurvedic wellness resort is built around wooden cottages, a herbal garden, fruit orchards and an in-house cold-pressed oil unit. At the heart of this resort is a *goshala* (cowshed), where guests can feed, brush or simply sit quietly with the cows. It's positioned as a grounding pause between the resort's other offerings which include Naturopathy, sound therapy, homa therapy, yoga, meditation, and pranic healing. The milk the cows produce also goes into the kitchen's therapeutic preparations. The *goshala* isn't purely experiential, it feeds directly into the property's treatment system.

KAMDHENU AROGYA WELLNESS SANSTHAN, NUH, HARYANA

This Ayurvedic and naturopathy centre, in the Aravalli belt near Gurugram, runs what it calls 'gau sparsh chikitsa,' or cow-touch therapy. It was founded by retired IAS officer and former Animal Welfare Board of India chairman Dr S.P. Gupta. Guests pet, massage and sit with the resident cows as part of the property's broader stress-management and de-addiction programmes. The idea, according to its founders, is that a cow's slower heartbeat and warmer body temperature have a steadying effect simply through proximity.